CHESS HANDOUTS

SERGEY V. POPOV

# ADVANCED

26 lessons · 156 puzzles from real Lichess games · Solutions on page 53

**Name:** _____ **Club / group:** _____

## Colour Key

**Basics**
How to think and use your clock

**Attack**
Sacrifices and attacks on the King

**Defence**
Stop their ideas; save bad positions

**Tactics**
Advanced combinations

**Strategy**
Pieces, pawns and long-term plans

**Endgame**
Exact technique with few pieces

**Openings**
Seven openings: ideas, not memory

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| 2 | Deflection | p. 3 · puzzles p. 4 | 15 | Pawn Majorities | p. 29 · puzzles p. 30 |
| 3 | Decoy | p. 5 · puzzles p. 6 | 16 | Converting an Advantage | p. 31 · puzzles p. 32 |
| 4 | Zwischenzug | p. 7 · puzzles p. 8 | 17 | Simplification | p. 33 · puzzles p. 34 |
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| 11 | Open & Closed Positions | p. 21 · puzzles p. 22 | 24 | Scandinavian Defence | p. 47 · puzzles p. 48 |
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Games from the Lichess open database (CC0). Chess pieces: Noto Sans Symbols 2 (SIL Open Font License).

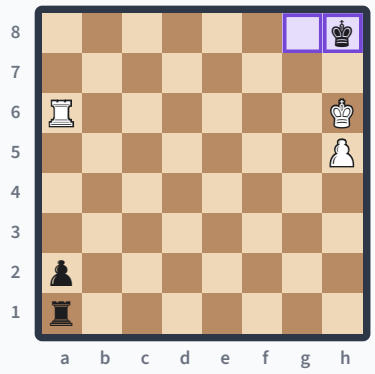
# CHECKS, CAPTURES, THREATS

CCT: a routine for finding good moves, plus how to use your clock

**Lesson 1 · Basics**
Level 3 Basics

## 1. Real Game: White to move

CCT FIRST

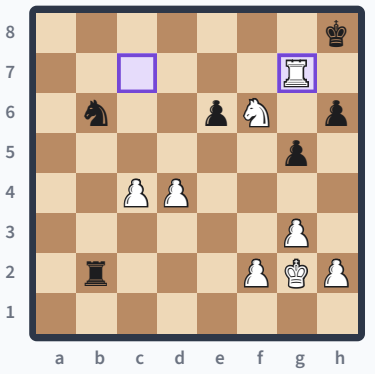


`Last move: 53...Kh8`

- What changed after **53...Kh8**? Then run CCT: checks first.
- Answer: **54.Ra8#**, mate follows.
- White (1903) v Black (1914) · 10+0 · lichess.org/J6SEql48

## 2. Real Game: Black to move

CCT FIRST

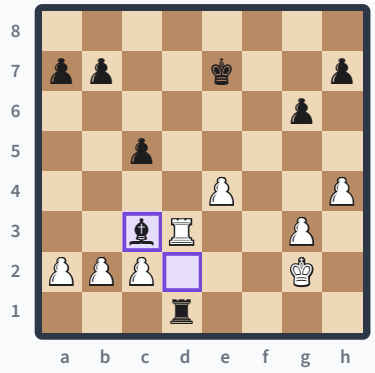


`Last move: 36.Rg7`

- List 2–3 candidate moves before calculating any of them.
- Answer: **36...Kxg7 37.Ne8+ Kf8**, wins 5 points.
- White (2071) v Black (2002) · 8+0 · lichess.org/JmLRln7J

## 3. Real Game: White to move

CCT FIRST

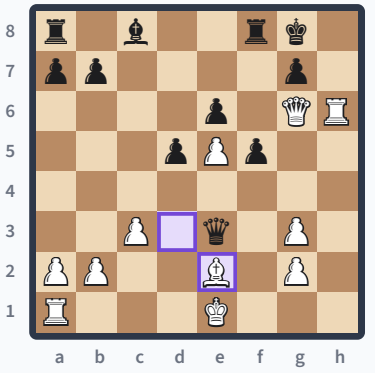


`Last move: 31...Bxc3`

- Calculate each candidate until the position is quiet.
- Answer: **32.Rxd1 Bxb2 33.Rd5**, wins 4 points.
- White (2207) v Black (1634) · 10+0 · lichess.org/xJDUaj1h

## 4. Real Game: Black to move

CCT FIRST



`Last move: 19.Be2`

- Before you touch a piece: what is their best reply?
- Answer: **19...Qxh6 20.Qxh6 gxh6**, wins 5 points.
- White (1983) v Black (2313) · 10+0 · lichess.org/FrYghAWU

## The Thinking Routine

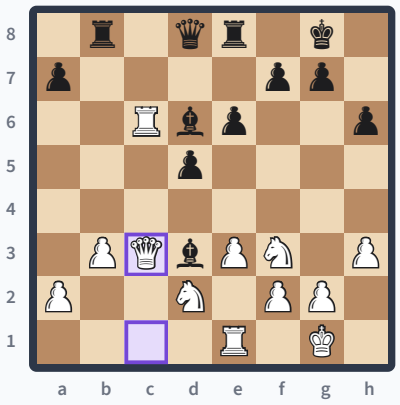
1. **What changed?** After every opponent move: what does it attack, and what did it stop guarding?
2. **CCT for both sides:** list every check, capture and threat. Then pick 2–3 candidate moves and calculate each until the position is quiet. Blunder-check the winner.
3. **Your clock:** think longest at critical moments (sacrifices, trades into an endgame, pawn moves you can't take back); play forced recaptures quickly; keep 5 minutes for the end.

# PUZZLES: CCT

Checks, captures, threats · six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 1 · Basics Puzzles**
Level 3 Basics

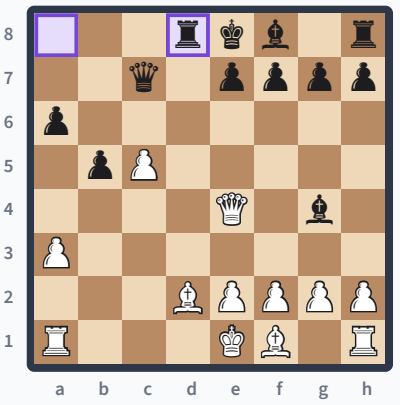
**1** **Black to move after 21.Qc3 (purple). What changed? Find the best move!**



White (1757) v Black (1709) · 14+0
lichess.org/d8qTwQrj

Answer:

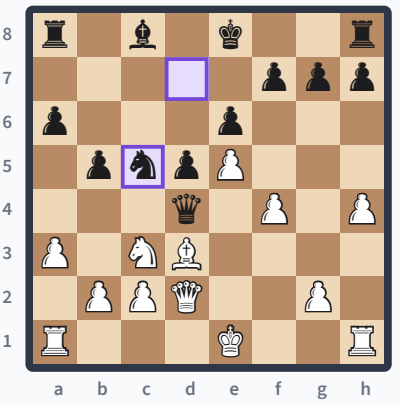
**2** **White to move after 14...Rd8 (purple). What changed? Find the best move!**



White (1879) v Black (1569) · 20+0
lichess.org/QuGLUpj8

Answer:

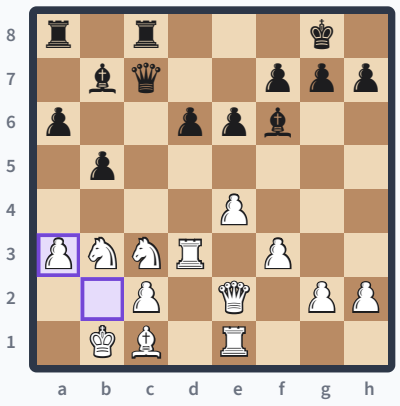
**3** **White to move after 14...Nc5 (purple). What changed? Find the best move!**



White (1824) v Black (1805) · 17+17
lichess.org/sonJbky4

Answer:

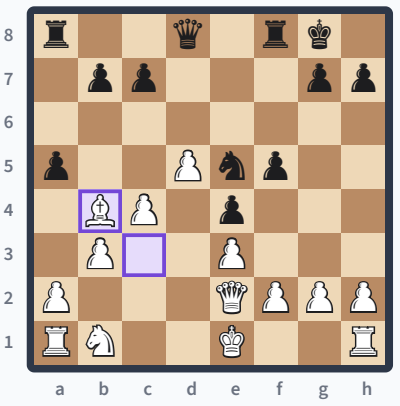
**4** **Black to move after 21.bxa3 (purple). What changed? Find the best move!**



White (1517) v Black (2061) · 10+0
lichess.org/wYE5TUoj

Answer:

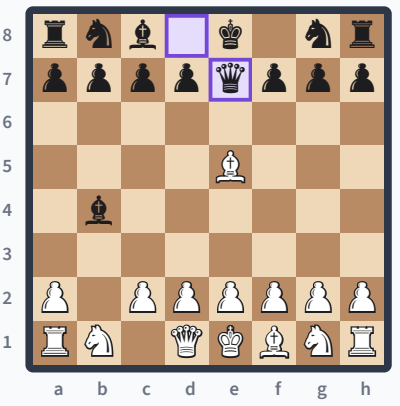
**5** **Black to move after 17.Bxb4 (purple). What changed? Find the best move!**



White (1855) v Black (1823) · 10+0
lichess.org/Dc7XtZxI

Answer:

**6** **White to move after 3...Qe7 (purple). What changed? Find the best move!**



White (1588) v Black (1996) · 10+0
lichess.org/5Gim4qaj

Answer:

**Tip:** what changed? Then checks, captures, threats for both sides, and a blunder check before you move.

**Score: ____ / 6**

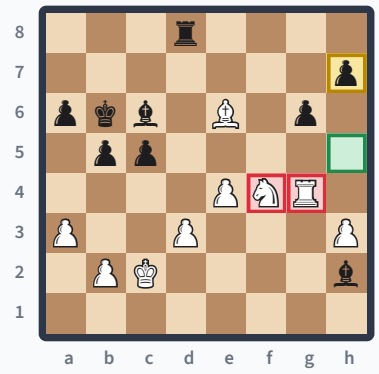
# DEFLECTION

Drag a defender away from its job



## 1. Real Game: 32...h5!

DRAG IT AWAY

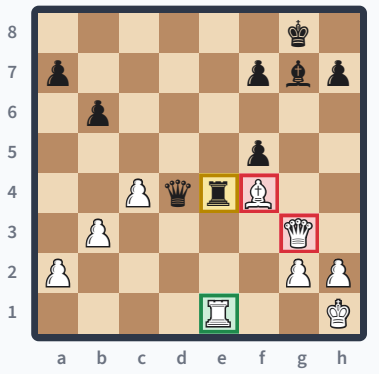


```
32...h5 33.Rxg6 Bxf4
```

- The Rook on **g4** guards **f4**.
- **32...h5** forces it to move: after **33.Rxg6**, **33...Bxf4** takes the Knight on f4.
- White (1804) v Black (1895) · 10+0 · lichess.org/KJst3X08

## 2. Real Game: 29...Rxe1+!

DRAG IT AWAY

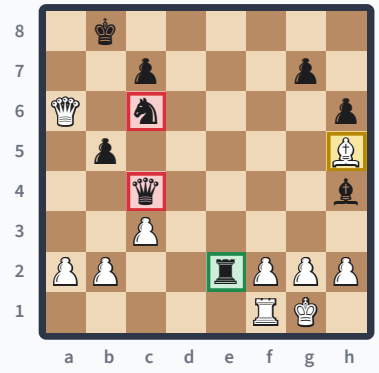


```
29...Rxe1+ 30.Qxe1 Qxf4
```

- The Queen on **g3** guards **f4**.
- **29...Rxe1+** forces it to move: after **30.Qxe1**, **30...Qxf4** takes the Bishop on f4.
- White (1689) v Black (1668) · 10+0 · lichess.org/arxFjJVN

## 3. Real Game: 28.Bxe2!

DRAG IT AWAY

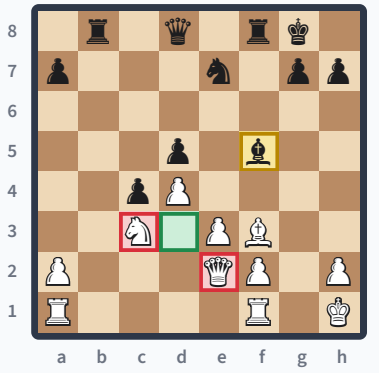


```
28.Bxe2 Qxe2 29.Qxc6
```

- The Queen on **c4** guards **c6**.
- **28.Bxe2** forces it to move: after **28...Qxe2**, **29.Qxc6** takes the Knight on c6.
- White (1903) v Black (1864) · 5+5 · lichess.org/rxATqebJ

## 4. Real Game: 19...Bd3!

DRAG IT AWAY



```
19...Bd3 20.Na4 Bxe2
```

- The Knight on **c3** guards **e2**.
- **19...Bd3** forces it to move: after **20.Na4**, **20...Bxe2** takes the Queen on e2.
- White (2291) v Black (2290) · 7+7 · lichess.org/njN5niah

## How to Spot a Deflection

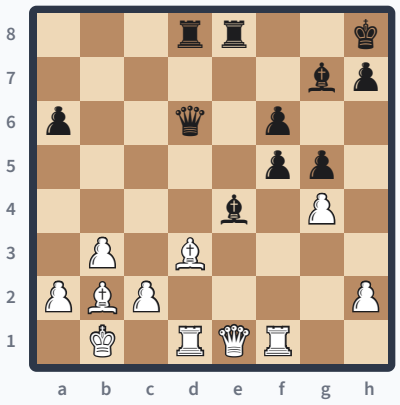
1. Find a defender with an **important job**: guarding the back rank, a piece, or a mating square.
2. Attack it, or offer it something to take, so it must **leave its post**.
3. Then strike at what it used to guard. Overloaded pieces (two jobs at once) are the easiest targets.

# PUZZLES: DEFLECTION

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 2 · Tactics Puzzles**
Level 3 Tactics

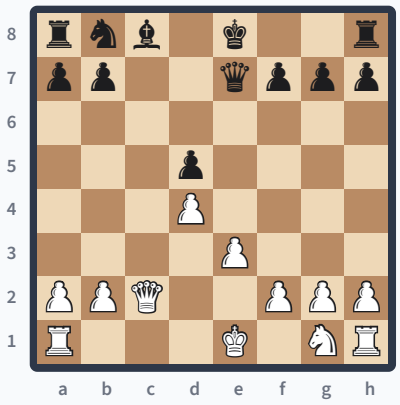
**1** **Black to move. Drag a defender away!**



White (1935) v Black (1924) · 9+8
lichess.org/16g3zRMn

Answer:

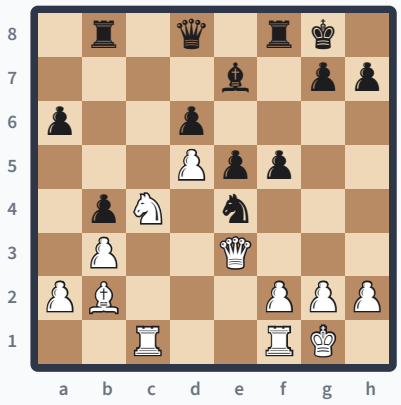
**2** **White to move. Drag a defender away!**



White (1654) v Black (1918) · 10+0
lichess.org/M06MUxbj

Answer:

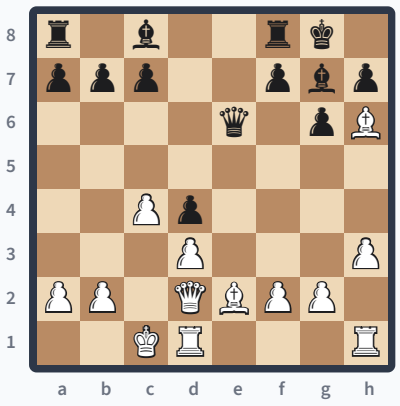
**3** **Black to move. Drag a defender away!**



White (1554) v Black (1456) · 11+0
lichess.org/wUgHZqsI

Answer:

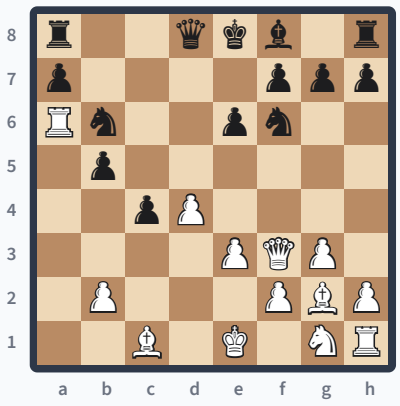
**4** **Black to move. Drag a defender away!**



White (1571) v Black (1554) · 5+10
lichess.org/dKGq55SS

Answer:

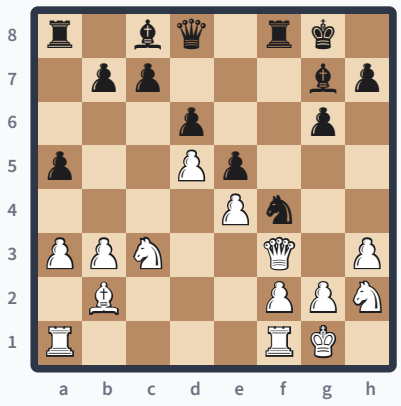
**5** **White to move. Drag a defender away!**



White (1845) v Black (1746) · 10+0
lichess.org/Ma3dsmYw

Answer:

**6** **Black to move. Drag a defender away!**



White (1728) v Black (1853) · 15+2
lichess.org/twxWSnW7

Answer:

**Tip:** look at every forcing move: checks, captures, and sacrifices that make a threat.

**Score: ____ / 6**

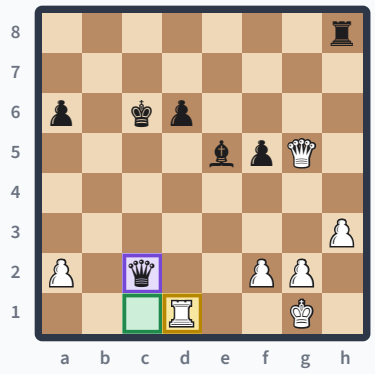
# DECOY

Lure a piece onto a bad square

**Lesson 3 · Tactics**
Level 3 Tactics

## 1. Real Game: 45.Rc1!

LURE THE QUEEN

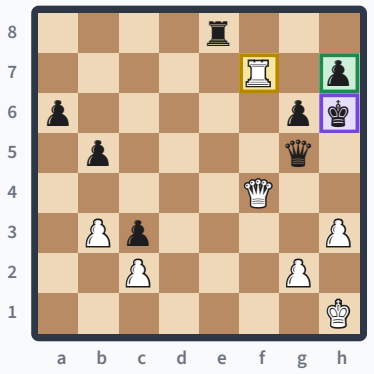


```
45.Rc1 Qxc1+ 46.Qxc1+
```

- **45.Rc1** lures the Queen to **c1** with **45...Qxc1+**.
- Now **46.Qxc1+** takes the Queen on c1 with check, wins 4 points.
- White (1634) v Black (1841) · 10+0 · lichess.org/ayZB9uNd

## 2. Real Game: 35.Rxh7+!

LURE THE KING

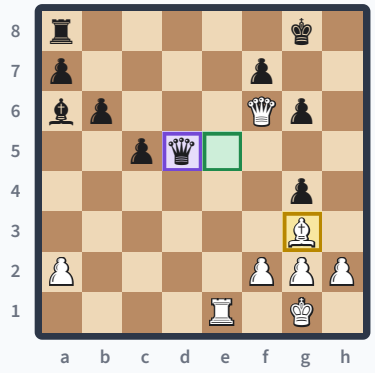


```
35.Rxh7+ Kxh7 36.Qxg5
```

- **35.Rxh7+** lures the King to **h7** with **35...Kxh7**.
- Now **36.Qxg5** takes the Queen on g5, wins 5 points.
- White (2031) v Black (2026) · 9+2 · lichess.org/1kxjgTPE

## 3. Real Game: 28.Be5!

LURE THE QUEEN

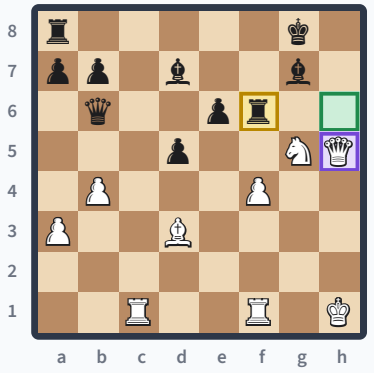


```
28.Be5 Qxe5 29.Qxe5
```

- **28.Be5** lures the Queen to **e5** with **28...Qxe5**.
- Now **29.Qxe5** takes the Queen on e5, wins 6 points.
- White (1632) v Black (1692) · 10+0 · lichess.org/1W7FWOD1

## 4. Real Game: 30...Rh6!

LURE THE QUEEN



```
30...Rh6 31.Qxh6 Bxh6
```

- **30...Rh6** lures the Queen to **h6** with **31.Qxh6**.
- Now **31...Bxh6** takes the Queen on h6, wins 4 points.
- White (1788) v Black (1740) · 15+0 · lichess.org/mJEfuyvG

### Decoy vs. Deflection

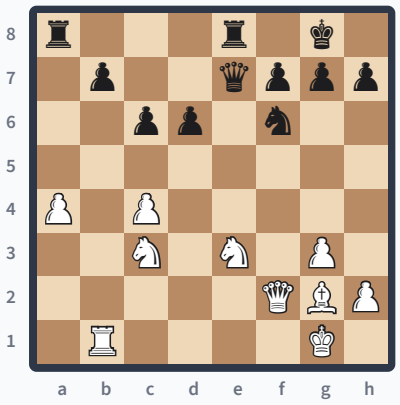
1. **Deflection** pulls a defender **away** from a square. **Decoy** pulls a piece **onto** a square.
2. Typical decoy squares: where the King or Queen can be **forked, skewered or mated**.
3. The bait is usually a sacrifice with check or a capture they can't refuse.

# PUZZLES: DECOY

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 3 · Tactics Puzzles**
Level 3 Tactics

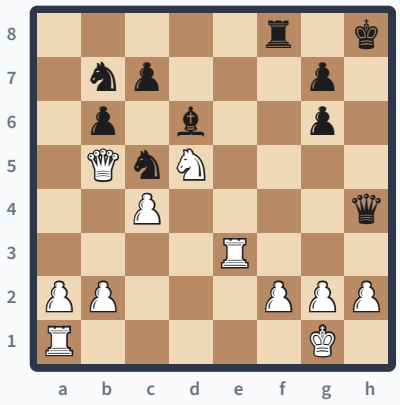
**1** **Black to move. Lure a piece onto a bad square!**



White (1703) v Black (1735) · 10+0
lichess.org/NDVz7YU4

Answer:

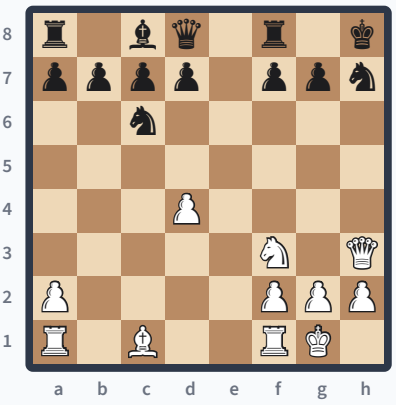
**2** **White to move. Lure a piece onto a bad square!**



White (2213) v Black (1900) · 10+0
lichess.org/MjUb9jcO

Answer:

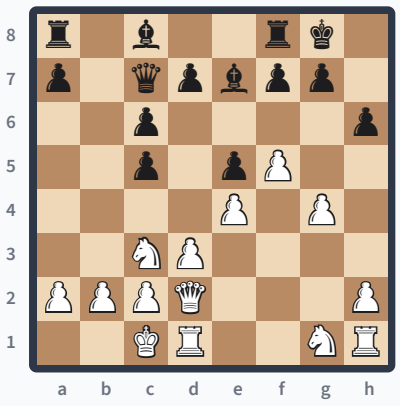
**3** **White to move. Lure a piece onto a bad square!**



White (1891) v Black (1910) · 9+8
lichess.org/Hp5D7fHr

Answer:

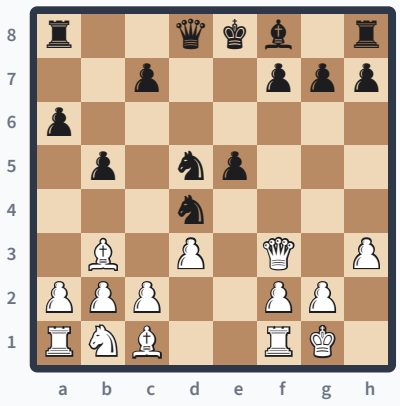
**4** **Black to move. Lure a piece onto a bad square!**



White (1538) v Black (1534) · 9+1
lichess.org/9Z1f8nax

Answer:

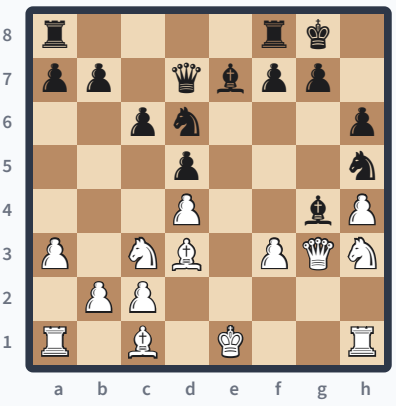
**5** **White to move. Lure a piece onto a bad square!**



White (1900) v Black (1647) · 10+15
lichess.org/3DpN699D

Answer:

**6** **White to move. Lure a piece onto a bad square!**



White (1869) v Black (1960) · 10+15
lichess.org/U5SiENhh

Answer:

**Tip:** look at every forcing move: checks, captures, and sacrifices that make a threat.

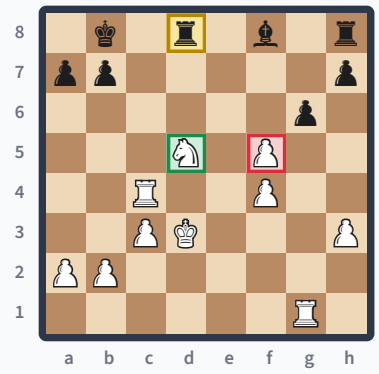
**Score: ____ / 6**

# ZWISCHENZUG

The in-between move: don't recapture on autopilot

**Lesson 4 · Tactics**
Level 3 Tactics

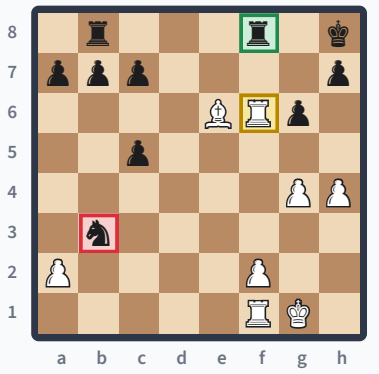
## 1. Real Game: 23...Rxd5+! NOT THE RECAPTURE



`23...Rxd5+ 24.Rd4 Rxf5`

- Your opponent just captured on **f5**. The natural move is to take back.
- Better: **23...Rxd5+** first! The recapture on f5 can wait, wins 4 points.
- White (1917) v Black (2121) · 10+0 · lichess.org/zIH1rtXE

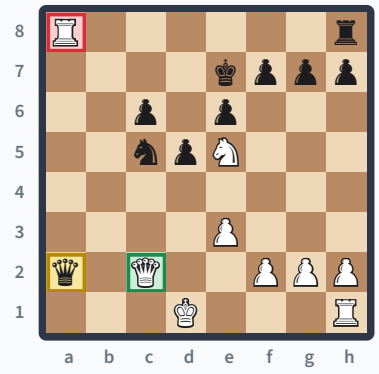
## 2. Real Game: 27.Rxf8+! NOT THE RECAPTURE



`27.Rxf8+ Rxf8 28.axb3`

- Your opponent just captured on **b3**. The natural move is to take back.
- Better: **27.Rxf8+** first! The recapture on b3 can wait, wins 3 points.
- White (1899) v Black (1776) · 10+0 · lichess.org/evNdFSN9

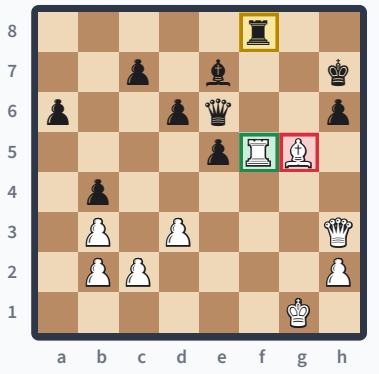
## 3. Real Game: 21...Qxc2+! NOT THE RECAPTURE



`21...Qxc2+ 22.Kxc2 Rxa8`

- Your opponent just captured on **a8**. The natural move is to take back.
- Better: **21...Qxc2+** first! The recapture on a8 can wait, wins 4 points.
- White (1613) v Black (1520) · 10+0 · lichess.org/rorqJ7ny

## 4. Real Game: 30...Rxf5! NOT THE RECAPTURE



`30...Rxf5 31.Bxe7 Rg5+`

- Your opponent just captured on **g5**. The natural move is to take back.
- Better: **30...Rxf5** first! The recapture on g5 can wait, wins 2 points.
- White (1540) v Black (1703) · 15+8 · lichess.org/0P5u9iGd

### Before You Recapture, Ask:

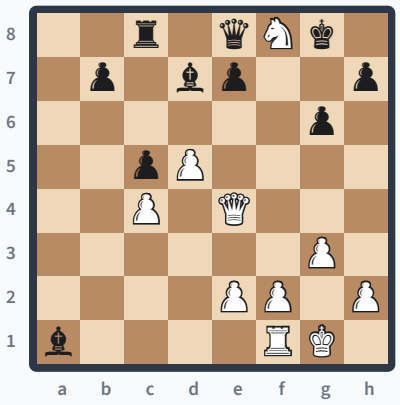
1. Do I have a **check**, a **capture** or a bigger **threat** first?
2. Will the piece I want to take back **still be there** after my in-between move?
3. Watch out for your opponent's zwischenzug too: after you capture, they may not recapture at once.

# PUZZLES: ZWISCHENZUG

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 4 · Tactics Puzzles**
Level 3 Tactics

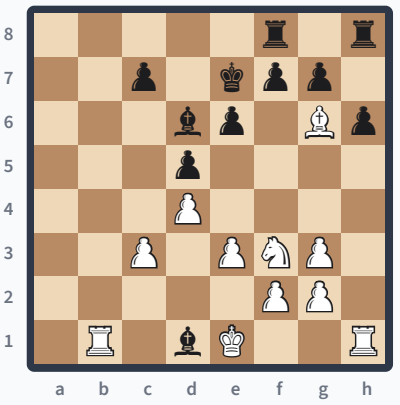
**1** **White to move. Don't take back yet: find the in-between move!**



White (1918) v Black (1904) · 15+15
lichess.org/5y4SI10i

Answer:

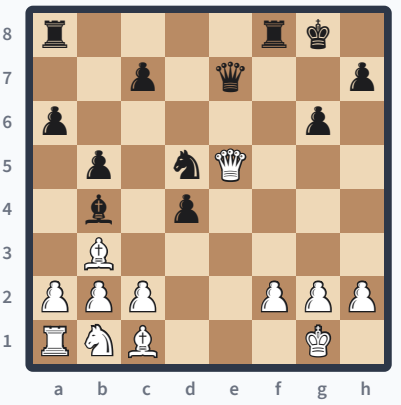
**2** **Black to move. Don't take back yet: find the in-between move!**



White (1813) v Black (1683) · 8+2
lichess.org/L57eq2T3

Answer:

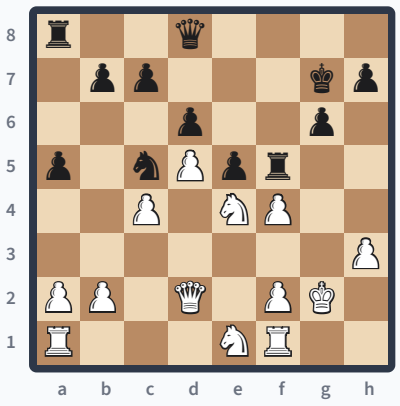
**3** **White to move. Don't take back yet: find the in-between move!**



White (1979) v Black (1826) · 9+10
lichess.org/qeNryRmX

Answer:

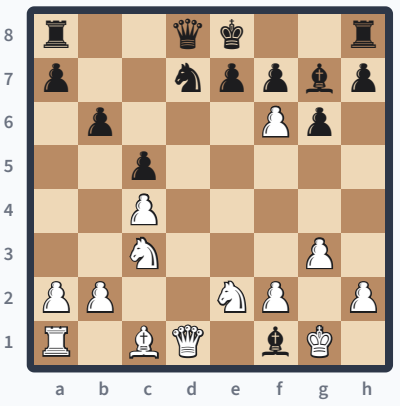
**4** **Black to move. Don't take back yet: find the in-between move!**



White (2085) v Black (2097) · 45+45
lichess.org/jQgvdXzZ

Answer:

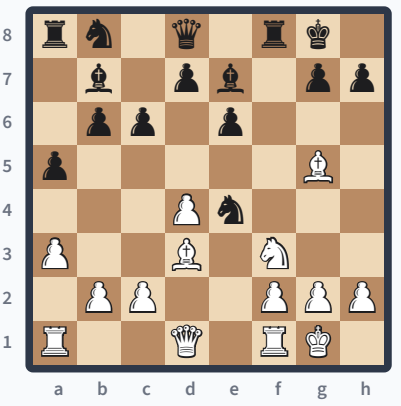
**5** **White to move. Don't take back yet: find the in-between move!**



White (2015) v Black (1876) · 10+0
lichess.org/GbWyAZdj

Answer:

**6** **White to move. Don't take back yet: find the in-between move!**



White (1850) v Black (1923) · 8+0
lichess.org/lLIjkHVR

Answer:

**Tip:** look at every forcing move: checks, captures, and sacrifices that make a threat.

**Score: ____ / 6**

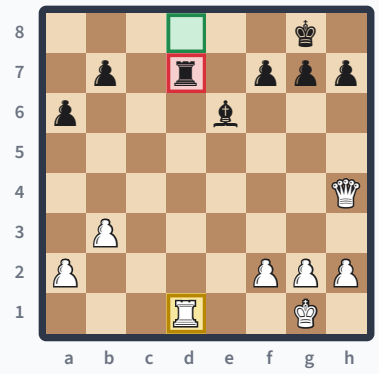
# X-RAY

Seeing through an enemy piece

**Lesson 5 · Tactics**
Level 3 Tactics

## 1. Textbook: 1.Qd8+!

X-RAY DEFENCE

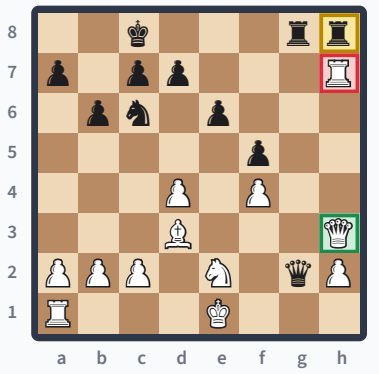


`1.Qd8+ Rxd8 2.Rxd8#`

- Black's Rook on **d7** seems to guard d8, but White's Rook on **d1** sees **through** it.
- **1.Qd8+!** If **1...Rxd8**, the Rook leaves the d-file and **2.Rxd8#** is mate.

## 2. Real Game: 18...Qxh3!

SEE THROUGH IT

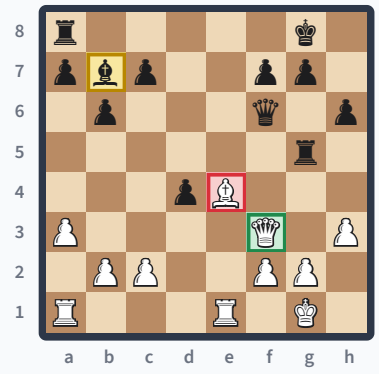


`18...Qxh3 19.Rxh3 Rxh3`

- The Rook on **h8** sees through the enemy Rook on **h7** to **h3**.
- **18...Qxh3**! If the Rook takes back on h3, it leaves the line and the Rook takes on h3, wins 5 points.
- White (1846) v Black (1622) · 10+0 · lichess.org/PAoHx2p8

## 3. Real Game: 21...Qxf3!

SEE THROUGH IT

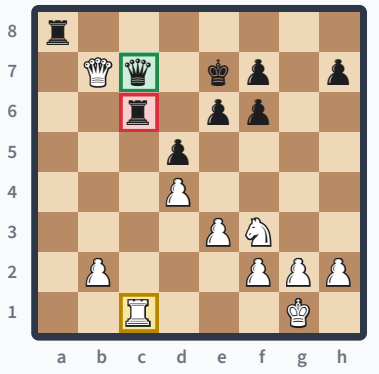


`21...Qxf3 22.Bxf3 Bxf3`

- The Bishop on **b7** sees through the enemy Bishop on **e4** to **f3**.
- **21...Qxf3**! If the Bishop takes back on f3, it leaves the line and the Bishop takes on f3, wins 3 points.
- White (1651) v Black (1684) · 10+0 · lichess.org/0CCos4zy

## 4. Real Game: 22.Qxc7+!

SEE THROUGH IT



`22.Qxc7+ Rxc7 23.Rxc7+`

- The Rook on **c1** sees through the enemy Rook on **c6** to **c7**.
- **22.Qxc7+**! If the Rook takes back on c7, it leaves the line and the Rook takes on c7, wins 5 points.
- White (1543) v Black (1550) · 10+0 · lichess.org/LuFQVm1z

## X-ray or Skewer?

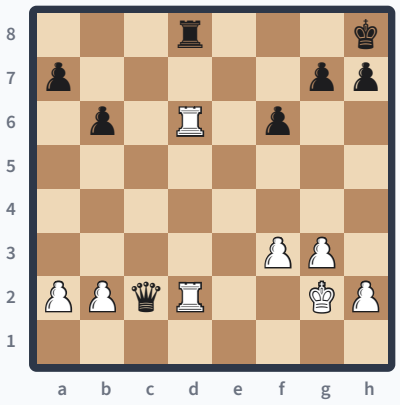
1. **Skewer:** you **attack** a valuable piece. It has to move, and you take the piece behind it.
2. **X-ray:** your piece **guards or attacks a square through an enemy piece**. When that enemy piece captures on the square, it leaves the line, and your piece behind takes back.
3. Before you count attackers and defenders, look **behind** every piece on the line: yours and theirs.

# PUZZLES: X-RAY

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 5 · Tactics Puzzles**
Level 3 Tactics

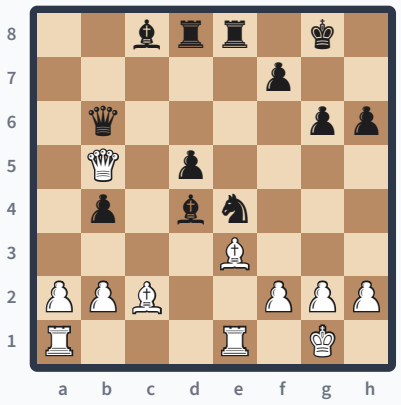
**1** **Black to move. Look through the pieces: find the X-ray!**



White (1927) v Black (1718) · 10+0
lichess.org/YoyvBr0u

Answer:

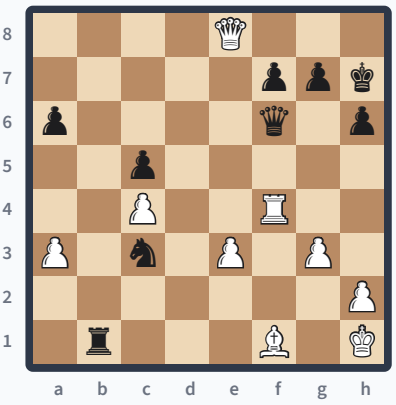
**2** **White to move. Look through the pieces: find the X-ray!**



White (1541) v Black (1548) · 5+8
lichess.org/LDwSfCg6

Answer:

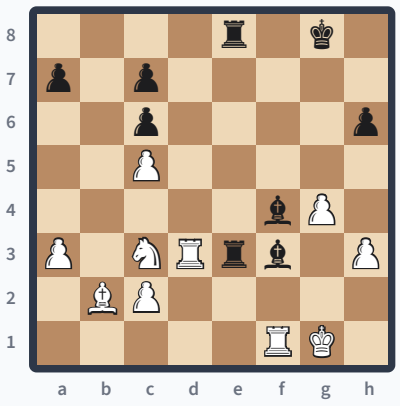
**3** **Black to move. Look through the pieces: find the X-ray!**



White (2161) v Black (2077) · 10+5
lichess.org/GjmgnTPq

Answer:

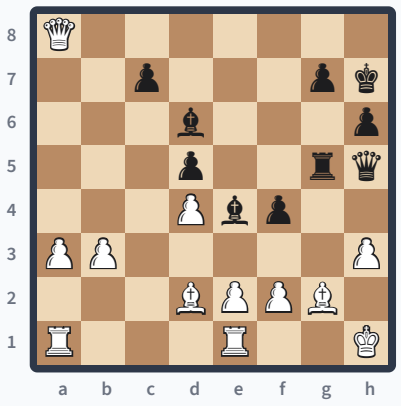
**4** **White to move. Look through the pieces: find the X-ray!**



White (1524) v Black (1741) · 10+0
lichess.org/R6jQ8CRr

Answer:

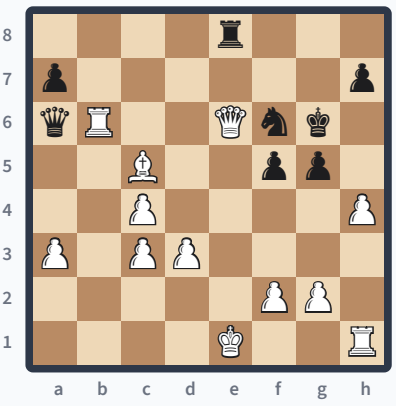
**5** **White to move. Look through the pieces: find the X-ray!**



White (2153) v Black (1555) · 10+0
lichess.org/7Jks81of

Answer:

**6** **Black to move. Look through the pieces: find the X-ray!**



White (1200) v Black (1200) · 12+0
lichess.org/3plm7jy4

Answer:

**Tip:** look at every forcing move: checks, captures, and sacrifices that make a threat.

**Score: ____ / 6**

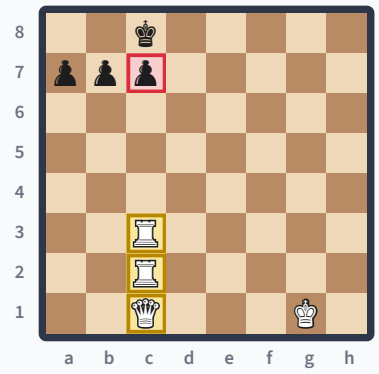
# BATTERIES & ALEKHINE'S GUN

Line up your pieces for double power

**Lesson 6 · Tactics**
Level 3 Tactics

## 1. Alekhine's Gun

R + R + Q

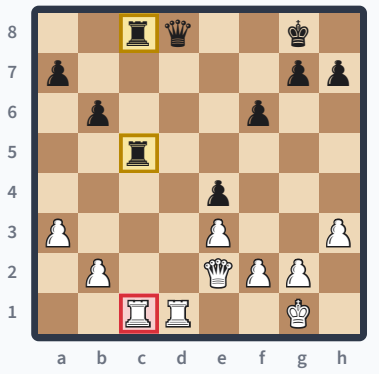


`Rooks in front, Queen behind`

- Two Rooks lined up with the **Queen behind them**: the strongest battery of all.
- It piles pressure on one square (here c7) until the defence breaks.

## 2. Real Game: 20...Rxc1!

ROOK + ROOK

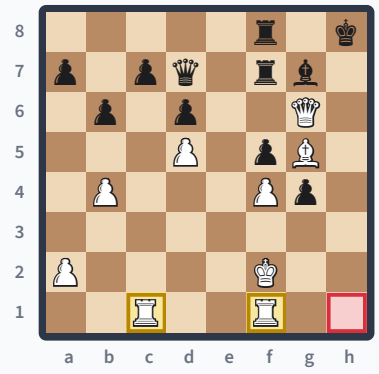


`20...Rxc1 21.Re1 Qd3`

- The Rook on **c8** backs up the Rook on **c5**: a battery on the file.
- **20...Rxc1** takes the Rook on c1, with the Rook behind it, wins 5 points.
- White (1561) v Black (1852) · 10+0 · lichess.org/WYTDnso9

## 3. Real Game: 30.Rh1+!

ROOK + ROOK

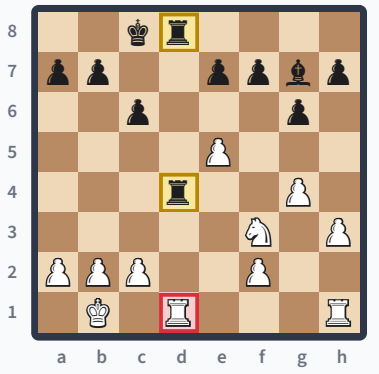


`30.Rh1+ Bh6 31.Qxh6+`

- The Rook on **c1** backs up the Rook on **f1**: a battery on the rank.
- **30.Rh1+** gives check, with the Rook behind it, mate follows.
- White (1631) v Black (1627) · 10+0 · lichess.org/F0ZcOPPk

## 4. Real Game: 22...Rxd1+!

ROOK + ROOK



`22...Rxd1+ 23.Rxd1 Rxd1#`

- The Rook on **d8** backs up the Rook on **d4**: a battery on the file.
- **22...Rxd1+** takes the Rook on d1 with check, with the Rook behind it, mate follows.
- White (1353) v Black (1661) · 10+0 · lichess.org/T7coOpIf

## Building a Battery

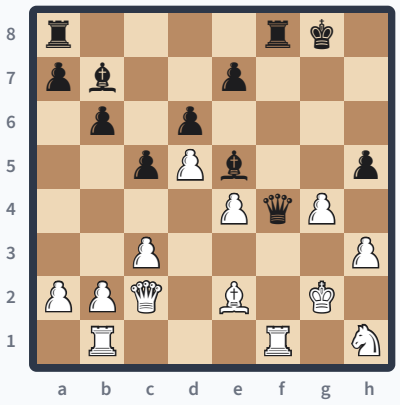
1. **Queen + Bishop** on a diagonal: the classic mating battery against h7 or h2.
2. **Queen + Rook** or **two Rooks** on a file: control it, then invade.
3. **Alekhine's Gun:** two Rooks in front and the Queen behind. The front piece strikes; the one behind makes the capture safe.

# PUZZLES: BATTERIES

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 6 · Tactics Puzzles**
Level 3 Tactics

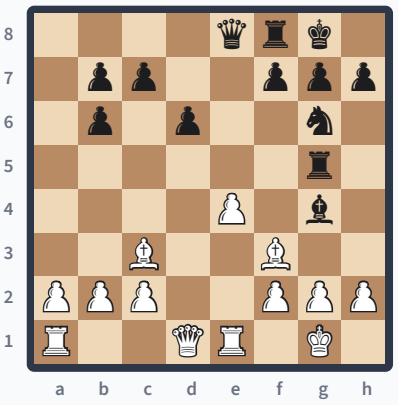
**1** **Black to move. Use your battery!**



White (1582) v Black (1773) · 20+10
lichess.org/pe8wu9Ud

Answer:

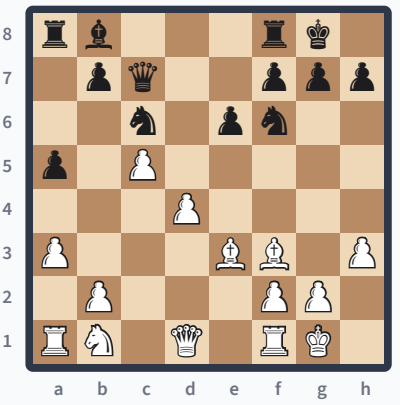
**2** **White to move. Use your battery!**



White (1806) v Black (1736) · 8+0
lichess.org/qLPltX2M

Answer:

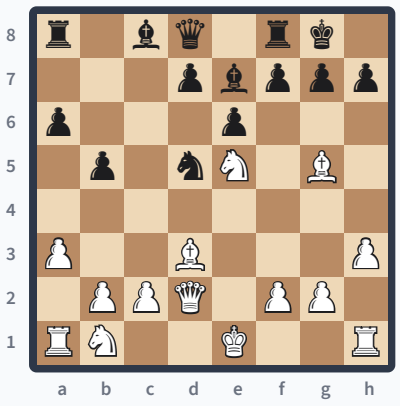
**3** **Black to move. Use your battery!**



White (1547) v Black (1491) · 10+0
lichess.org/EHODQ73d

Answer:

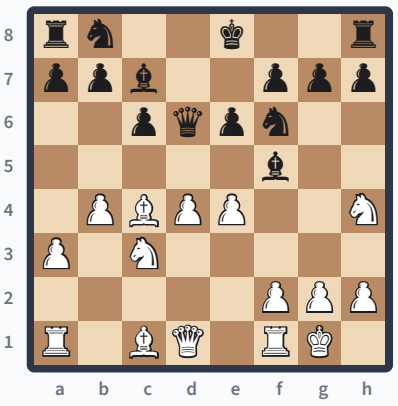
**4** **Black to move. Use your battery!**



White (1507) v Black (1735) · 10+15
lichess.org/fgjRZQCJ

Answer:

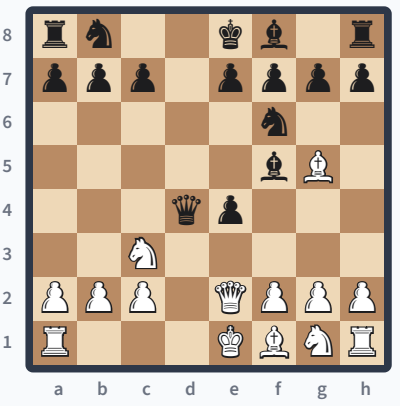
**5** **Black to move. Use your battery!**



White (1658) v Black (1663) · 10+0
lichess.org/cioc0wSl

Answer:

**6** **White to move. Use your battery!**



White (1952) v Black (1946) · 10+0
lichess.org/4gg2x3d9

Answer:

**Tip:** look at every forcing move: checks, captures, and sacrifices that make a threat.

**Score: ____ / 6**

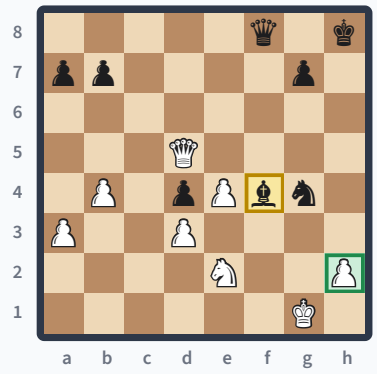
# THE GREEK GIFT

Bxh7+: the classic Bishop sacrifice

**Lesson 7 · Attack**
Level 3 Attack

## 1. Real Game: 33...Bxh2+!

BISHOP TAKES, WITH CHECK

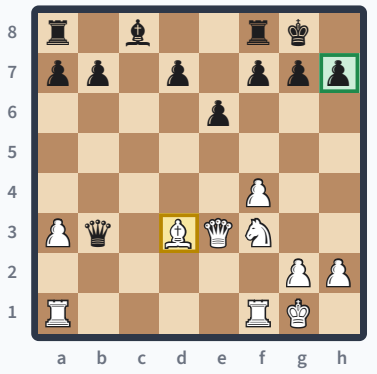


```
33...Bxh2+ 34.Kg2 Ne3+
```

- **33...Bxh2+**: the Bishop takes the pawn in front of the King, with check.
- Line: **33...Bxh2+ 34.Kg2 Ne3+ 35.Kxh2**, mate follows.
- White (1954) v Black (2082) · 12+0 · lichess.org/AlsPBB7X

## 2. Real Game: 17.Bxh7+!

BISHOP TAKES, WITH CHECK

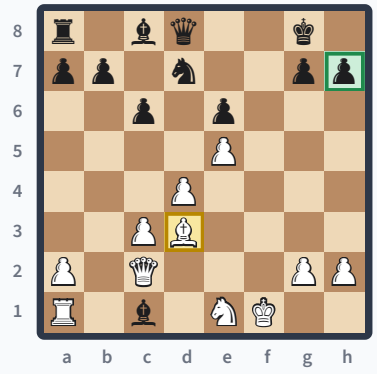


```
17.Bxh7+ Kxh7 18.Ng5+
```

- **17.Bxh7+**: the Bishop takes the pawn in front of the King, with check.
- Line: **17.Bxh7+ Kxh7 18.Ng5+ Kg8**.
- White (2033) v Black (1256) · 10+0 · lichess.org/5JCjRFRS

## 3. Real Game: 17.Bxh7+!

BISHOP TAKES, WITH CHECK

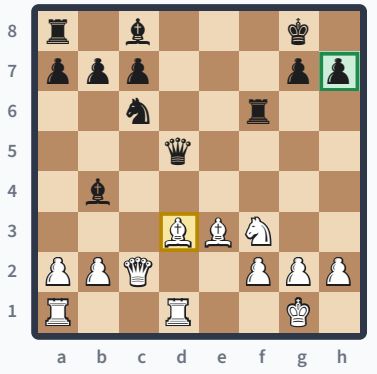


```
17.Bxh7+ Kh8 18.Rxc1
```

- **17.Bxh7+**: the Bishop takes the pawn in front of the King, with check.
- Line: **17.Bxh7+ Kh8 18.Rxc1 Nf8**, wins 4 points.
- White (1487) v Black (1542) · 5+5 · lichess.org/Rsd6bzFM

## 4. Real Game: 14.Bxh7+!

BISHOP TAKES, WITH CHECK



```
14.Bxh7+ Kh8 15.Rxd5
```

- **14.Bxh7+**: the Bishop takes the pawn in front of the King, with check.
- Line: **14.Bxh7+ Kh8 15.Rxd5 Bg4**, wins 10 points.
- White (1441) v Black (1331) · 15+15 · lichess.org/HKaACDz5

### Greek Gift Checklist

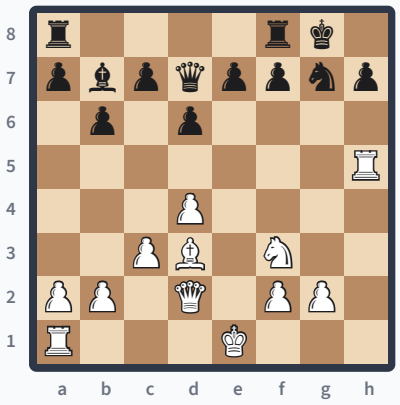
1. **Bishop** aims at h7 (or h2), and h7 is only guarded by the King.
2. Your **Knight** can jump to g5 (or g4) with check, and your **Queen** can reach h5 (or h4).
3. No enemy Knight on f6 and no piece that can quickly defend h7. Check all three, then sacrifice!

# PUZZLES: GREEK GIFT

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 7 · Attack Puzzles**
Level 3 Attack

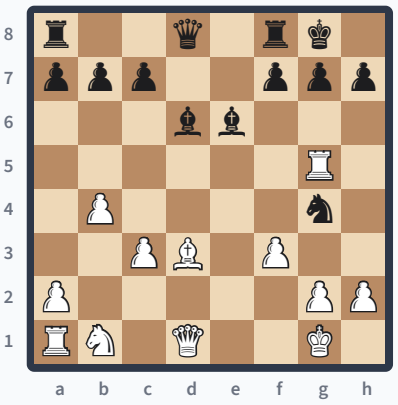
**1** **White to move. Is the Greek Gift on?**



White (1382) v Black (1242) · 10+0
lichess.org/CwsDtOhD

Answer:

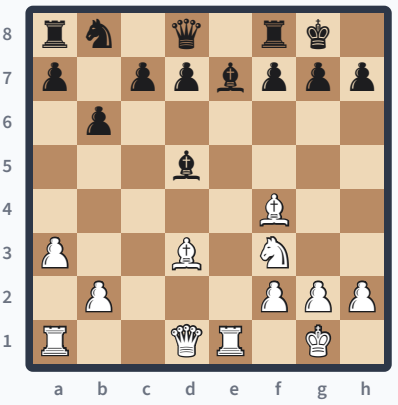
**2** **Black to move. Is the Greek Gift on?**



White (1557) v Black (1496) · 10+0
lichess.org/iAYf1BKl

Answer:

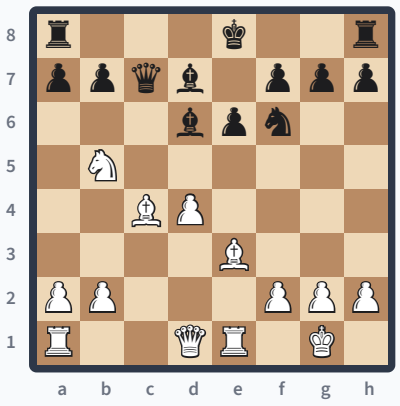
**3** **White to move. Is the Greek Gift on?**



White (1573) v Black (1566) · 10+0
lichess.org/COzIyGeD

Answer:

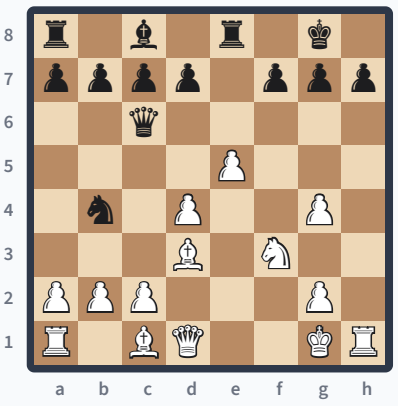
**4** **Black to move. Is the Greek Gift on?**



White (1895) v Black (1919) · 8+0
lichess.org/tOFtHZPS

Answer:

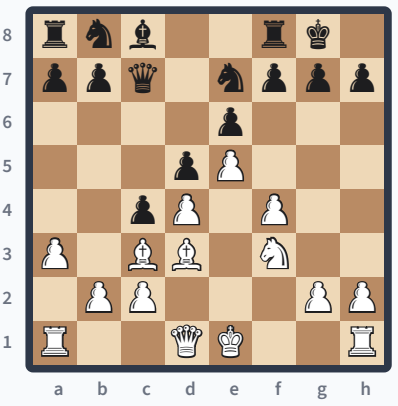
**5** **White to move. Is the Greek Gift on?**



White (1284) v Black (1436) · 15+0
lichess.org/NhTgFLTz

Answer:

**6** **White to move. Is the Greek Gift on?**



White (1963) v Black (1866) · 5+5
lichess.org/iHHKUba1

Answer:

**Tip:** count the attackers near the enemy King against the defenders. More attackers? Go for it!

**Score: ____ / 6**

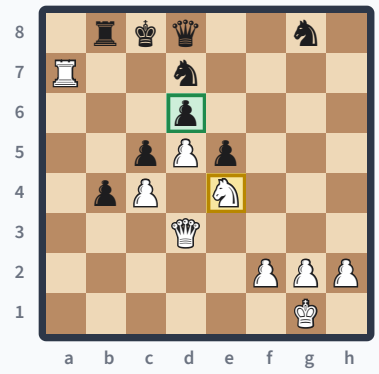
# OPPOSITE-SIDE CASTLING

Kings on different wings: it's a race

**Lesson 8 · Attack**
Level 3 Attack

## 1. Real Game: 30.Nxd6#!

RACE TO ATTACK

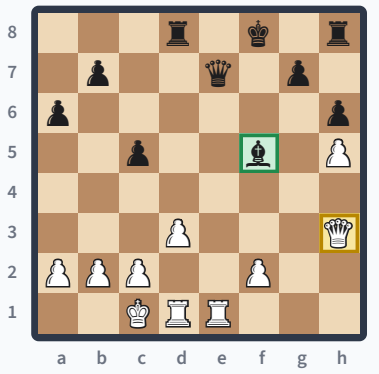


```
30.Nxd6#
```

- The Kings are castled on opposite wings, so it is a race to attack.
- **30.Nxd6#** strikes near the enemy King, mate follows.
- White (1337) v Black (1484) · 8+5 · lichess.org/f1rivmvc

## 2. Real Game: 27.Qxf5+!

RACE TO ATTACK

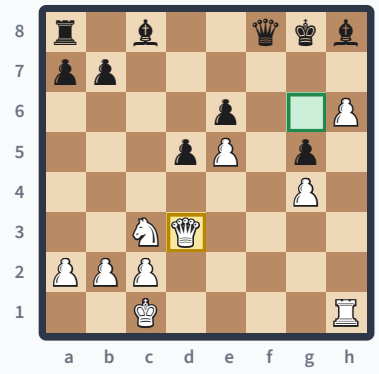


```
27.Qxf5+ Qf6 28.Qxc5+
```

- The Kings are castled on opposite wings, so it is a race to attack.
- **27.Qxf5+** strikes near the enemy King, wins 4 points.
- White (1664) v Black (1568) · 5+8 · lichess.org/JOnxnmo6

## 3. Real Game: 23.Qg6+!

RACE TO ATTACK

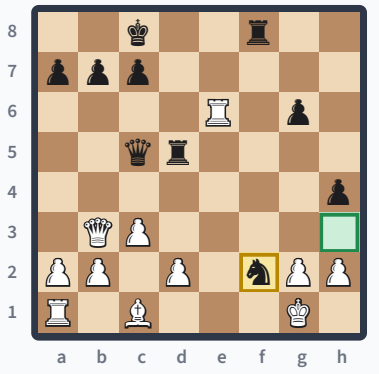


```
23.Qg6+ Bg7 24.Nxd5
```

- The Kings are castled on opposite wings, so it is a race to attack.
- **23.Qg6+** strikes near the enemy King, keeping the attack going.
- White (1500) v Black (1404) · 5+8 · lichess.org/JSYfuYiL

## 4. Real Game: 22...Nh3+!

RACE TO ATTACK



```
22...Nh3+ 23.Kh1 Rf1#
```

- The Kings are castled on opposite wings, so it is a race to attack.
- **22...Nh3+** strikes near the enemy King, mate follows.
- White (1362) v Black (1650) · 15+0 · lichess.org/RWzHix4u

### Racing Rules

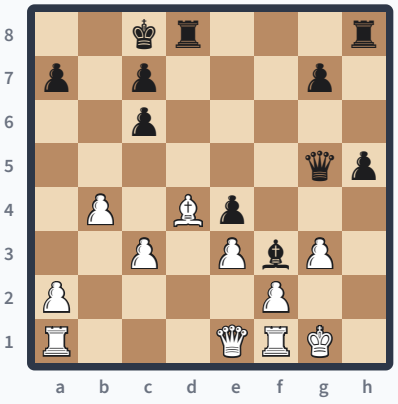
1. **Speed beats material:** a pawn storm is fine even if it costs a pawn.
2. Push the pawns in front of the **enemy** King; don't touch the ones in front of yours.
3. Open files towards their King for your Rooks and Queen. Count: whose attack arrives first?

# PUZZLES: OPPOSITE-SIDE CASTLING

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 8 · Attack Puzzles**
Level 3 Attack

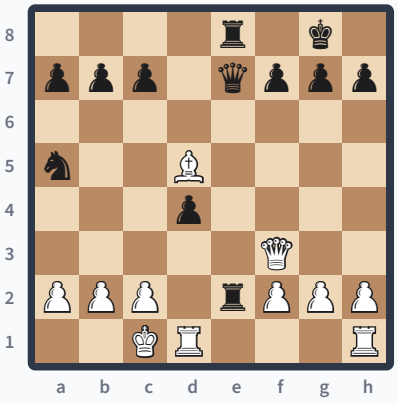
**1** **Black to move. Kings on opposite wings: attack!**



White (1689) v Black (1578) · 7+5
lichess.org/j7VHtgWQ

Answer:

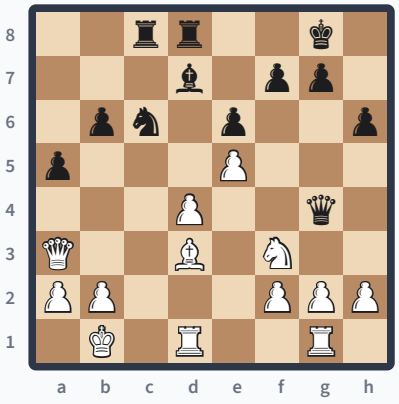
**2** **Black to move. Kings on opposite wings: attack!**



White (1637) v Black (1707) · 10+0
lichess.org/h3JwL5jE

Answer:

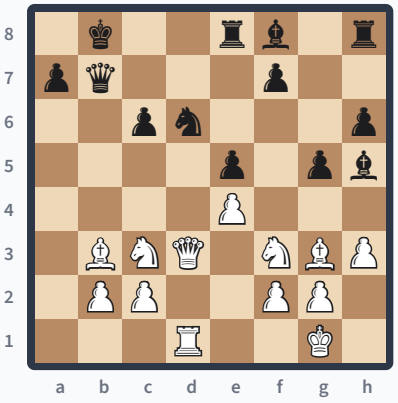
**3** **White to move. Kings on opposite wings: attack!**



White (2263) v Black (2006) · 10+0
lichess.org/h8sFveY6

Answer:

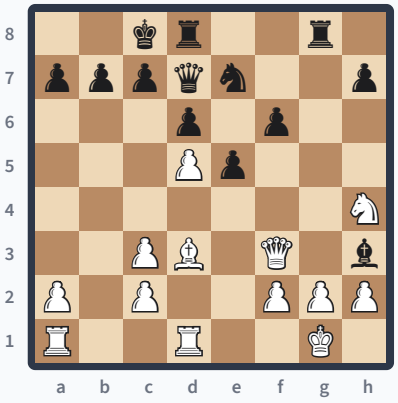
**4** **Black to move. Kings on opposite wings: attack!**



White (1909) v Black (1887) · 10+8
lichess.org/gQ5c7uFl

Answer:

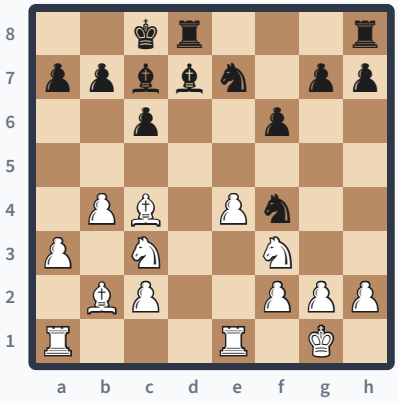
**5** **Black to move. Kings on opposite wings: attack!**



White (1828) v Black (1801) · 10+0
lichess.org/qsuJFyCt

Answer:

**6** **White to move. Kings on opposite wings: attack!**



White (1546) v Black (1532) · 25+0
lichess.org/cqsUd7ne

Answer:

**Tip:** count the attackers near the enemy King against the defenders. More attackers? Go for it!

**Score: ____ / 6**

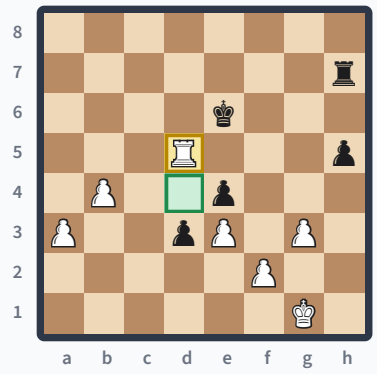
# PROPHYLAXIS

Stop your opponent's idea before it happens

**Lesson 9 · Defence**
Level 3 Defence

## 1. Real Game: 40.Rd4!

STOP THEIR IDEA

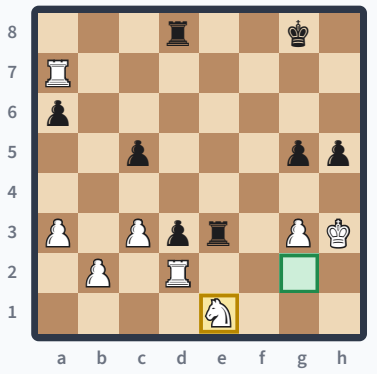


`40.Rd4 Kf5 41.b5`

- Your opponent wants to play **Kxd5 (winning the Rook)**.
- **40.Rd4** stops it before it happens, and White stays on top.
- White (1590) v Black (1499) · 8+0 · lichess.org/44pMM3cU

## 2. Real Game: 40.Ng2!

STOP THEIR IDEA

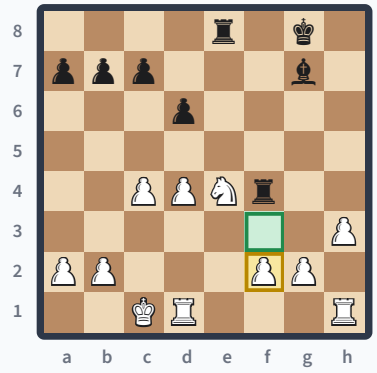


`40.Ng2 Rf3 41.Re7`

- Your opponent wants to play **Rxe1 (winning the Knight)**.
- **40.Ng2** stops it before it happens, and White stays on top.
- White (1919) v Black (1640) · 10+0 · lichess.org/82SyDDyE

## 3. Real Game: 24.f3!

STOP THEIR IDEA

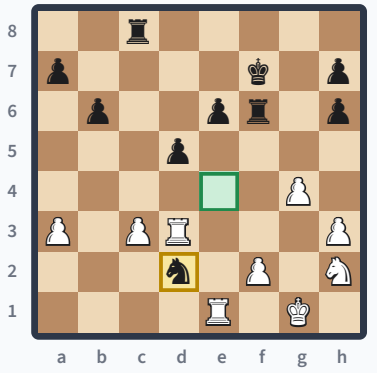


`24.f3 c5 25.Rhe1`

- Your opponent wants to play **Rexe4 (winning the Knight)**.
- **24.f3** stops it before it happens, and White stays on top.
- White (1520) v Black (1521) · 15+5 · lichess.org/TDvZiP6g

## 4. Real Game: 30...Ne4!

STOP THEIR IDEA



`30...Ne4 31.Nf3 Ke7`

- Your opponent wants to play **Rxd2 (winning the Knight)**.
- **30...Ne4** stops it before it happens, and Black stays on top.
- White (2006) v Black (1757) · 10+0 · lichess.org/iPirZ2te

## Thinking Prophylactically

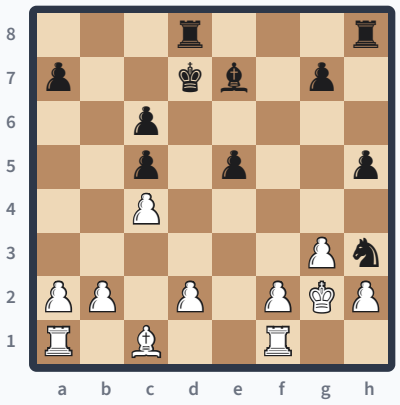
1. Ask: **"If it were my opponent's move, what would they play?"**
2. If their idea is dangerous, **stop it first**, even with a quiet move.
3. Quiet moves like a King step, a pawn move or a Rook lift often win more than an early attack.

# PUZZLES: PROPHYLAXIS

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 9 · Defence Puzzles**
Level 3 Defence

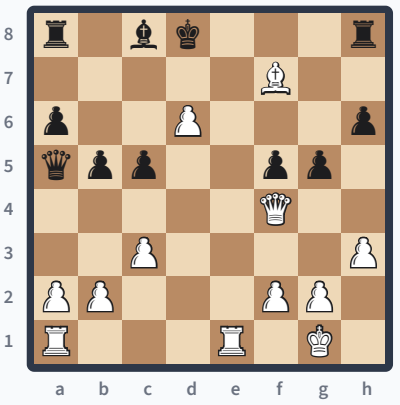
**1** **Black to move. What does your opponent want? Stop it first!**



White (1364) v Black (1327) · 15+15
lichess.org/IfwmhlVo

Answer:

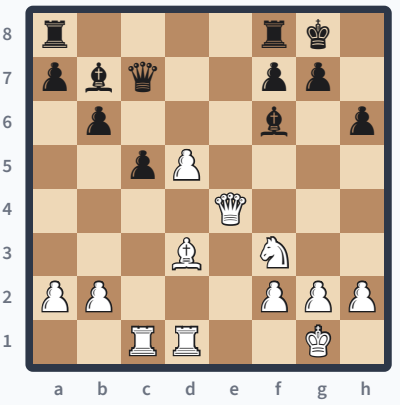
**2** **White to move. What does your opponent want? Stop it first!**



White (1634) v Black (1641) · 5+7
lichess.org/c5j0J10c

Answer:

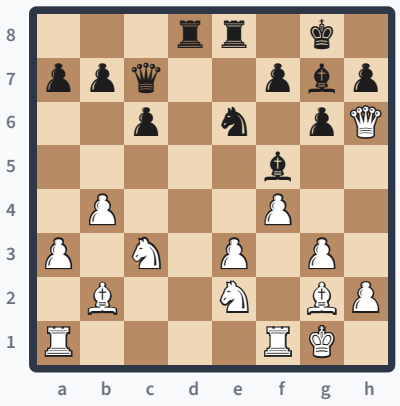
**3** **Black to move. What does your opponent want? Stop it first!**



White (2194) v Black (2240) · 10+0
lichess.org/pN0ioHNr

Answer:

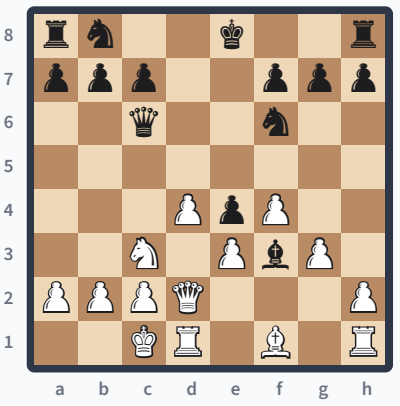
**4** **White to move. What does your opponent want? Stop it first!**



White (1479) v Black (1427) · 10+0
lichess.org/cska7GZG

Answer:

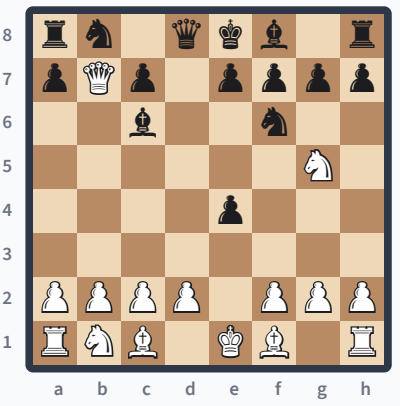
**5** **White to move. What does your opponent want? Stop it first!**



White (1384) v Black (1498) · 9+2
lichess.org/S9R1YUeM

Answer:

**6** **White to move. What does your opponent want? Stop it first!**



White (1875) v Black (2042) · 10+5
lichess.org/RPP0aiwY

Answer:

**Tip:** first ask what your opponent wants. Then find the move that stops it.

**Score: ____ / 6**

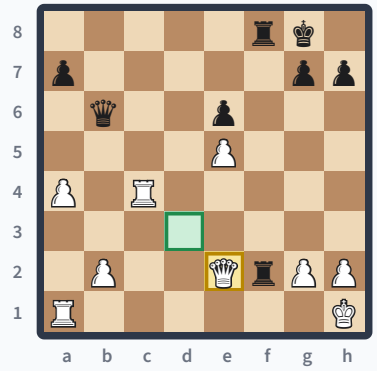
# DEFENDING WORSE POSITIONS

When you're worse, find the move that hangs on

**Lesson 10 · Defence**
Level 3 Defence

## 1. Real Game: 28.Qd3!

ONLY MOVE

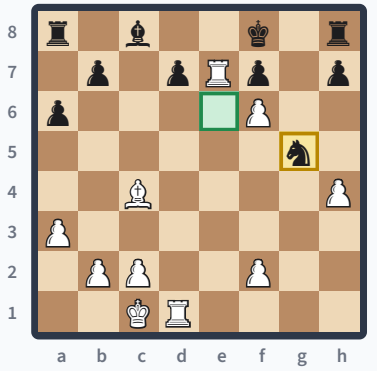


```
28.Qd3 Rxg2 29.b4
```

- White is worse here. Only one move holds.
- **28.Qd3**! Every other move loses much more.
- White (2008) v Black (2135) · 15+0 · lichess.org/8c3usY4b

## 2. Real Game: 22...Ne6!

ONLY MOVE

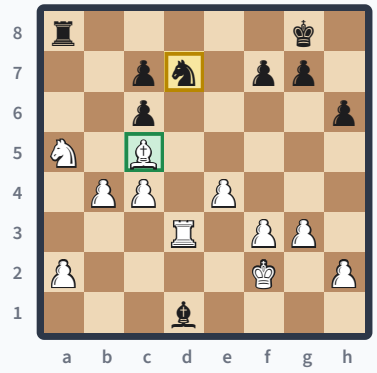


```
22...Ne6 23.f4 Nxf4
```

- Black is worse here. Only one move holds.
- **22...Ne6**! Every other move loses much more.
- White (1600) v Black (1432) · 10+0 · lichess.org/Jj6QlqD1

## 3. Real Game: 29...Nxc5!

ONLY MOVE

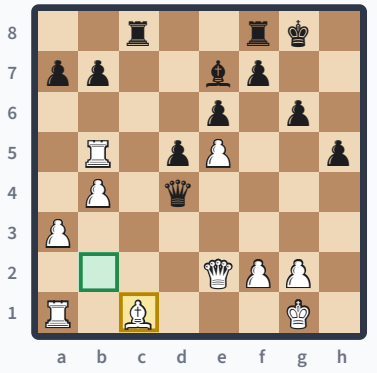


```
29...Nxc5 30.Rxd1 Ne6
```

- Black is worse here. Only one move holds.
- **29...Nxc5**! Every other move loses much more.
- White (1914) v Black (1897) · 10+0 · lichess.org/1ae3VI3t

## 4. Real Game: 23.Bb2!

ONLY MOVE



```
23.Bb2 Qf4 24.Rxb7
```

- White is worse here. Only one move holds.
- **23.Bb2**! Every other move loses much more.
- White (2166) v Black (2318) · 8+0 · lichess.org/wW08ojaV

## How to Defend

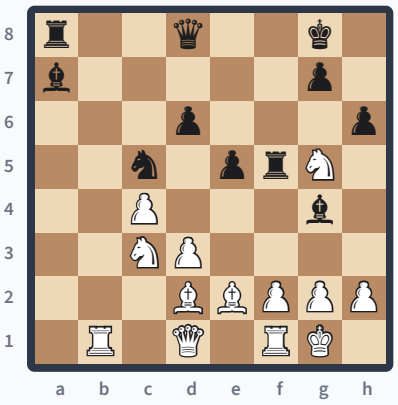
1. Look for **forcing** defensive moves first: checks, captures, and moves that trade the attacker's best piece.
2. Giving material back is fine if it kills the attack.
3. Keep your pieces near your King, stay calm, and make your opponent prove it. Many games are saved!

# PUZZLES: DEFENDING

Worse positions · six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 10 · Defence Puzzles**
Level 3 Defence

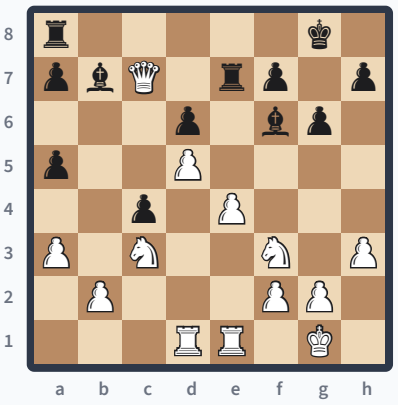
**1** **Black to move. You're worse: find the only defence!**



White (1480) v Black (1491) · 10+0
lichess.org/Ev8ZgWIx

Answer:

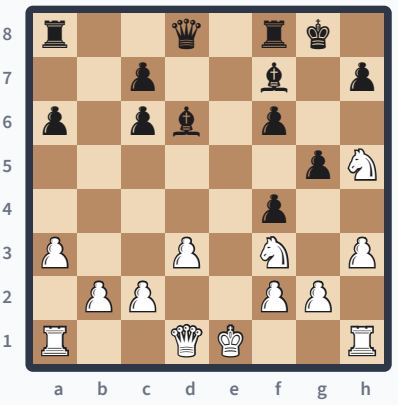
**2** **Black to move. You're worse: find the only defence!**



White (2067) v Black (2040) · 15+15
lichess.org/G6NlAmv6

Answer:

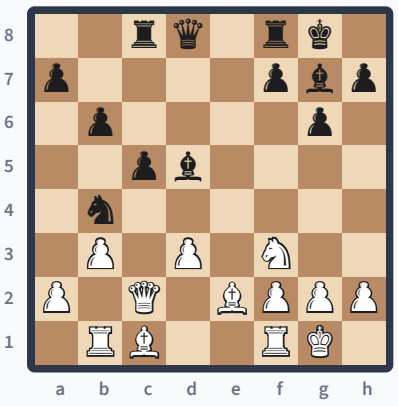
**3** **White to move. You're worse: find the only defence!**



White (1507) v Black (1576) · 10+0
lichess.org/Mu8Nvs6Z

Answer:

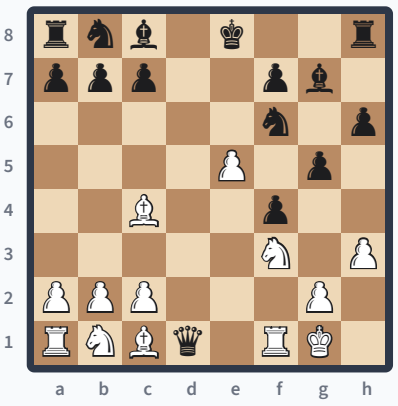
**4** **White to move. You're worse: find the only defence!**



White (1902) v Black (2176) · 10+5
lichess.org/Jhwx6Lqj

Answer:

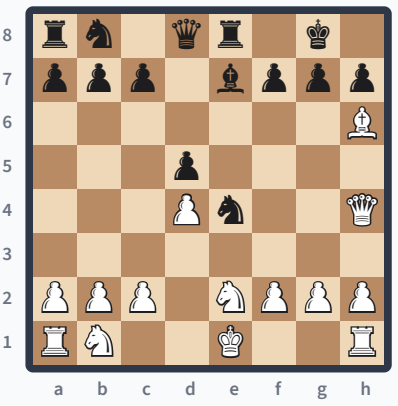
**5** **White to move. You're worse: find the only defence!**



White (1621) v Black (1659) · 5+8
lichess.org/xY6Pm79H

Answer:

**6** **White to move. You're worse: find the only defence!**



White (1363) v Black (1623) · 15+7
lichess.org/EYWHfTh2

Answer:

**Tip:** first ask what your opponent wants. Then find the move that stops it.

**Score: ____ / 6**

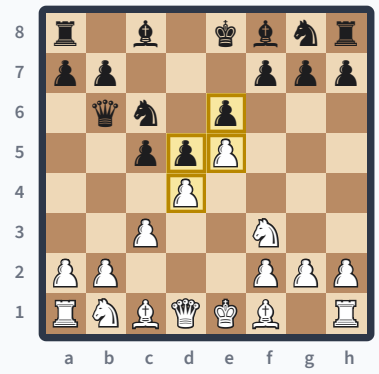
# OPEN & CLOSED POSITIONS

Know your position, then choose your pieces

**Lesson 11 · Strategy**
Level 3 Strategy

## 1. A Closed Centre

KNIGHTS LIKE IT

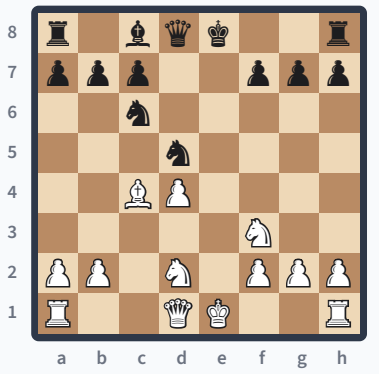


`French Advance: d4/d5 and e5/e6 locked`

- The centre pawns are **locked**. Long diagonals are blocked.
- Knights can jump over pawns, so they love closed positions.

## 2. An Open Centre

BISHOPS LIKE IT

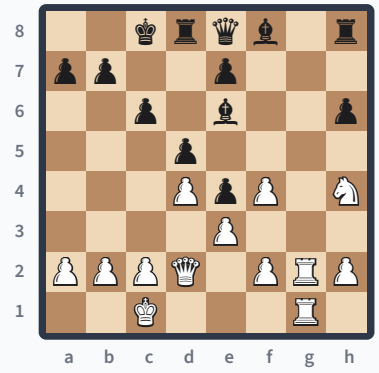


`Italian: the centre pawns have been traded`

- Few centre pawns and open lines: **Bishops and Rooks** rule.
- Two Bishops together are very strong in open positions.

## 3. Real Game: Closed

LOCKED CENTRE

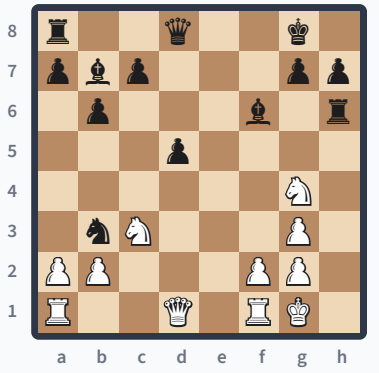


`Locked pawns: e3/e4, d4/d5`

- The pawns lock the centre, so long-range pieces struggle. Knights hop over them.
- Plan: play on the wings with pawn breaks.
- White (1521) v Black (1892) · 10+0 · lichess.org/OCVDIC6i

## 4. Real Game: Open

OPEN CENTRE



`Only 3 centre pawns left`

- Open lines everywhere: Bishops, Rooks and Queens are strongest.
- Plan: open files and diagonals towards the enemy King.
- White (1966) v Black (2056) · 8+0 · lichess.org/7irMQrjg

### Change the Position to Suit Your Pieces

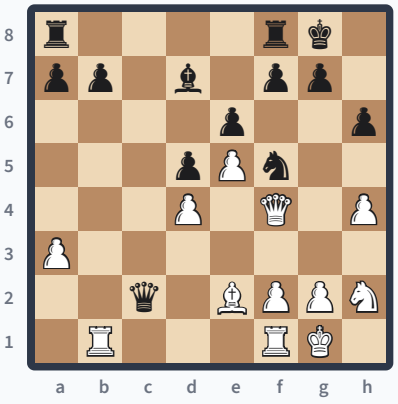
1. Have the **Bishops**? Open the position with pawn breaks and exchanges of centre pawns.
2. Have the **Knights**? Keep the centre closed and find outposts.
3. **Rooks** need just one open file. In closed positions, prepare a pawn break to open one.

# PUZZLES: OPEN & CLOSED POSITIONS

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 11 · Strategy Puzzles**
Level 3 Strategy

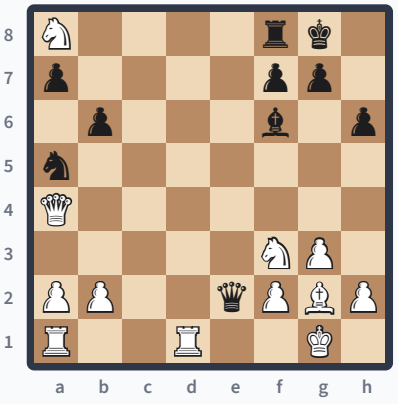
**1** **Is the centre open or closed? Which minor piece would you rather have?**



White (1789) v Black (1899) · 10+0
lichess.org/SqRBTbsG

Answer:

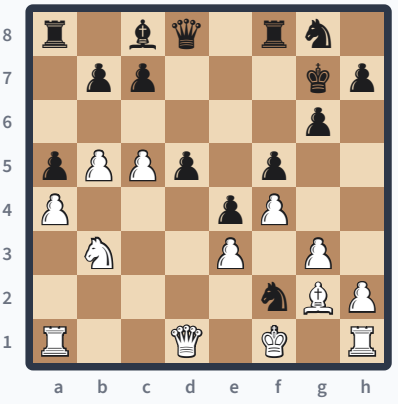
**2** **Is the centre open or closed? Which minor piece would you rather have?**



White (2094) v Black (2416) · 8+0
lichess.org/IhBXD4Zz

Answer:

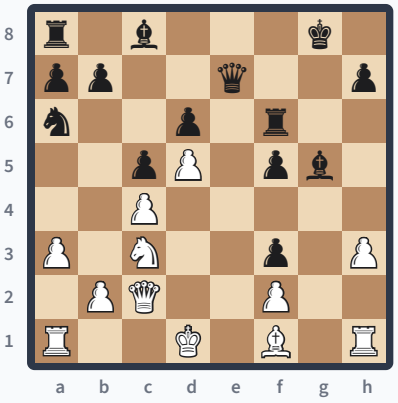
**3** **Is the centre open or closed? Which minor piece would you rather have?**



White (1882) v Black (2193) · 30+30
lichess.org/ByHYGkJZ

Answer:

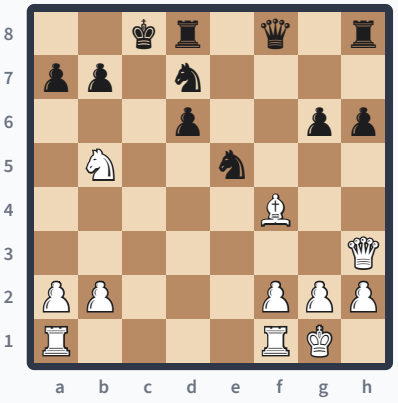
**4** **Is the centre open or closed? Which minor piece would you rather have?**



White (1994) v Black (2132) · 25+25
lichess.org/YOVKeMxP

Answer:

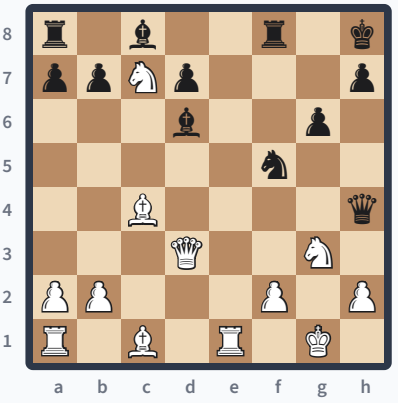
**5** **Is the centre open or closed? Which minor piece would you rather have?**



White (1500) v Black (1503) · 8+0
lichess.org/Q8Wyxruo

Answer:

**6** **Is the centre open or closed? Which minor piece would you rather have?**



White (1566) v Black (1520) · 10+2
lichess.org/cN4BZfbe

Answer:

**Tip:** improve your worst piece, fix enemy weaknesses, then cash in.

**Score: ____ / 6**

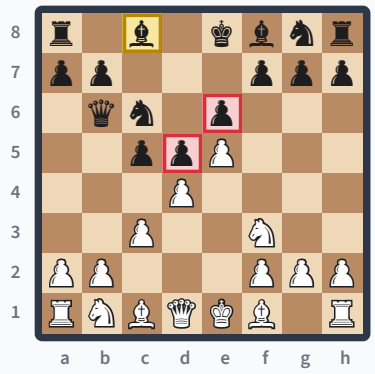
# GOOD & BAD BISHOPS

Your pawns decide how good your Bishop is

**Lesson 12 · Strategy**
Level 3 Strategy

## 1. The Bad Bishop

BLOCKED BY ITS OWN PAWNS



`French: Black's c8-Bishop`

- Black's centre pawns **d5 and e6** stand on light squares, the same colour as the c8-Bishop.
- It has almost no moves: a classic **bad Bishop**.

## 2. The Good Bishop

FREE DIAGONALS

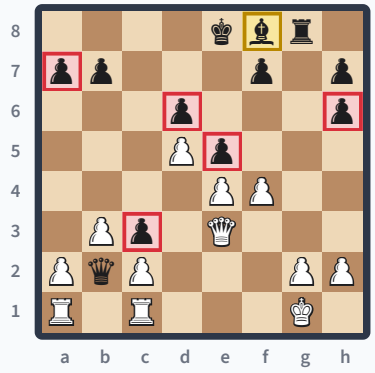


`White's f1-Bishop, same position`

- White's centre pawns **d4 and e5** stand on dark squares.
- So White's **light-squared** Bishop has open diagonals: a good Bishop.

## 3. Real Game: Bad Bishop

BAD BISHOP

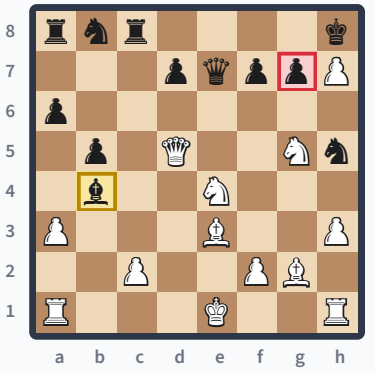


`Black's Bishop f8 (dark squares)`

- Black's pawns on dark squares: **5** of 8 (c3, e5, d6, h6, a7).
- Its own pawns block it: a bad Bishop.
- White (1429) v Black (1500) · 15+1 · lichess.org/PXiVI14x

## 4. Real Game: Good Bishop

GOOD BISHOP



`Black's Bishop b4 (dark squares)`

- Black's pawns on dark squares: **1** of 5 (g7).
- Pawns on the other colour leave the diagonals free: a good Bishop.
- White (1310) v Black (1303) · 20+40 · lichess.org/cIt2iPsO

### What to Do About Bishops

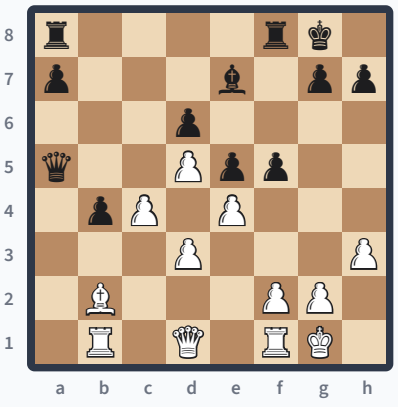
1. Put your pawns on the **opposite colour** to your remaining Bishop.
2. **Trade your bad Bishop** (for example ...b6 and ...Ba6 in the French), or get it outside the pawn chain.
3. Against a bad Bishop, fix more enemy pawns on its colour and use your Knight.

# PUZZLES: GOOD & BAD BISHOPS

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 12 · Strategy Puzzles**
Level 3 Strategy

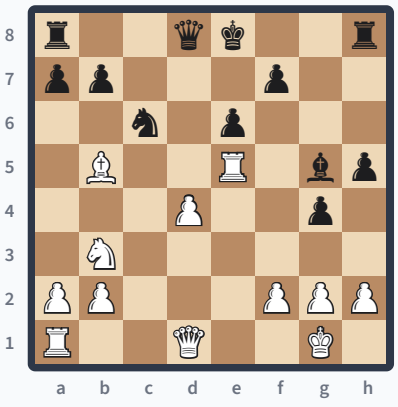
## 1 Is White's Bishop on b2 good or bad?



White (1722) v Black (1612) · 15+2
lichess.org/h2WdvNn9

Answer:

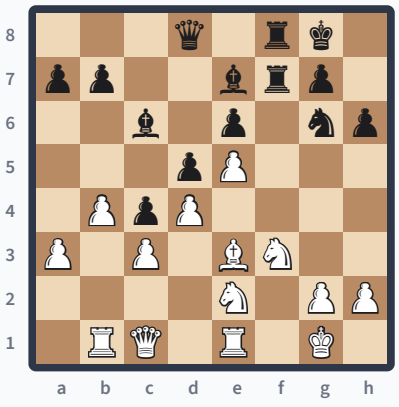
## 2 Is Black's Bishop on g5 good or bad?



White (1710) v Black (1499) · 15+15
lichess.org/CVnq41kq

Answer:

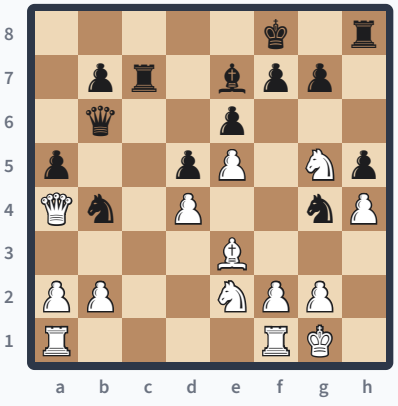
## 3 Is White's Bishop on e3 good or bad?



White (1919) v Black (1945) · 10+0
lichess.org/YSU9Y6Fk

Answer:

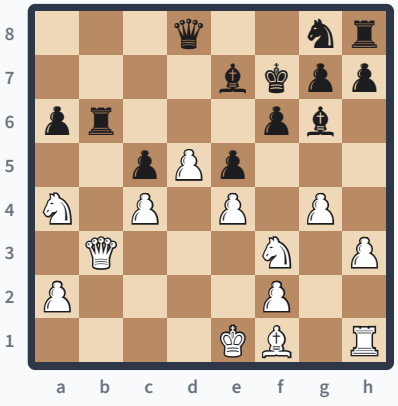
## 4 Is White's Bishop on e3 good or bad?



White (2180) v Black (2298) · 8+0
lichess.org/v0ZdHma3

Answer:

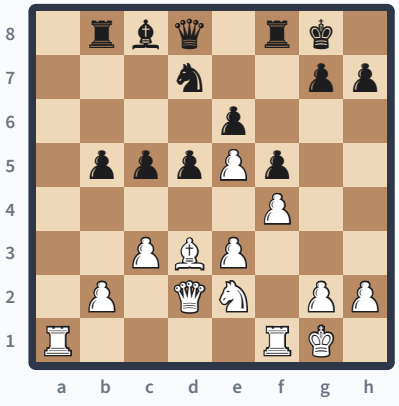
## 5 Is White's Bishop on f1 good or bad?



White (1829) v Black (1812) · 5+8
lichess.org/P7kNbHoz

Answer:

## 6 Is Black's Bishop on c8 good or bad?



White (2218) v Black (2133) · 10+5
lichess.org/4qjLQ2vt

Answer:

**Tip:** improve your worst piece, fix enemy weaknesses, then cash in.

**Score: ____ / 6**

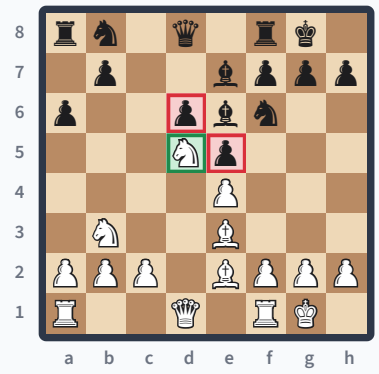
# OUTPOSTS

Squares no pawn can ever attack

Lesson 13 · Strategy
Level 3 Strategy

## 1. The d5 Outpost

SICILIAN HOLE

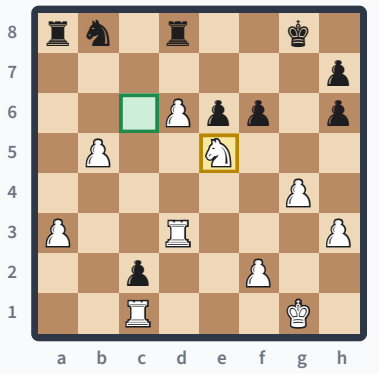


`...e5 left a hole on d5`

- Black has no c- or e-pawn that can ever attack **d5**.
- The Knight on d5 is a monster: only a piece can take it.

## 2. Real Game: 35.Nc6!

KNIGHT OUTPOST

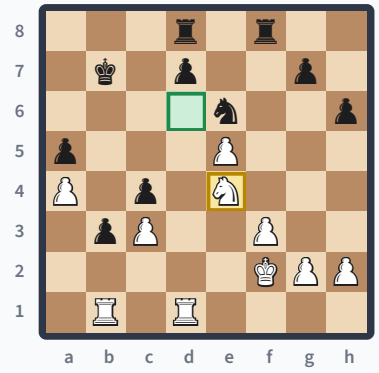


`35.Nc6 Rd7 36.Rxc2`

- **35.Nc6** puts the Knight on **c6**, an outpost.
- The pawn on b5 guards it, and no enemy pawn can ever chase it away.
- White (2063) v Black (1633) · 10+0 · lichess.org/AGyetIn2

## 3. Real Game: 32.Nd6+!

KNIGHT OUTPOST

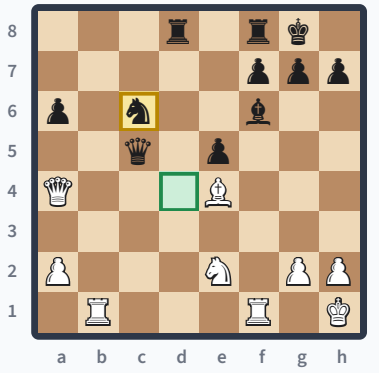


`32.Nd6+ Kc7 33.Nxc4`

- **32.Nd6+** puts the Knight on **d6**, an outpost.
- The pawn on e5 guards it, and no enemy pawn can ever chase it away.
- White (1916) v Black (1943) · 10+0 · lichess.org/1zf3E5Qv

## 4. Real Game: 24...Nd4!

KNIGHT OUTPOST



`24...Nd4 25.Qxa6 Rd6`

- **24...Nd4** puts the Knight on **d4**, an outpost.
- The pawn on e5 guards it, and no enemy pawn can ever chase it away.
- White (1641) v Black (1598) · 10+0 · lichess.org/KYjtOele

## Finding Outposts

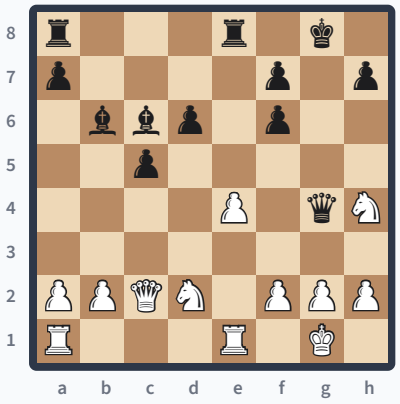
1. An **outpost** is a square in enemy territory that **no enemy pawn can ever attack**.
2. Guard it with one of your pawns, then put a **Knight** there. It can't be chased away.
3. Holes appear when pawns move forward: after ...e5 in the Sicilian, d5 becomes a hole.

# PUZZLES: OUTPOSTS

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 13 · Strategy Puzzles**
Level 3 Strategy

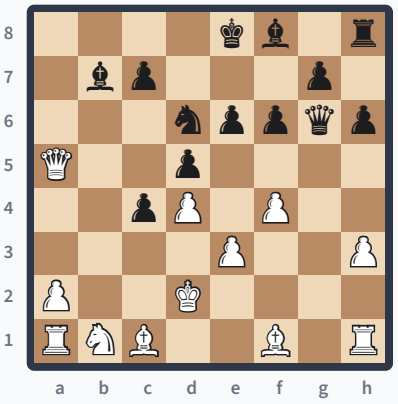
**1** **White to move. Find the best square for your Knight!**



White (1416) v Black (1511) · 15+0
lichess.org/eiqYU4gu

Answer:

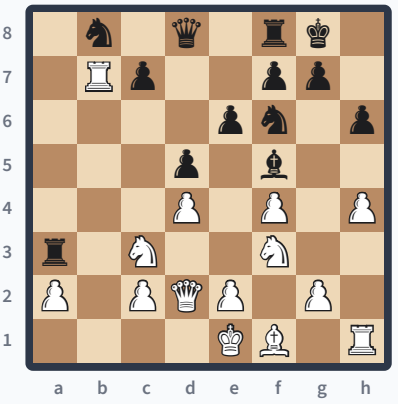
**2** **Black to move. Find the best square for your Knight!**



White (973) v Black (1050) · 15+15
lichess.org/GMA7tc2O

Answer:

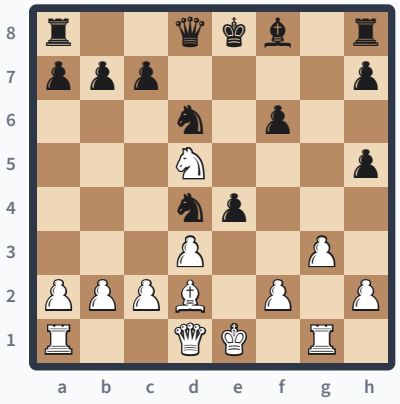
**3** **Black to move. Find the best square for your Knight!**



White (1511) v Black (1363) · 5+10
lichess.org/r3XYsW8V

Answer:

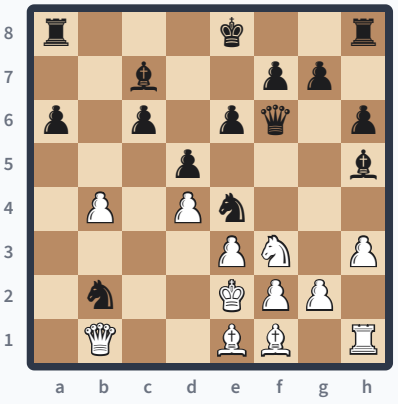
**4** **Black to move. Find the best square for your Knight!**



White (1238) v Black (1665) · 10+0
lichess.org/mbKyVXW4

Answer:

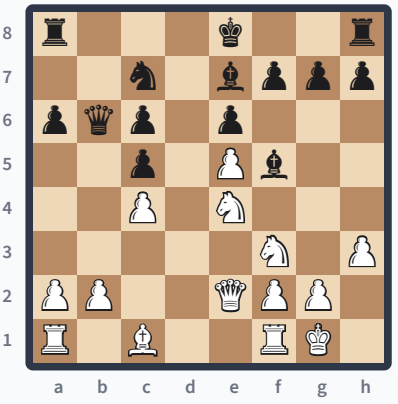
**5** **Black to move. Find the best square for your Knight!**



White (1500) v Black (1584) · 7+8
lichess.org/t6mdHSNd

Answer:

**6** **White to move. Find the best square for your Knight!**



White (1907) v Black (1886) · 5+5
lichess.org/2O5yNONv

Answer:

**Tip:** improve your worst piece, fix enemy weaknesses, then cash in.

**Score: ____ / 6**

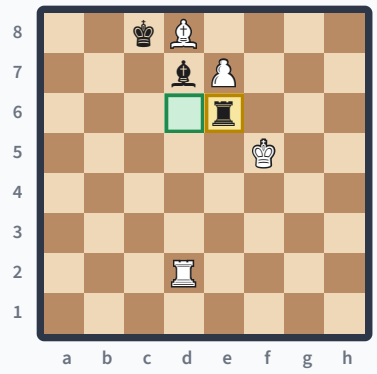
# OPEN FILES & THE 7TH RANK

Where your Rooks belong

**Lesson 14 · Strategy**
Level 3 Strategy

## 1. Real Game: 55...Rd6+!

OPEN FILE

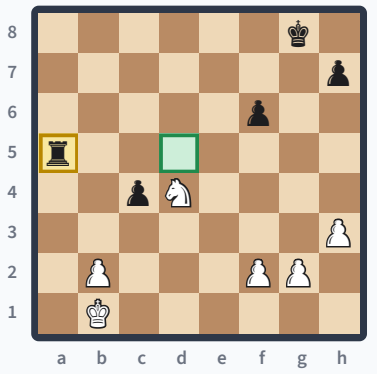


```
55...Rd6+ 56.Kg5 Rxd2
```

- **55...Rd6+**: the Rook takes the open **d-file**.
- Open files are highways. Next stop: the 7th rank.
- White (972) v Black (1247) · 10+0 · lichess.org/mwcADhNn

## 2. Real Game: 38...Rd5!

OPEN FILE

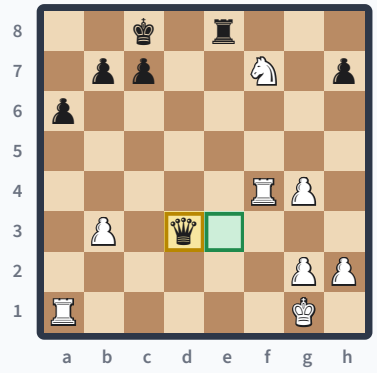


```
38...Rd5 39.Nc6 Rd2
```

- **38...Rd5**: the Rook takes the open **d-file**.
- Open files are highways. Next stop: the 7th rank.
- White (1621) v Black (1325) · 8+5 · lichess.org/vxqgqYJD

## 3. Real Game: 23...Qe3+!

OPEN FILE

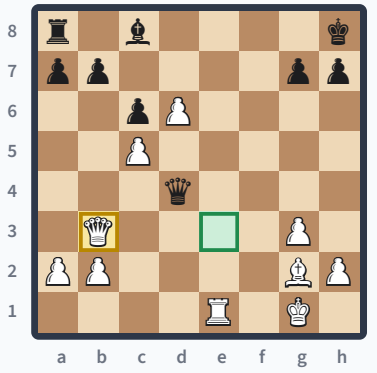


```
23...Qe3+ 24.Rf2 Rf8
```

- **23...Qe3+**: the Queen takes the open **e-file**.
- Open files are highways. Next stop: the 7th rank.
- White (1929) v Black (1690) · 10+0 · lichess.org/d4YKhxGi

## 4. Real Game: 25.Qe3!

OPEN FILE



```
25.Qe3 Qxe3+ 26.Rxe3
```

- **25.Qe3**: the Queen takes the open **e-file**.
- Open files are highways. Next stop: the 7th rank.
- White (2070) v Black (1910) · 15+5 · lichess.org/Pul3KmLC

## Rook Rules

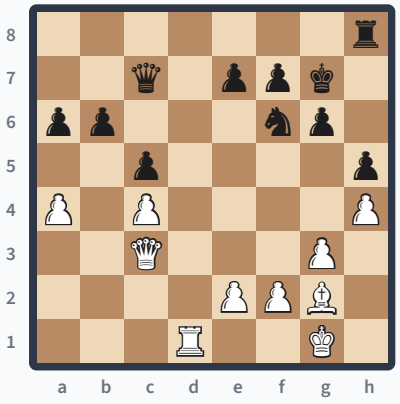
1. Put Rooks on **open files** (no pawns) or half-open files (only enemy pawns).
2. **Double** your Rooks on the file, then invade the **7th rank**.
3. A Rook on the 7th attacks pawns from the side and traps the King on the back rank.

# PUZZLES: OPEN FILES & THE 7TH RANK

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 14 · Strategy Puzzles**
Level 3 Strategy

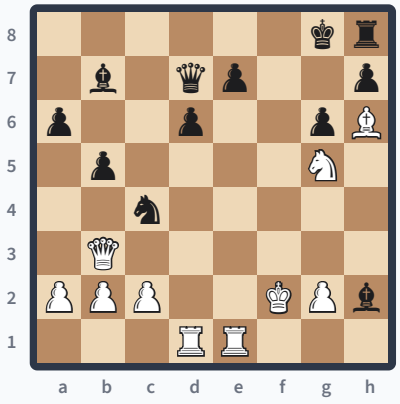
**1** **Black to move. Put your heavy piece to work!**



White (1768) v Black (1878) · 10+0
lichess.org/Aub91G4K

Answer:

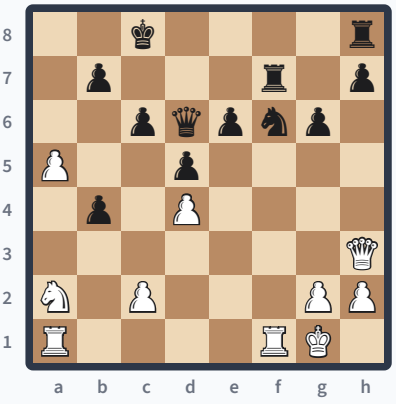
**2** **Black to move. Put your heavy piece to work!**



White (1799) v Black (1760) · 10+10
lichess.org/CDglUpUj

Answer:

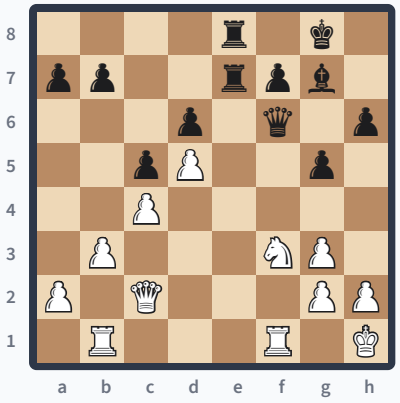
**3** **Black to move. Put your heavy piece to work!**



White (1404) v Black (1558) · 10+5
lichess.org/9DkLUGt2

Answer:

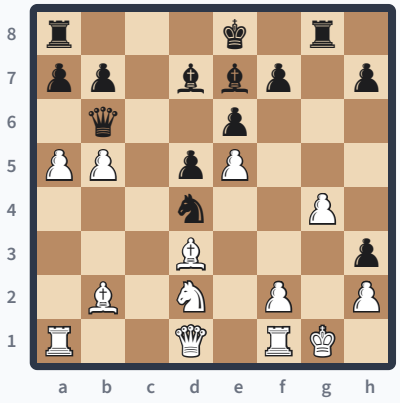
**4** **Black to move. Put your heavy piece to work!**



White (2022) v Black (2016) · 10+0
lichess.org/5ccfqkyU

Answer:

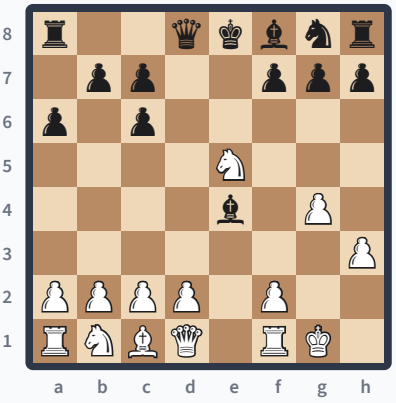
**5** **Black to move. Put your heavy piece to work!**



White (2222) v Black (2029) · 15+15
lichess.org/g5AVWcp2

Answer:

**6** **White to move. Put your heavy piece to work!**



White (2159) v Black (1749) · 10+0
lichess.org/CNJt3rqI

Answer:

**Tip:** improve your worst piece, fix enemy weaknesses, then cash in.

**Score: ____ / 6**

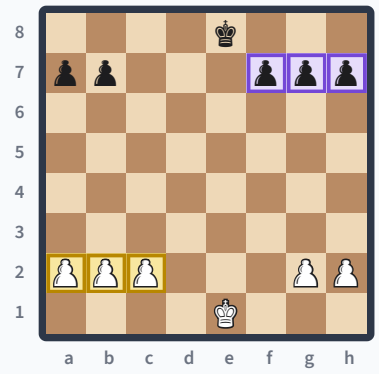
# PAWN MAJORITIES

More pawns on one wing = a future passed pawn

**Lesson 15 · Strategy**
Level 3 Strategy

## 1. Two Majorities

3 v 2 AND 2 v 3

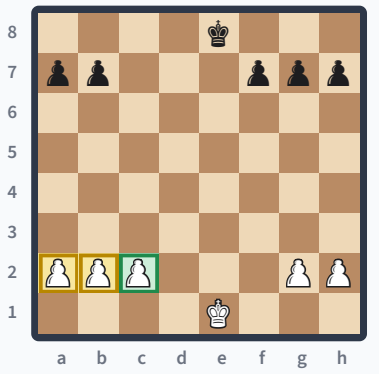


`White: queenside 3-2 · Black: kingside 3-2`

- White has **3 pawns v 2** on the queenside; Black has **3 v 2** on the kingside.
- Both sides can make a passed pawn on their own wing.

## 2. Candidate Pawn First

NO PAWN IN FRONT

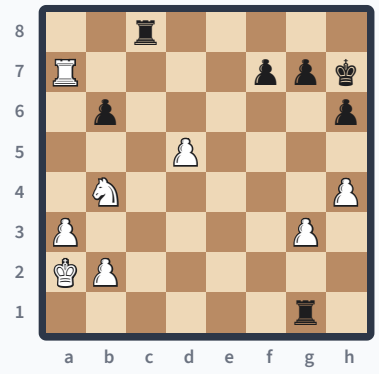


`White plays c4, b4, c5: the c-pawn goes first`

- The **candidate** is the pawn with no enemy pawn in front of it: here the **c-pawn**.
- Push the candidate first, supported by its neighbours, and a passed pawn appears.

## 3. Real Game: Majorities

COUNT BY WING

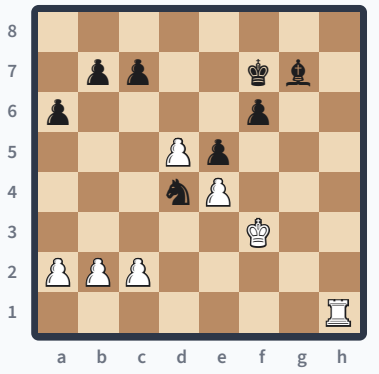


`Queenside W3-B1 · Kingside W2-B3`

- Queenside (a–d files): White 3, Black 1. Kingside (e–h): White 2, Black 3.
- Each majority can make a passed pawn. Push the one furthest from the Kings.
- White (1710) v Black (2053) · 10+0 · lichess.org/LvoKexcf

## 4. Real Game: Majorities

COUNT BY WING



`Queenside W4-B3 · Kingside W1-B2`

- Queenside (a–d files): White 4, Black 3. Kingside (e–h): White 1, Black 2.
- Each majority can make a passed pawn. Push the one furthest from the Kings.
- White (1349) v Black (1306) · 10+0 · lichess.org/RVdKnAU2

## Using a Majority

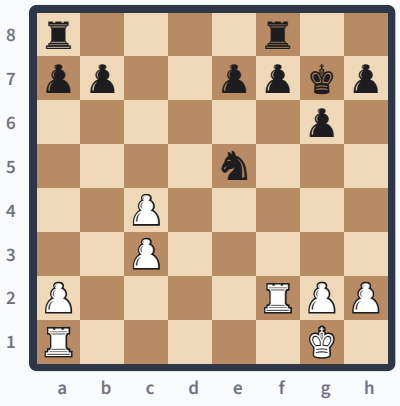
1. Count pawns on each wing (a–d and e–h).
2. A **queenside majority** is extra good when both Kings are on the kingside: the passed pawn is far from the enemy King.
3. Advance the candidate pawn first; don't rush the others and create weaknesses.

# PUZZLES: PAWN MAJORITIES

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 15 · Strategy Puzzles**
Level 3 Strategy

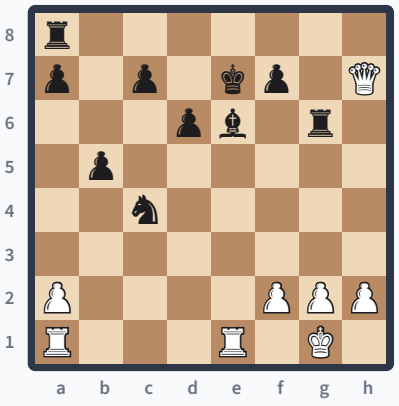
**1** **Where does each side have a pawn majority?**



White (1822) v Black (1934) · 10+0
lichess.org/6ydzLNMU

Answer:

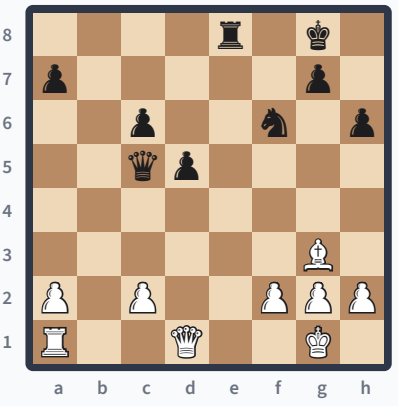
**2** **Where does each side have a pawn majority?**



White (2082) v Black (1517) · 10+0
lichess.org/bG1kuBgN

Answer:

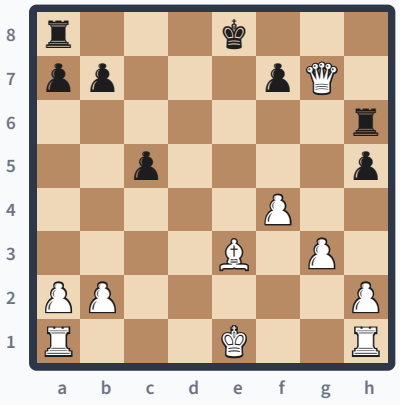
**3** **Where does each side have a pawn majority?**



White (1592) v Black (1628) · 10+0
lichess.org/PsrBfkbV

Answer:

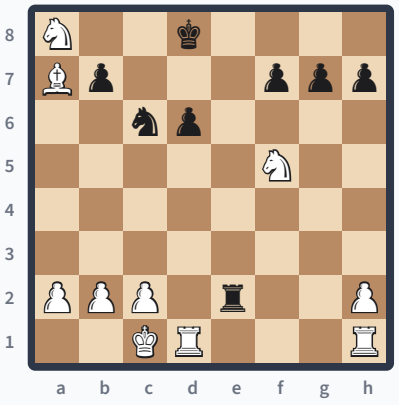
**4** **Where does each side have a pawn majority?**



White (1158) v Black (1500) · 5+8
lichess.org/4xJuL3iO

Answer:

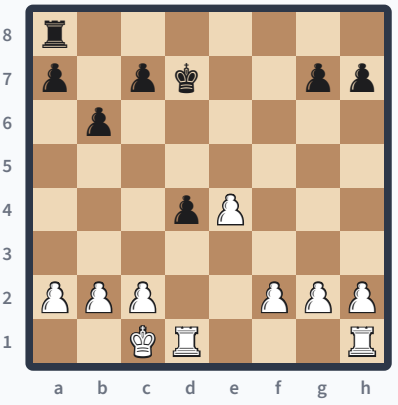
**5** **Where does each side have a pawn majority?**



White (1391) v Black (1360) · 20+0
lichess.org/bzujF8pw

Answer:

**6** **Where does each side have a pawn majority?**



White (1437) v Black (1431) · 10+0
lichess.org/S9SV1nuZ

Answer:

**Tip:** improve your worst piece, fix enemy weaknesses, then cash in.

**Score: ____ / 6**

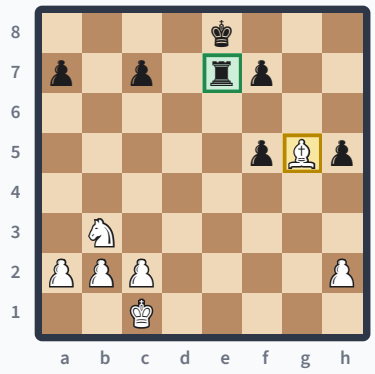
# CONVERTING AN ADVANTAGE

Turn a better position into extra material

**Lesson 16 · Strategy**
Level 3 Strategy

## 1. Real Game: 25.Bxe7!

CASH IN

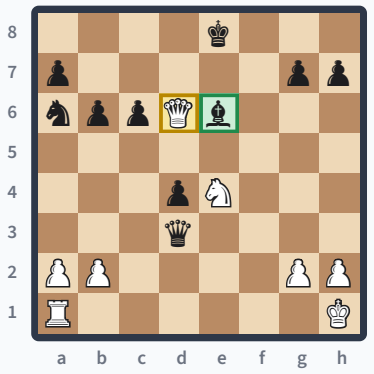


`25.Bxe7 Kxe7 26.Nd2`

- Material is equal, but one side has the better position.
- **25.Bxe7 Kxe7 26.Nd2 Kf6**: the pressure turns into material, wins 2 points.
- White (1937) v Black (1221) · 16+8 · lichess.org/brRIdRzh

## 2. Real Game: 33.Qxe6+!

CASH IN

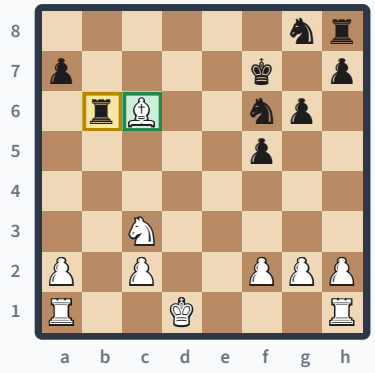


`33.Qxe6+ Kd8 34.Qd6+`

- Material is equal, but one side has the better position.
- **33.Qxe6+ Kd8 34.Qd6+ Kc8**: the pressure turns into material, wins 3 points.
- White (1525) v Black (1343) · 5+8 · lichess.org/8kalyRfy

## 3. Real Game: 17...Rxc6!

CASH IN

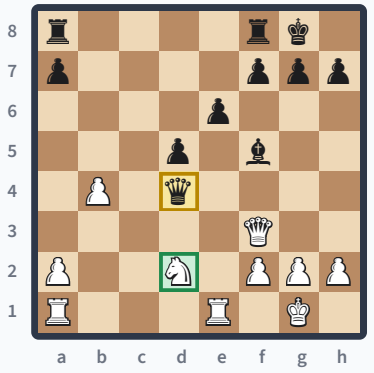


`17...Rxc6 18.Nb5 Ne7`

- Material is equal, but one side has the better position.
- **17...Rxc6 18.Nb5 Ne7 19.Kc1**: the pressure turns into material, wins 3 points.
- White (1347) v Black (1412) · 10+0 · lichess.org/aYEAskk0

## 4. Real Game: 21...Qxd2!

CASH IN



`21...Qxd2 22.Qa3 Bg6`

- Material is equal, but one side has the better position.
- **21...Qxd2 22.Qa3 Bg6 23.h3**: the pressure turns into material, wins 3 points.
- White (1710) v Black (1738) · 12+3 · lichess.org/x8Mr5B3I

### From Pressure to Points

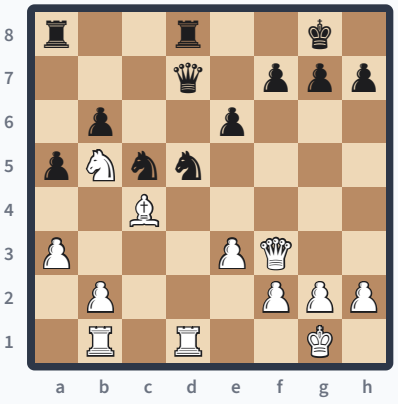
1. A **positional advantage** (better pieces, weak enemy pawns, open files) doesn't win by itself.
2. Build up pressure until a target **can't be defended** any more, then cash in.
3. Look for the moment when your pressure wins a pawn or piece. Then simplify.

# PUZZLES: CONVERTING AN ADVANTAGE

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 16 · Strategy Puzzles**
Level 3 Strategy

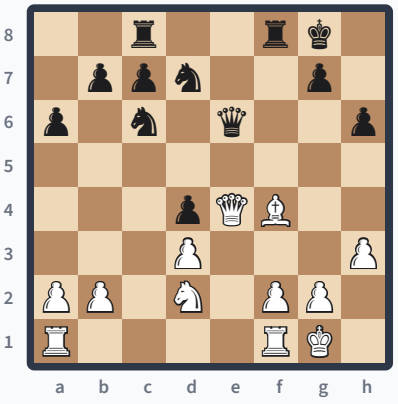
**1** **White to move. Turn your better position into material!**



White (1510) v Black (1725) · 7+2
lichess.org/YUmrKeRR

Answer:

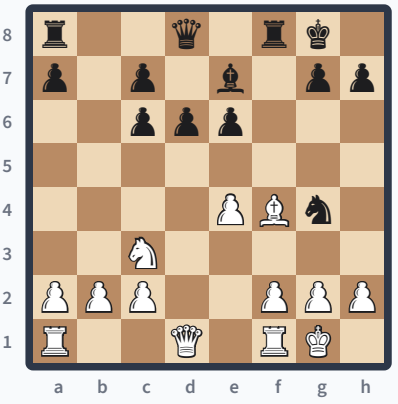
**2** **Black to move. Turn your better position into material!**



White (1423) v Black (1610) · 10+0
lichess.org/AelmoJUj

Answer:

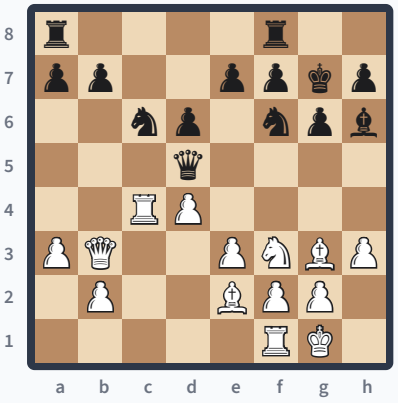
**3** **White to move. Turn your better position into material!**



White (2329) v Black (1613) · 10+0
lichess.org/aBqSsQkG

Answer:

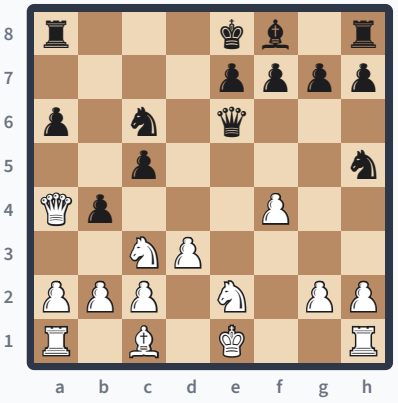
**4** **Black to move. Turn your better position into material!**



White (1696) v Black (1967) · 10+8
lichess.org/j10I9Oe6

Answer:

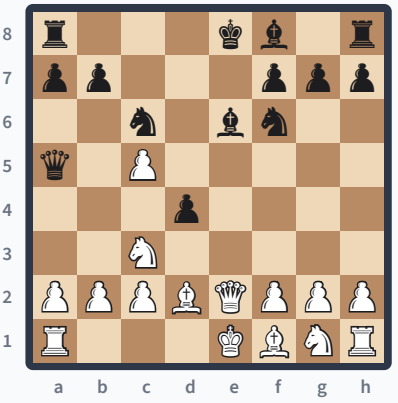
**5** **Black to move. Turn your better position into material!**



White (1377) v Black (1645) · 10+0
lichess.org/AEnf3ulA

Answer:

**6** **Black to move. Turn your better position into material!**



White (1684) v Black (1717) · 10+0
lichess.org/AAEpWnBt

Answer:

**Tip:** improve your worst piece, fix enemy weaknesses, then cash in.

**Score: ____ / 6**

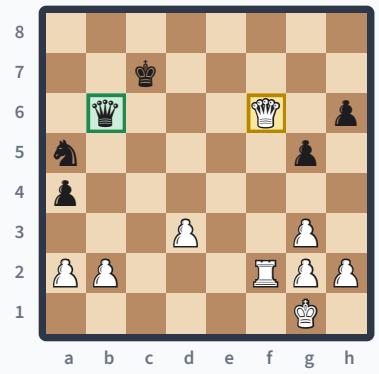
# SIMPLIFICATION

Ahead in material? Trade pieces, not pawns

**Lesson 17 · Strategy**
Level 3 Strategy

## 1. Real Game: 38.Qxb6+!

TRADE DOWN

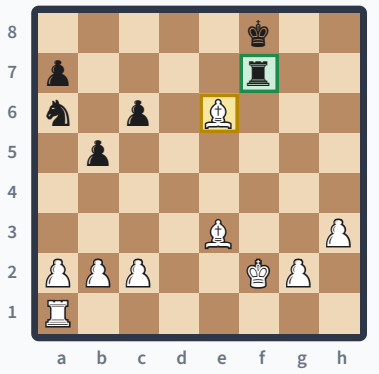


```
38.Qxb6+ Kxb6 39.Rf6+
```

- White is 5 points up.
- **38.Qxb6+** forces a trade. Every exchange brings the win closer.
- White (1668) v Black (1365) · 10+5 · lichess.org/iSzpTKUk

## 2. Real Game: 26.Bxf7!

TRADE DOWN

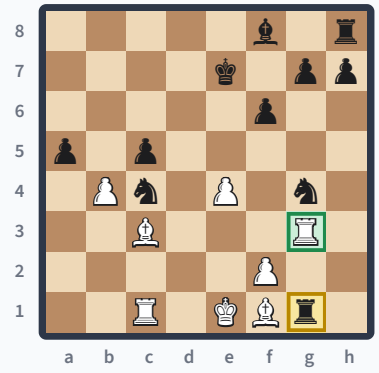


```
26.Bxf7 Kxf7 27.Bxa7
```

- White is 5 points up.
- **26.Bxf7** forces a trade. Every exchange brings the win closer.
- White (1551) v Black (1142) · 10+0 · lichess.org/5kY5WUxA

## 3. Real Game: 33...Rxg3!

TRADE DOWN

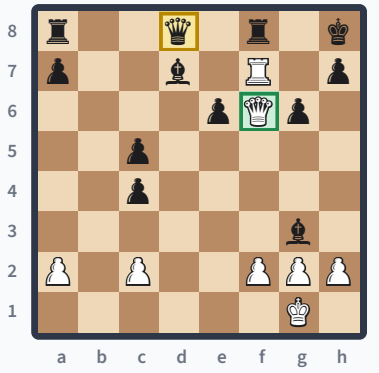


```
33...Rxg3 34.fxg3 axb4
```

- Black is 5 points up.
- **33...Rxg3** forces a trade. Every exchange brings the win closer.
- White (1146) v Black (1055) · 6+9 · lichess.org/diXKJT7y

## 4. Real Game: 24...Qxf6!

TRADE DOWN



```
24...Qxf6 25.Rxf6 Rxf6
```

- Black is 12 points up.
- **24...Qxf6** forces a trade. Every exchange brings the win closer.
- White (1137) v Black (1533) · 10+5 · lichess.org/JAl8hjBY

### When to Simplify

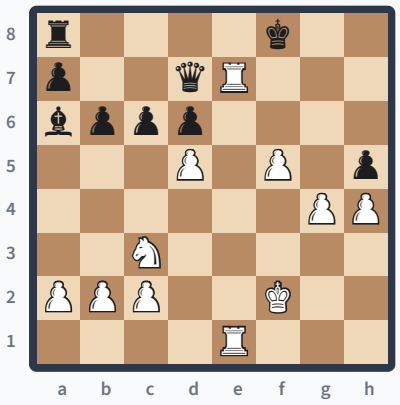
1. When you're ahead, **trade pieces**. Each trade makes your extra material count for more.
2. Keep your **pawns**: they become Queens in the endgame.
3. Trade your opponent's **most active** pieces first, and give material back if it kills their counterplay.

# PUZZLES: SIMPLIFICATION

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 17 · Strategy Puzzles**
Level 3 Strategy

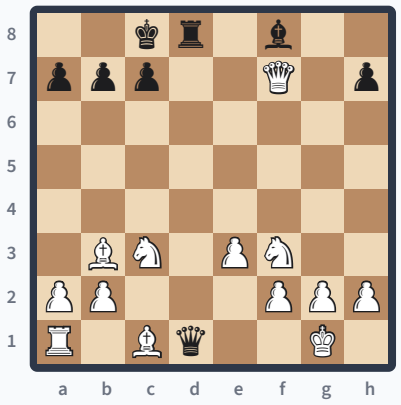
**1** **Black to move. You're ahead: find the right trade!**



White (1568) v Black (1617) · 10+0
lichess.org/F7oADKYb

Answer:

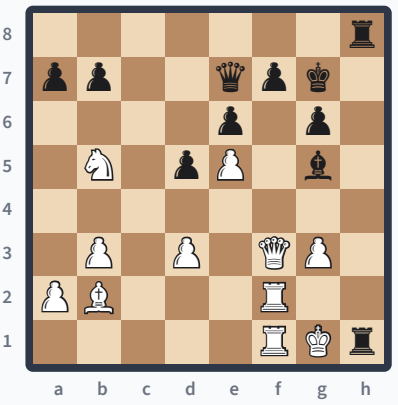
**2** **White to move. You're ahead: find the right trade!**



White (1939) v Black (1167) · 8+3
lichess.org/7JK0UUgx

Answer:

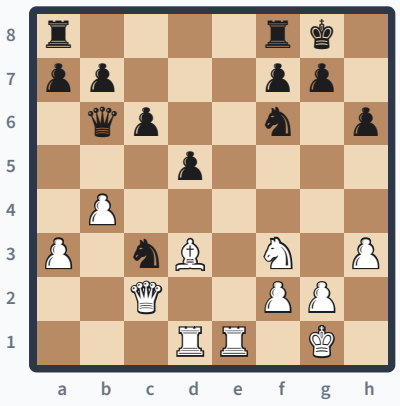
**3** **White to move. You're ahead: find the right trade!**



White (1735) v Black (1759) · 10+0
lichess.org/4w787c2x

Answer:

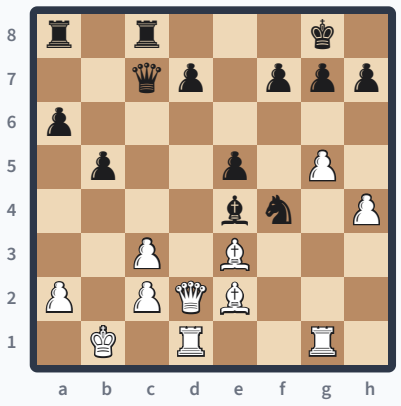
**4** **Black to move. You're ahead: find the right trade!**



White (1774) v Black (1965) · 10+0
lichess.org/roan7WHy

Answer:

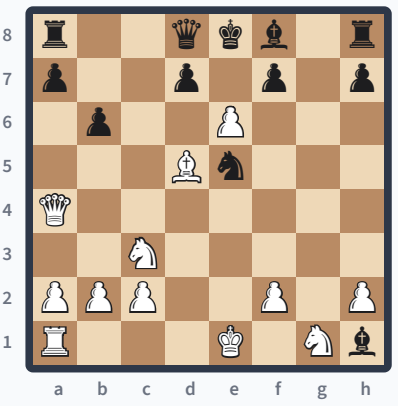
**5** **Black to move. You're ahead: find the right trade!**



White (1933) v Black (2318) · 10+0
lichess.org/AAiM3La2

Answer:

**6** **Black to move. You're ahead: find the right trade!**



White (1245) v Black (1264) · 15+15
lichess.org/yHUUC2i5

Answer:

**Tip:** improve your worst piece, fix enemy weaknesses, then cash in.

**Score: ____ / 6**

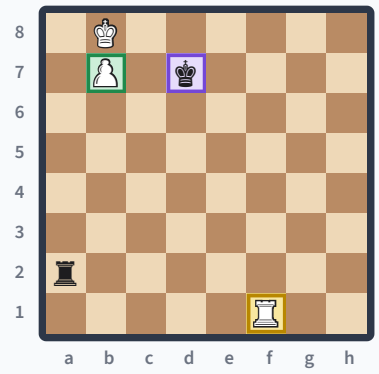
# ROOK ENDGAMES

Lucena wins, Philidor draws

**Lesson 18 · Endgame**
Level 3 Endgame

## 1. The Lucena Position

BUILD A BRIDGE

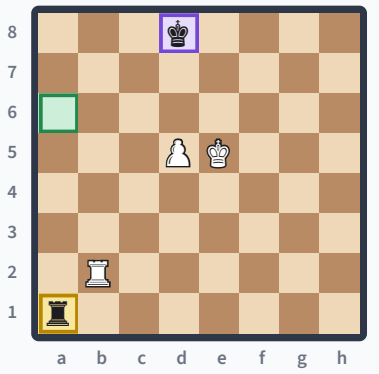


```
1.Rd1+ Ke6 2.Rd4! and the King walks out
```

- White's King is stuck in front of its pawn. Check the black King away first.
- Then **Rd4!** builds a "bridge": the Rook blocks the checks and the pawn promotes.

## 2. The Philidor Defence

THIRD-RANK DEFENCE

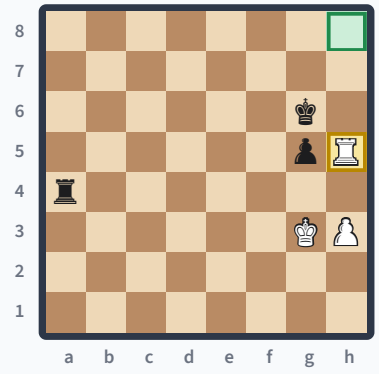


```
Black to move: 1...Ra6! and wait
```

- Keep the Rook on the **6th rank** so the white King can't come forward.
- When the pawn advances to d6, drop the Rook back and **check from behind**. It's a draw.

## 3. Real Game: 66.Rh8!

ONLY MOVE

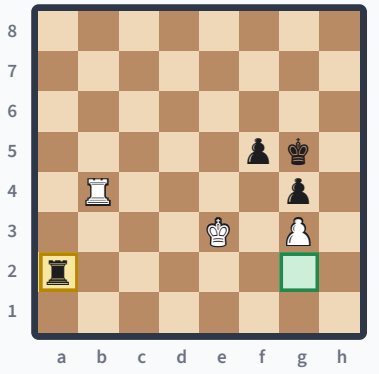


```
66.Rh8 Ra5 67.Rc8
```

- **66.Rh8**! This holds the draw.
- Every other move is clearly worse. Endgames reward exact moves.
- White (1513) v Black (1634) · 8+0 · lichess.org/oSgyvDxC

## 4. Real Game: 49...Rg2!

ONLY MOVE



```
49...Rg2 50.Rb5 Rxg3+
```

- **49...Rg2**! This wins.
- Every other move is clearly worse. Endgames reward exact moves.
- White (1809) v Black (2056) · 15+10 · lichess.org/uvGGn5T2

## Rook Endgame Rules

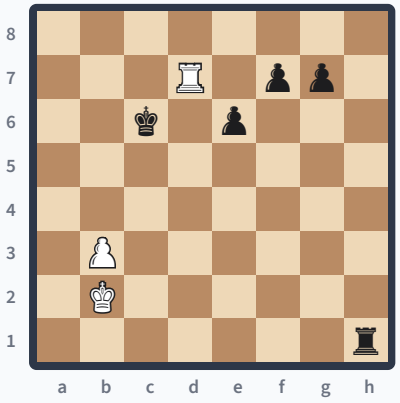
1. **Lucena:** King in front of its pawn on the 7th? Cut off the enemy King, then build a bridge with the Rook on the 4th rank.
2. **Philidor:** defending? Rook on your 3rd rank until the pawn advances, then check from behind.
3. Rooks belong **behind** passed pawns, yours and theirs.

# PUZZLES: ROOK ENDGAMES

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 18 · Endgame Puzzles**
Level 3 Endgame

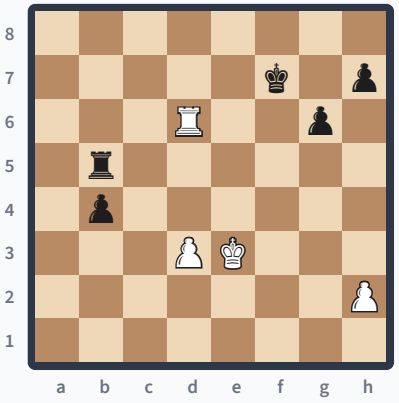
**1** **White to move. Rook endgame: find the only good move!**



White (1228) v Black (1227) · 10+0
lichess.org/sjTPYY3f

Answer:

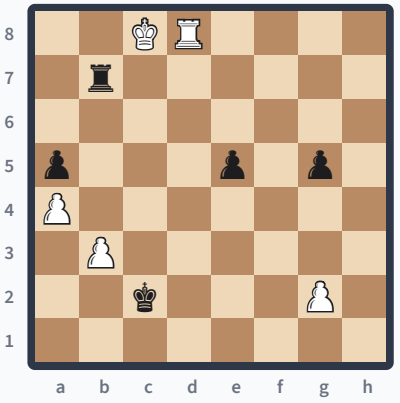
**2** **Black to move. Rook endgame: find the only good move!**



White (1228) v Black (1732) · 10+0
lichess.org/iFhCGwBS

Answer:

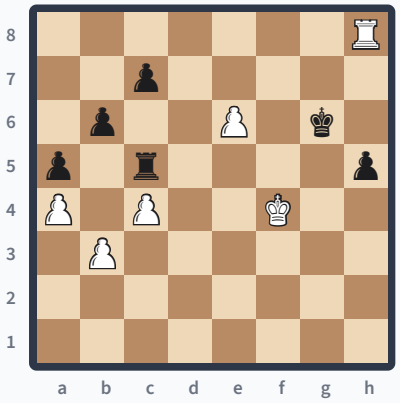
**3** **White to move. Rook endgame: find the only good move!**



White (1840) v Black (1699) · 10+0
lichess.org/TtsLcVlP

Answer:

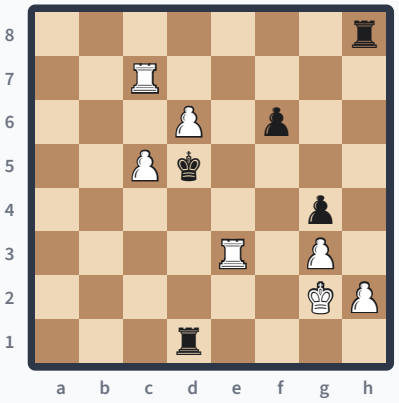
**4** **Black to move. Rook endgame: find the only good move!**



White (1976) v Black (1987) · 7+4
lichess.org/MP8TYTbX

Answer:

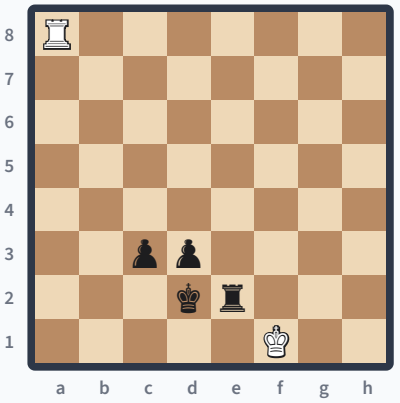
**5** **Black to move. Rook endgame: find the only good move!**



White (1362) v Black (1458) · 12+5
lichess.org/UKHQznZP

Answer:

**6** **White to move. Rook endgame: find the only good move!**



White (1828) v Black (1937) · 10+0
lichess.org/pYP277Es

Answer:

**Tip:** Kings are fighters in the endgame. Every tempo counts!

**Score: ____ / 6**

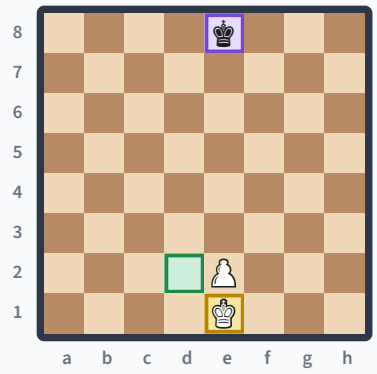
# OPPOSITION & KEY SQUARES

King and pawn endings are won by the Kings

**Lesson 19 · Endgame**
Level 3 Endgame

## 1. Distant Opposition

KINGS FAR APART

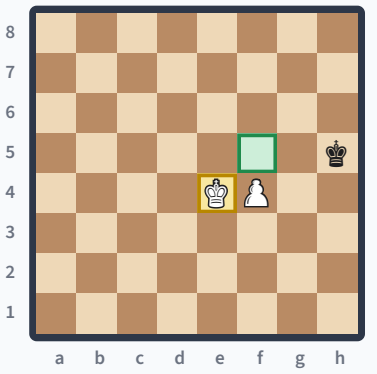


```
White to move: 1.Kd2! (or 1.Kf2) wins
```

- Only a King move forward wins. **1.Kd1?** is just a draw.
- Take the opposition early and walk your King in front of the pawn.

## 2. Real Game: 69.Kf5!

ONLY MOVE

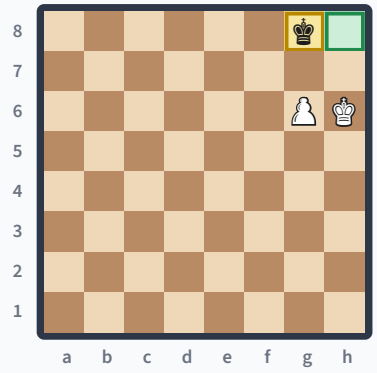


```
69.Kf5 Kh6 70.Kf6
```

- **69.Kf5**! This wins.
- Every other move is clearly worse. Endgames reward exact moves.
- White (1936) v Black (1812) · 10+0 · lichess.org/8ZhOzU0R

## 3. Real Game: 87...Kh8!

ONLY MOVE

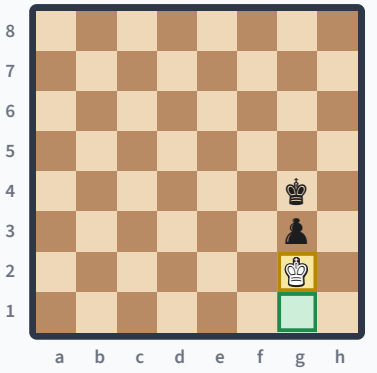


```
87...Kh8 88.Kh5 Kg7
```

- **87...Kh8**! This holds the draw.
- Every other move is clearly worse. Endgames reward exact moves.
- White (1814) v Black (2122) · 10+0 · lichess.org/GCPmb59X

## 4. Real Game: 95.Kg1!

ONLY MOVE



```
95.Kg1 Kf3 96.Kh1
```

- **95.Kg1**! This holds the draw.
- Every other move is clearly worse. Endgames reward exact moves.
- White (2165) v Black (2158) · 8+0 · lichess.org/Aj0AOyg9

## King Endgame Rules

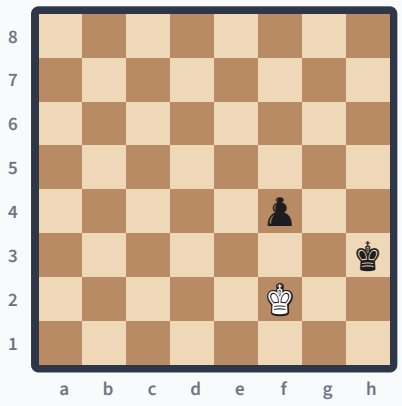
1. **Key squares:** get your King two squares in front of your pawn and you win.
2. **Opposition:** Kings face each other with an odd number of squares between; the side *not* to move has it.
3. **Triangulation:** if you need to pass the move, walk your King around a small triangle of squares that the enemy King can't copy.

# PUZZLES: OPPOSITION & KEY SQUARES

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 19 · Endgame Puzzles**
Level 3 Endgame

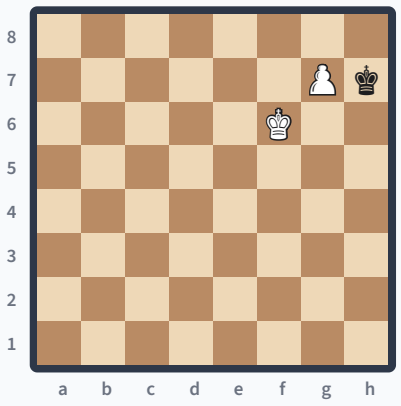
**1** **White to move. King and pawns: find the King move!**



White (1844) v Black (2110) · 10+0
lichess.org/CjnJA5t6

Answer:

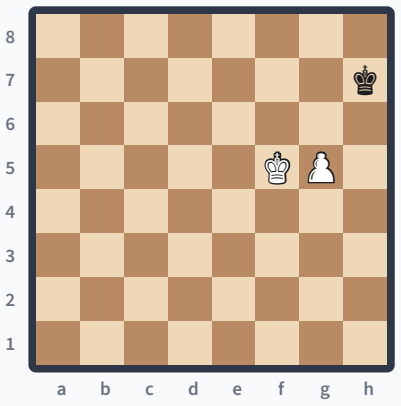
**2** **White to move. King and pawns: find the King move!**



White (1779) v Black (1794) · 5+5
lichess.org/Bi5kk9ch

Answer:

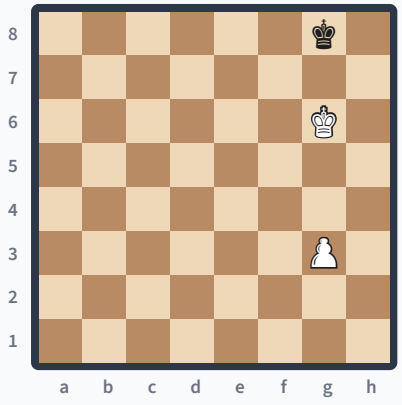
**3** **Black to move. King and pawns: find the King move!**



White (1783) v Black (1749) · 10+0
lichess.org/67oaFvds

Answer:

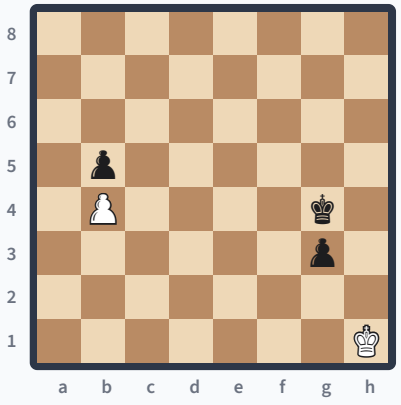
**4** **White to move. King and pawns: find the King move!**



White (1684) v Black (1511) · 30+3
lichess.org/Al14IEgI

Answer:

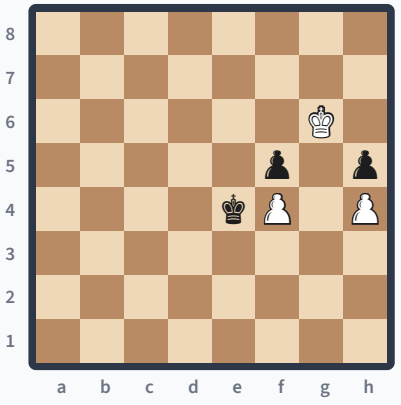
**5** **Black to move. King and pawns: find the King move!**



White (1687) v Black (1709) · 15+2
lichess.org/elQHIEKK

Answer:

**6** **White to move. King and pawns: find the King move!**



White (1962) v Black (1973) · 15+15
lichess.org/wRcp1MGU

Answer:

**Tip:** Kings are fighters in the endgame. Every tempo counts!

**Score: ____ / 6**

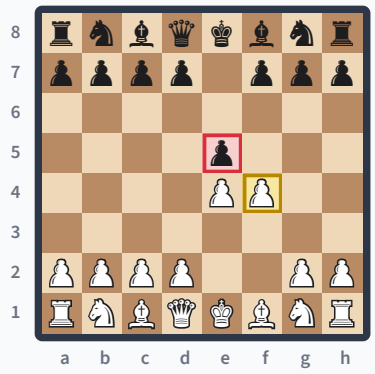
# THE KING'S GAMBIT

1.e4 e5 2.f4 · Give a pawn, take the centre

**Lesson 20 · Openings**
Level 3 Openings

## 1. The Gambit

2.F4!?

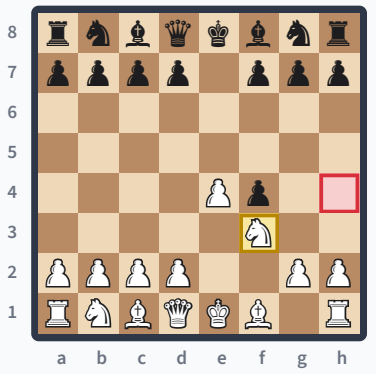


`1.e4 e5 2.f4`

- White offers the f-pawn to pull Black's e-pawn away from the centre.
- If Black takes, White gets d4 and an open f-file for the Rook.

## 2. Accepted: 3.Nf3

STOP ...QH4+

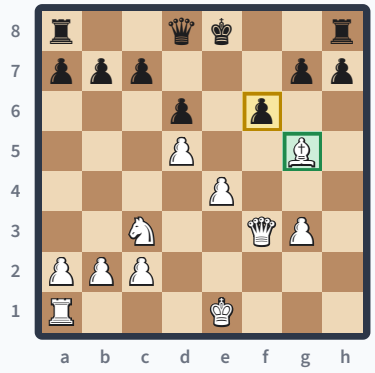


`2...exf4 3.Nf3`

- **3.Nf3** stops ...Qh4+ and prepares d4 and Bc4.
- White will castle and aim everything at f7.

## 3. Real Game: 15...fxg5!

REAL GAME

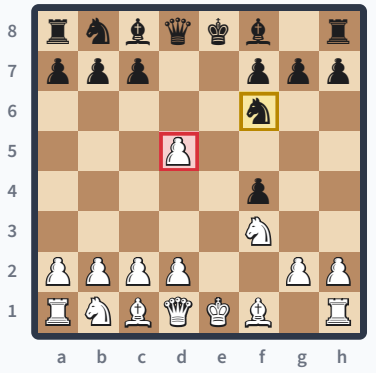


`15...fxg5 16.e5 dxe5`

- Black to move in a real game.
- **15...fxg5**! **15...fxg5 16.e5 dxe5 17.Ne4**, wins 4 points.
- White (1762) v Black (1580) · 10+15 · lichess.org/2pgWBSbd

## 4. Black's Antidote

3...D5!



`3...d5 4.exd5 Nf6`

- Black gives the pawn back to open lines and develop fast.
- Good rule against any gambit: return material for development.

## King's Gambit: Key Ideas

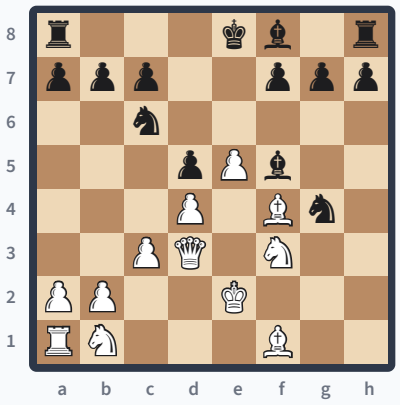
1. **Main idea:** White offers the f-pawn to pull Black's e-pawn away from the centre.
2. **Watch for:** Trap: 2...Bc5 3.fxe5?? Qh4+ 4.g3 Qxe4+ and Black wins the h1-Rook.
3. **In real games** (card 3): most points are lost to simple tactics in the opening. Check every capture!

# PUZZLES: KING'S GAMBIT

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 20 · Openings Puzzles**
Level 3 Openings

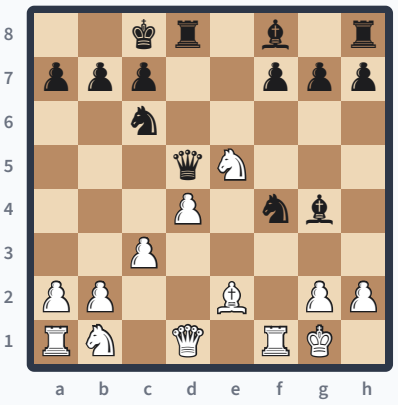
## 1 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1423) v Black (1396) · 8+3
lichess.org/uCzI23NG

Answer:

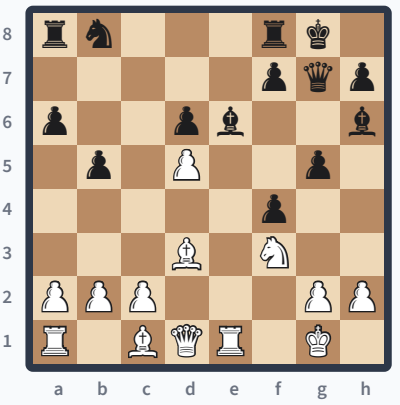
## 2 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1962) v Black (1700) · 5+5
lichess.org/se4MSTCf

Answer:

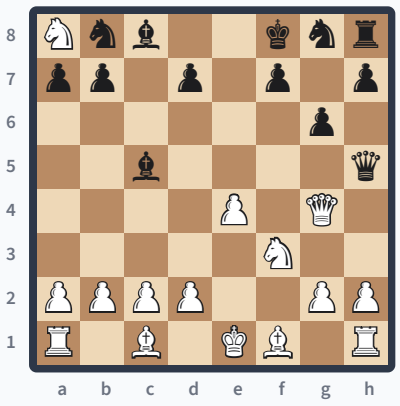
## 3 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1520) v Black (1539) · 10+0
lichess.org/6Ic6HvpE

Answer:

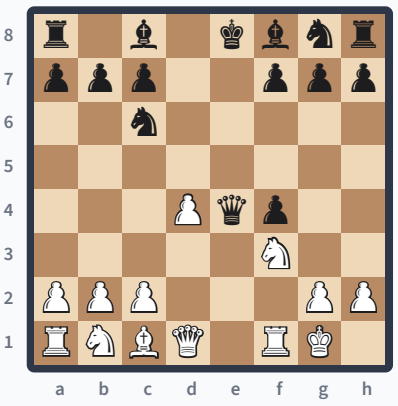
## 4 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1538) v Black (1545) · 10+0
lichess.org/qe8R9dnY

Answer:

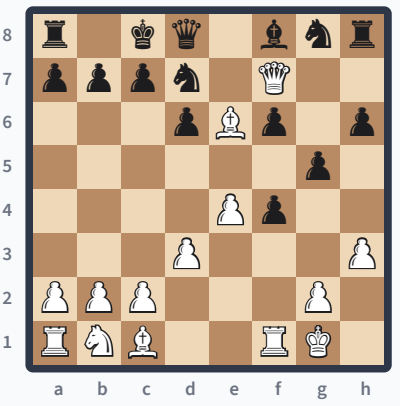
## 5 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1799) v Black (1578) · 0+13
lichess.org/Of4802hf

Answer:

## 6 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1494) v Black (1348) · 15+0
lichess.org/kon4VKdn

Answer:

**Tip:** after every opening move, ask: what did that leave unguarded?

**Score: ____ / 6**

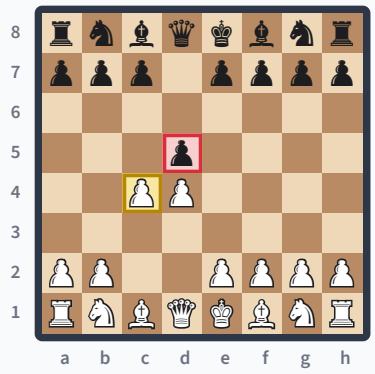
# THE QUEEN'S GAMBIT

1.d4 d5 2.c4 · Not a real gambit

**Lesson 21 · Openings**
Level 3 Openings

## 1. The Offer

2.C4

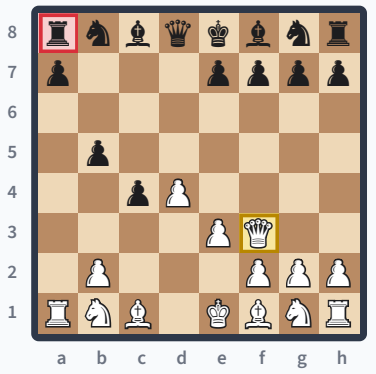


```
1.d4 d5 2.c4
```

- White attacks d5 from the side. Taking would give up the centre.
- Black can't keep the pawn for long: that's why it isn't a real gambit.

## 2. Accepted: Don't Hold On

6.QF3! WINS

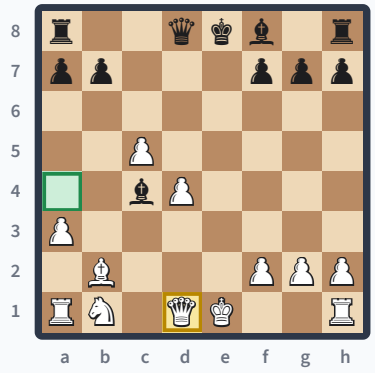


```
2...dxc4 3.e3 b5? 4.a4 c6 5.axb5 cxb5 6.Qf3!
```

- Trying to keep the pawn with ...b5 fails.
- **6.Qf3!** hits the a8-Rook along the long diagonal.

## 3. Real Game: 13.Qa4+!

REAL GAME

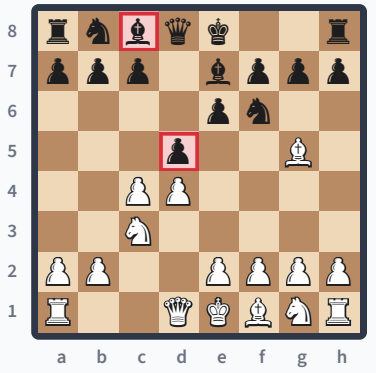


```
13.Qa4+ b5 14.cxb6+
```

- White to move in a real game.
- **13.Qa4+**! **13.Qa4+ b5 14.cxb6+ Qd7**, wins 4 points.
- White (1907) v Black (2051) · 10+0 · lichess.org/QeczVYS5

## 4. Declined: Solid

2...E6



```
2...e6 3.Nc3 Nf6 4.Bg5 Be7
```

- Black holds d5 and develops. The c8-Bishop is Black's problem piece.
- White's plan: pressure on the queenside with the minority attack.

## Queen's Gambit: Key Ideas

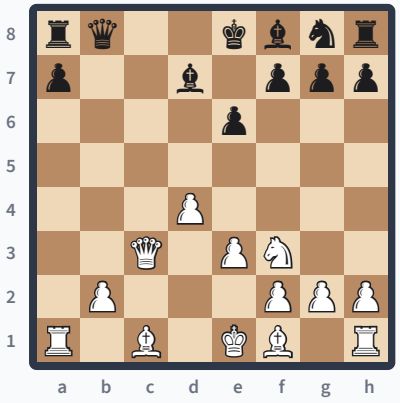
1. **Main idea:** White attacks d5 from the side. Taking would give up the centre.
2. **Watch for:** Minority attack: in the Exchange Queen's Gambit White plays b4–b5 to create a weak Black c-pawn.
3. **In real games** (card 3): most points are lost to simple tactics in the opening. Check every capture!

# PUZZLES: QUEEN'S GAMBIT

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 21 · Openings Puzzles**
Level 3 Openings

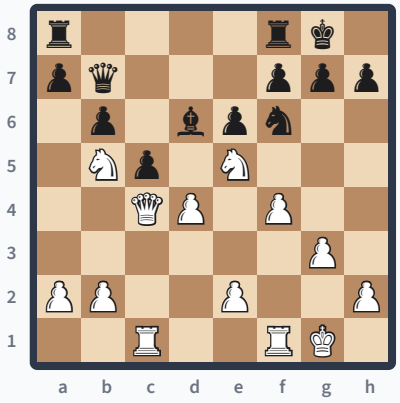
**1** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1216) v Black (1670) · 10+0
lichess.org/lV2UCevS

Answer:

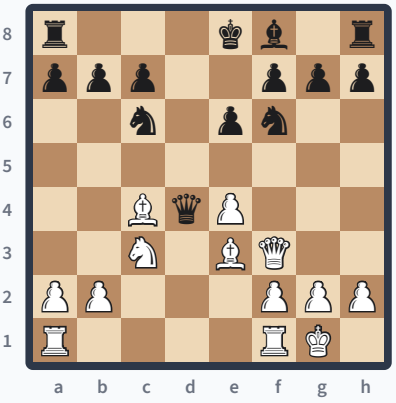
**2** **White to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1988) v Black (2010) · 10+0
lichess.org/Kxaw9vGG

Answer:

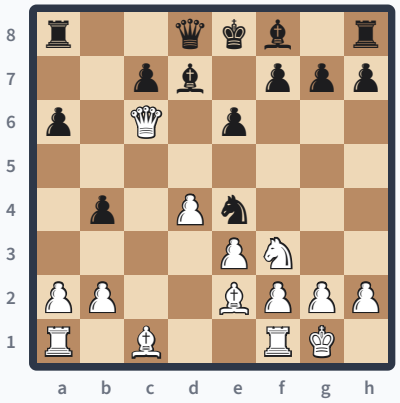
**3** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1667) v Black (1584) · 10+0
lichess.org/BEI6ho3a

Answer:

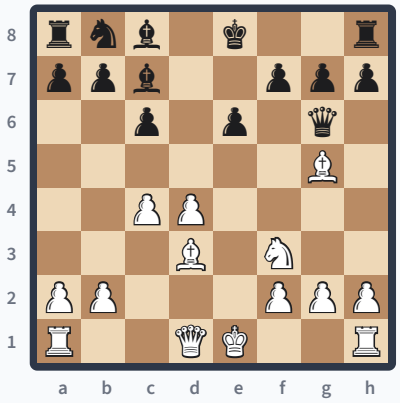
**4** **White to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1830) v Black (1263) · 5+8
lichess.org/G9NpQlT5

Answer:

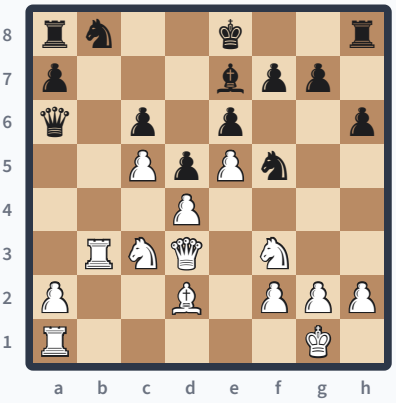
**5** **White to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (2161) v Black (1910) · 10+0
lichess.org/yyOI0nz4

Answer:

**6** **White to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1816) v Black (1602) · 10+0
lichess.org/nhuejukv

Answer:

**Tip:** after every opening move, ask: what did that leave unguarded?

**Score: ____ / 6**

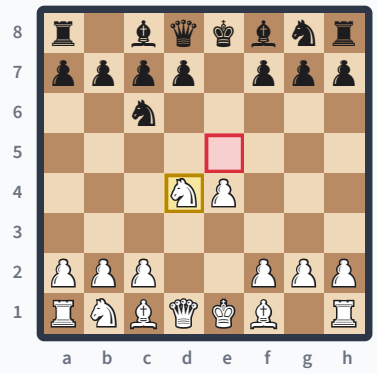
# THE SCOTCH GAME

1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 · Open the centre now

**Lesson 22 · Openings**
Level 3 Openings

## 1. The Break

3.D4

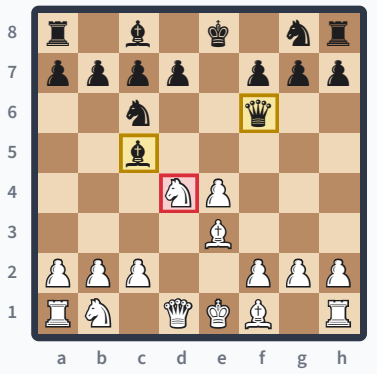


```
1.e4 e5 2.Nf3 Nc6 3.d4 exd4 4.Nxd4
```

- White opens the centre at once instead of the slow Italian build-up.
- The Knight on d4 is central but can be attacked.

## 2. Hit the Knight

4...BC5 5.BE3 QF6

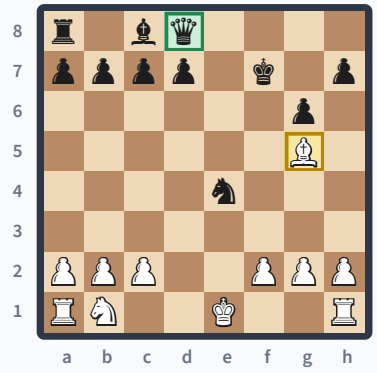


```
4...Bc5 5.Be3 Qf6
```

- Black attacks the d4-Knight three times.
- White defends calmly with c3 and develops. Don't panic.

## 3. Real Game: 13.Bxd8!

REAL GAME

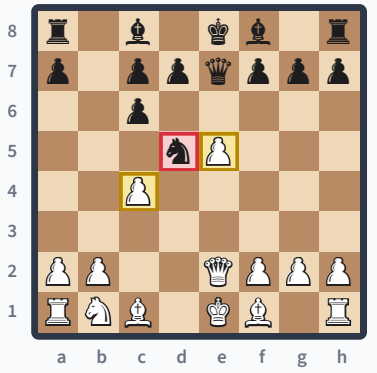


```
13.Bxd8 b6 14.Bxc7
```

- White to move in a real game.
- **13.Bxd8**! **13.Bxd8 b6 14.Bxc7 Ba6**, wins 10 points.
- White (1947) v Black (1958) · 9+8 · lichess.org/XizCcEC7

## 4. Space Grab

6.E5



```
4...Nf6 5.Nxc6 bxc6 6.e5 Qe7 7.Qe2 Nd5
8.c4
```

- White trades on c6 and chases the Knight with e5 and c4.
- Black gets doubled c-pawns but the half-open b-file.

## Scotch Game: Key Ideas

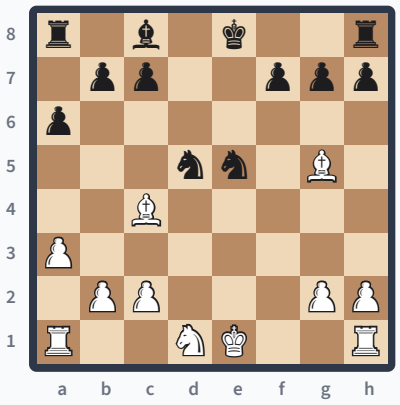
1. **Main idea:** White opens the centre at once instead of the slow Italian build-up.
2. **Watch for:** Plan: fast development, castle, and use your space. If Black plays ...Qh4 or ...Qf6, develop with tempo.
3. **In real games** (card 3): most points are lost to simple tactics in the opening. Check every capture!

# PUZZLES: SCOTCH GAME

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 22 · Openings Puzzles**
Level 3 Openings

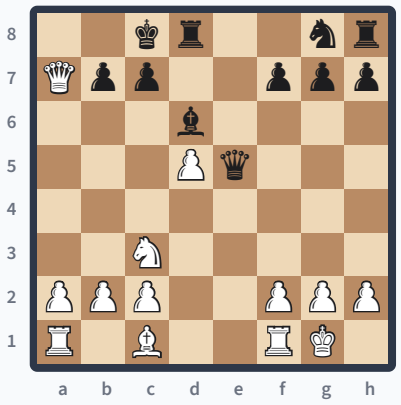
**1** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1565) v Black (1563) · 15+5
lichess.org/ehOlv8k8

Answer:

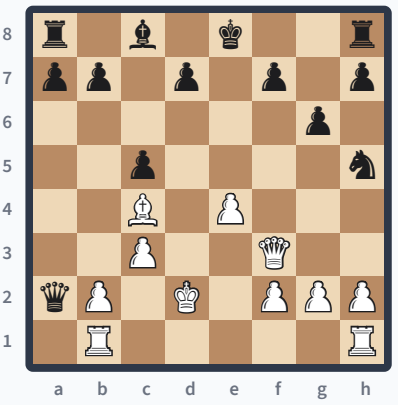
**2** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1208) v Black (1194) · 10+0
lichess.org/SWQcyk7q

Answer:

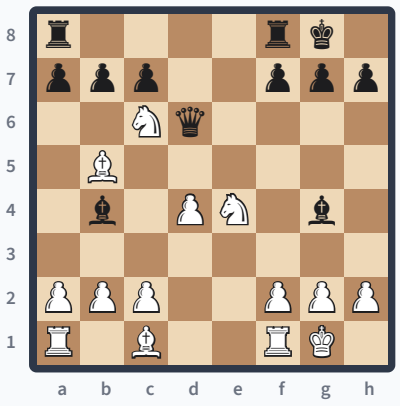
**3** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1765) v Black (1784) · 10+0
lichess.org/584UFtfW

Answer:

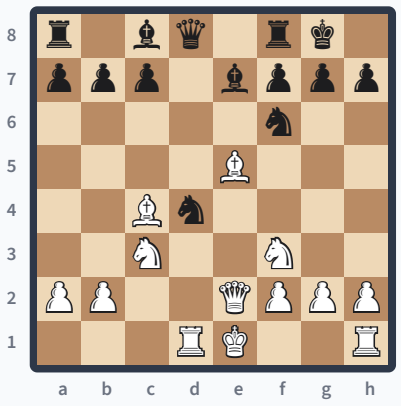
**4** **White to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1206) v Black (1163) · 10+0
lichess.org/T1f6mLqd

Answer:

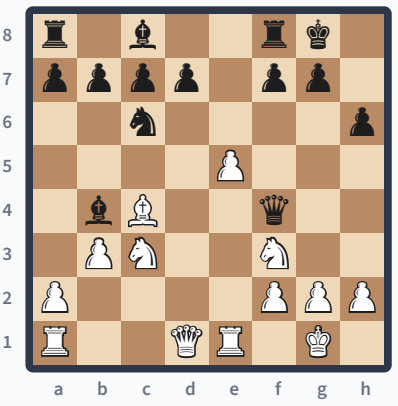
**5** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1267) v Black (1641) · 15+0
lichess.org/KFLvkNhL

Answer:

**6** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1429) v Black (1333) · 15+7
lichess.org/JkYN9sxq

Answer:

**Tip:** after every opening move, ask: what did that leave unguarded?

**Score: ____ / 6**

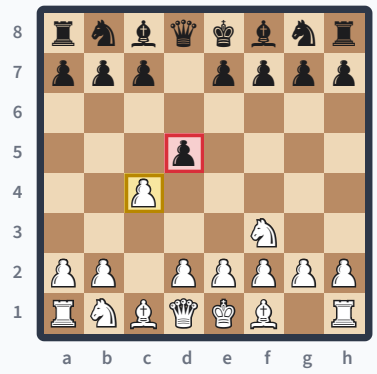
# THE RÉTI OPENING

1.Nf3 · Develop first, decide later

**Lesson 23 · Openings**
Level 3 Openings

## 1. Hit from the Side

2.C4

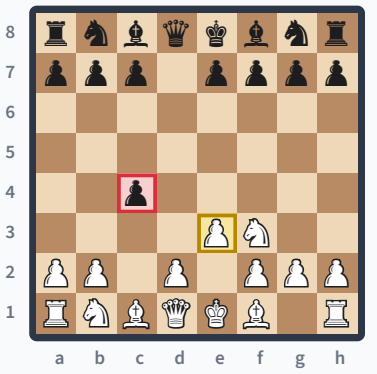


```
1.Nf3 d5 2.c4
```

- White attacks d5 with the c-pawn instead of occupying the centre.
- Flexible: it can turn into a Queen's Gambit or an English.

## 2. Win It Back

3.E3

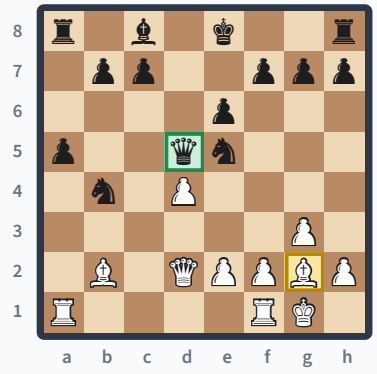


```
2...dxc4 3.e3
```

- If Black takes, 3.e3 and Bxc4 regain the pawn easily.
- White keeps a nice centre and fast development.

## 3. Real Game: 14.Bxd5!

REAL GAME

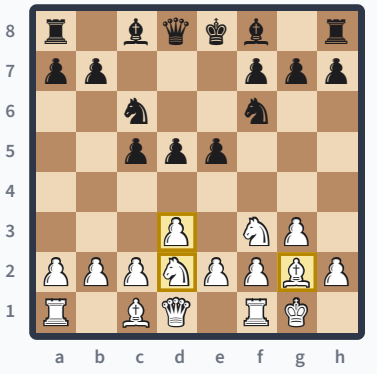


```
14.Bxd5 exd5 15.dxe5
```

- White to move in a real game.
- **14.Bxd5**! **14.Bxd5 exd5 15.dxe5 b6**, wins 9 points.
- White (1360) v Black (1362) · 10+0 · lichess.org/MbpgeF2I

## 4. King's Indian Attack

SAME SETUP, EVERY TIME



```
1.Nf3 d5 2.g3 Nf6 3.Bg2 c5 4.0-0 Nc6
5.d3 e5 6.Nbd2
```

- Fianchetto, castle, d3 and Nbd2, then e4 and a kingside attack.
- One setup against almost anything: like the London, but on the kingside.

## Réti Opening: Key Ideas

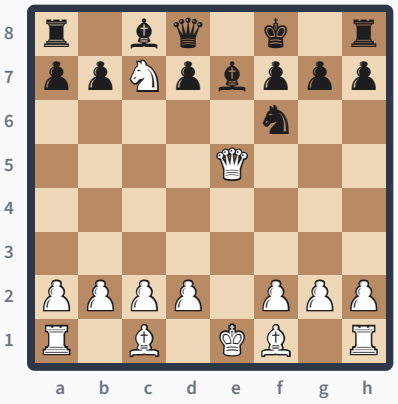
1. **Main idea:** White attacks d5 with the c-pawn instead of occupying the centre.
2. **Watch for:** Plan: develop, castle, then choose the centre: c4 against ...d5, e4 against closed setups.
3. **In real games** (card 3): most points are lost to simple tactics in the opening. Check every capture!

# PUZZLES: RÉTI OPENING

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 23 · Openings Puzzles**
Level 3 Openings

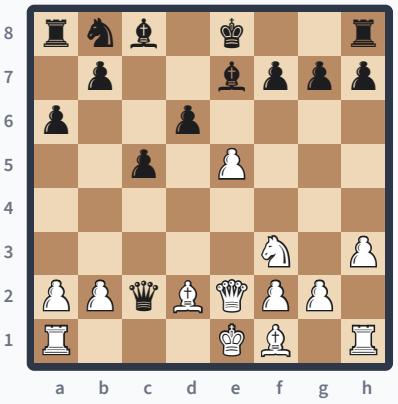
**1** **White to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (2087) v Black (2162) · 10+0
lichess.org/6qMKO7pP

Answer:

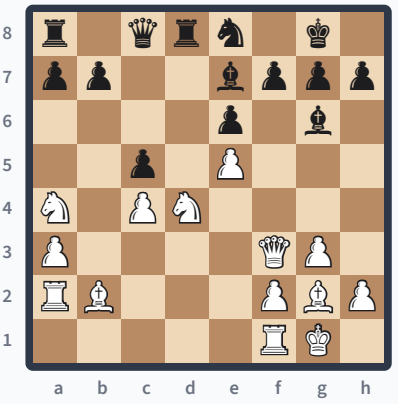
**2** **White to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1670) v Black (1432) · 60+5
lichess.org/JFYIw8LK

Answer:

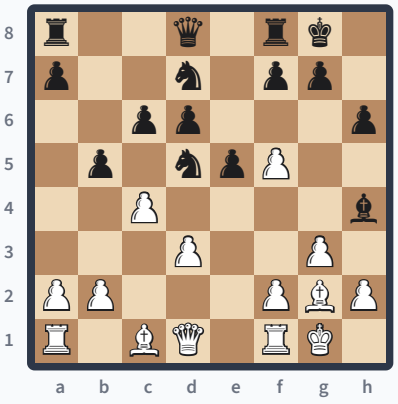
**3** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1572) v Black (1376) · 6+5
lichess.org/QrDl6KmE

Answer:

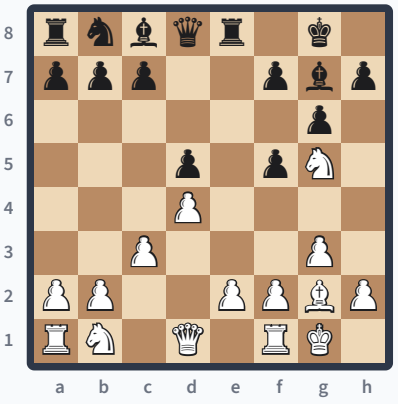
**4** **White to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1903) v Black (1887) · 10+0
lichess.org/xG5ck0mP

Answer:

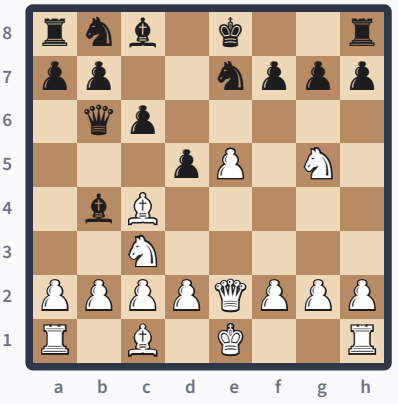
**5** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1205) v Black (1412) · 25+0
lichess.org/U2c6Ntqe

Answer:

**6** **White to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1299) v Black (1169) · 7+8
lichess.org/Mw2TrtJz

Answer:

**Tip:** after every opening move, ask: what did that leave unguarded?

**Score: ____ / 6**

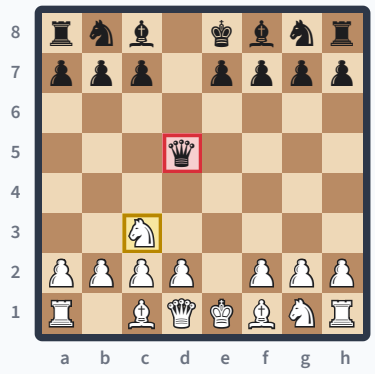
# THE SCANDINAVIAN DEFENCE

1.e4 d5 · Challenge the centre at once

**Lesson 24 · Openings**
Level 3 Openings

## 1. Queen Out Early

3.NC3 GAINS TIME

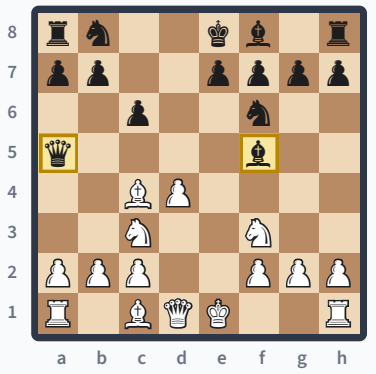


`1.e4 d5 2.exd5 Qxd5 3.Nc3`

- Black's Queen recaptures and gets chased: White develops with tempo.
- Black accepts this to get quick, simple development.

## 2. Safe Square: a5

3...QA5

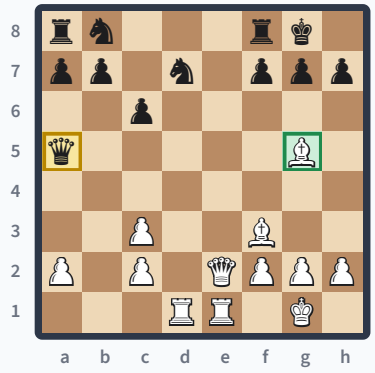


`3...Qa5 4.d4 Nf6 5.Nf3 c6 6.Bc4 Bf5`

- From a5 the Queen pins the c3-Knight and is hard to hit.
- Black plays ...c6, ...Bf5 and ...e6: a solid "Caro-Kann" shape.

## 3. Real Game: 14...Qxg5!

REAL GAME

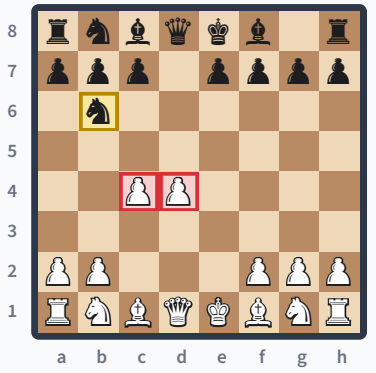


`14...Qxg5 15.Qe4 Nb6`

- Black to move in a real game.
- **14...Qxg5**! **14...Qxg5 15.Qe4 Nb6 16.h4**, wins 3 points.
- White (1412) v Black (1410) · 10+0 · lichess.org/lzJdapQf

## 4. 2...Nf6 Instead

KNIGHT TAKES BACK



`2...Nf6 3.d4 Nxd5 4.c4 Nb6`

- Black recaptures with the Knight, but White gains space with c4.
- Black then hits the centre with ...g6, ...Bg7 and ...c5.

## Scandinavian Defence: Key Ideas

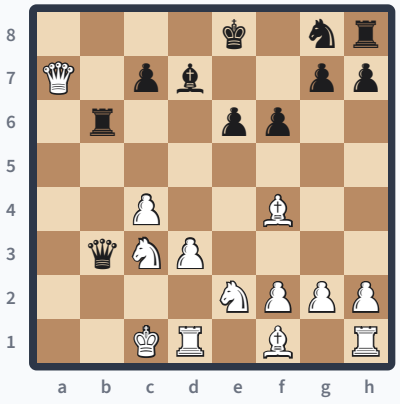
1. **Main idea:** Black's Queen recaptures and gets chased: White develops with tempo.
2. **Watch for:** For White: develop with tempo against the Queen and grab the centre with d4. For Black: Queen to a5 or d6, then develop fast.
3. **In real games** (card 3): most points are lost to simple tactics in the opening. Check every capture!

# PUZZLES: SCANDINAVIAN DEFENCE

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 24 · Openings Puzzles**
Level 3 Openings

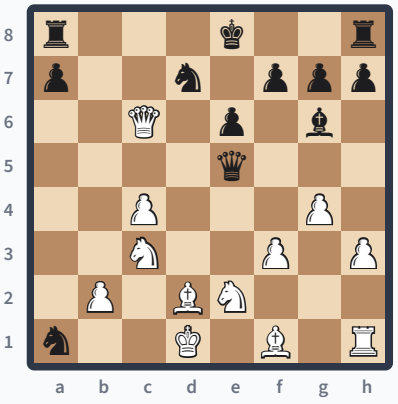
## 1 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1343) v Black (1328) · 8+0
lichess.org/3g5zl637

Answer:

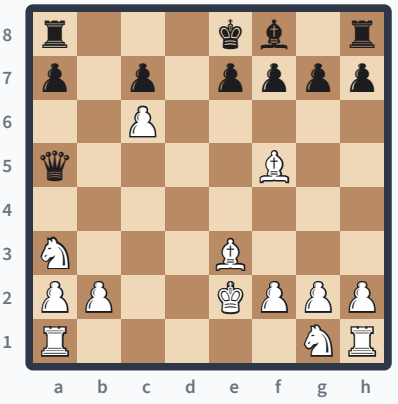
## 2 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1161) v Black (958) · 15+15
lichess.org/1nZFIHZq

Answer:

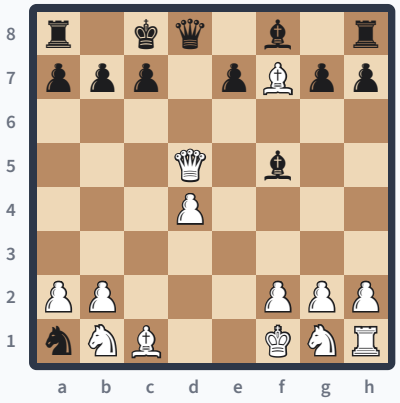
## 3 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1878) v Black (2062) · 10+0
lichess.org/vi8nJDK1

Answer:

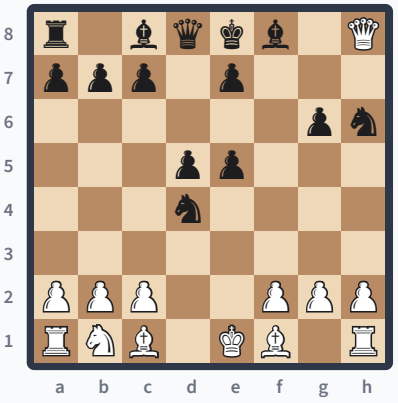
## 4 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1691) v Black (1622) · 15+10
lichess.org/iR66H8b3

Answer:

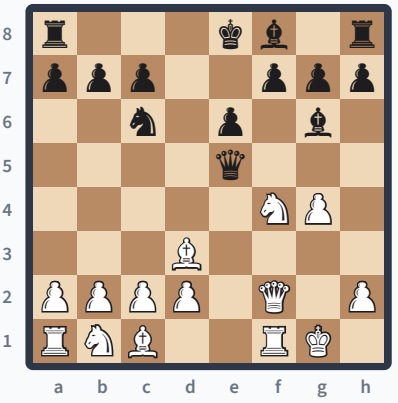
## 5 White to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1511) v Black (1614) · 11+0
lichess.org/ZgkgfcvW

Answer:

## 6 Black to move. Punish the mistake!



White (1299) v Black (1304) · 5+8
lichess.org/E4G2B8dY

Answer:

**Tip:** after every opening move, ask: what did that leave unguarded?

**Score: ____ / 6**

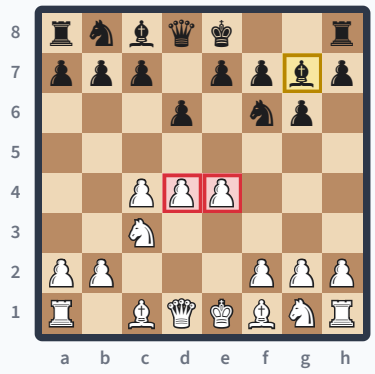
# THE KING'S INDIAN DEFENCE

1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 · Let White take the centre

**Lesson 25 · Openings**
Level 3 Openings

## 1. The Setup

...G6, ...BG7, ...D6

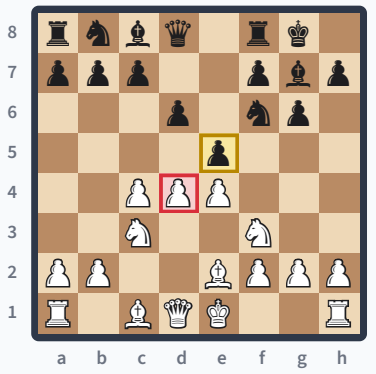


```
1.d4 Nf6 2.c4 g6 3.Nc3 Bg7 4.e4 d6
```

- Black fianchettoes and lets White build a big centre.
- Like the Modern Defence: the centre is a target, not a fortress.

## 2. Strike Back

5...O-O 6...E5

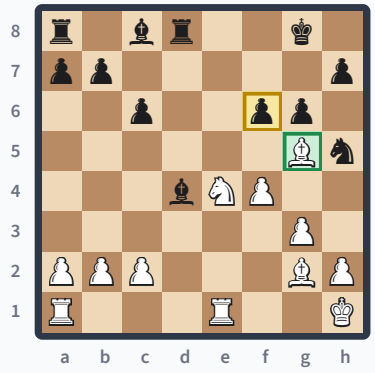


```
5.Nf3 O-O 6.Be2 e5
```

- Black castles and hits the centre with **...e5** (or ...c5).
- The g7-Bishop gets stronger the more the centre opens.

## 3. Real Game: 17...fxg5!

REAL GAME

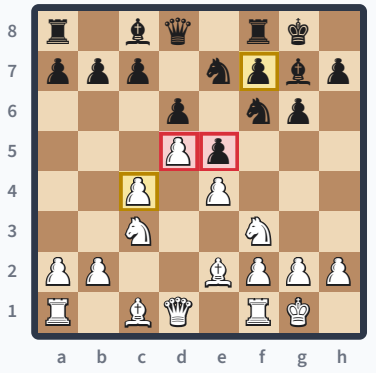


```
17...fxg5 18.fxg5 Bg7
```

- Black to move in a real game.
- **17...fxg5**! **17...fxg5 18.fxg5 Bg7 19.c3**, wins 2 points.
- White (1678) v Black (1839) · 10+0 · lichess.org/cWabwXyt

## 4. Closed Centre

OPPOSITE WINGS



```
7.O-O Nc6 8.d5 Ne7
```

- After d5 the centre locks. Now it's a race on the wings.
- Black attacks the King with ...f5; White attacks the queenside with c5.

## King's Indian Defence: Key Ideas

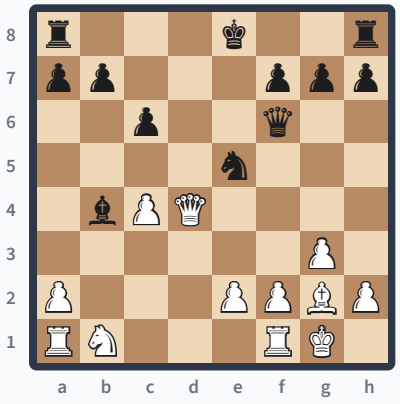
1. **Main idea:** Black fianchettoes and lets White build a big centre.
2. **Watch for:** Rule of thumb: attack on the side your pawn chain points to. Black's e5–d6 chain points to the kingside.
3. **In real games** (card 3): most points are lost to simple tactics in the opening. Check every capture!

# PUZZLES: KING'S INDIAN DEFENCE

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 25 · Openings Puzzles**
Level 3 Openings

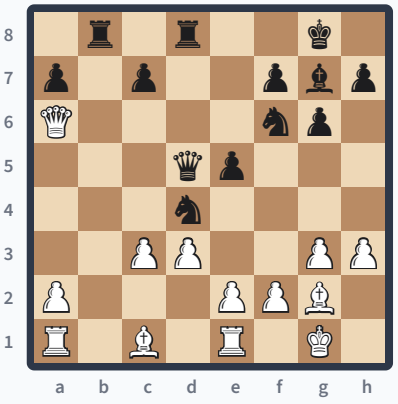
**1** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1970) v Black (1853) · 10+0
lichess.org/uB4u3dzQ

Answer:

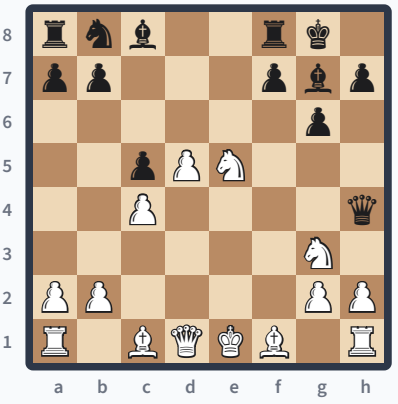
**2** **White to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1729) v Black (1012) · 10+5
lichess.org/TrKbsNxR

Answer:

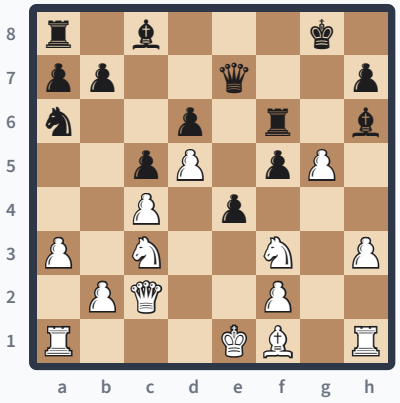
**3** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1716) v Black (1722) · 20+15
lichess.org/uPVmYmVk

Answer:

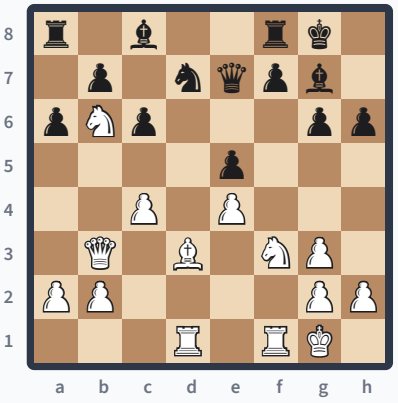
**4** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1994) v Black (2132) · 25+25
lichess.org/YOVKeMxP

Answer:

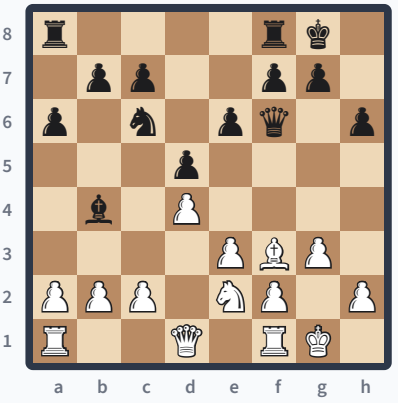
**5** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1862) v Black (1843) · 10+0
lichess.org/vW0j5ibe

Answer:

**6** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1494) v Black (1640) · 10+0
lichess.org/PgCQgXoQ

Answer:

**Tip:** after every opening move, ask: what did that leave unguarded?

**Score: ____ / 6**

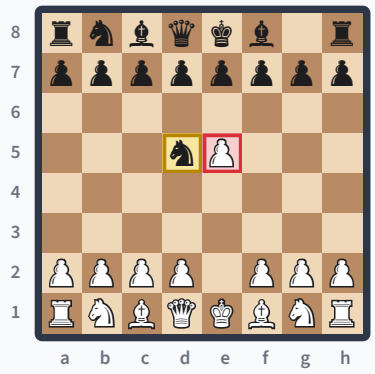
# ALEKHINE'S DEFENCE

1.e4 Nf6 · Invite the pawns, then attack them

**Lesson 26 · Openings**
Level 3 Openings

## 1. The Invitation

1...Nf6

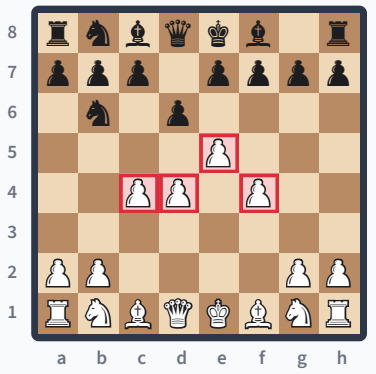


```
1.e4 Nf6 2.e5 Nd5
```

- Black attacks e4 at once and lets the pawn chase the Knight.
- The idea: White's advanced pawns become targets.

## 2. Four Pawns Attack

BIG CENTRE

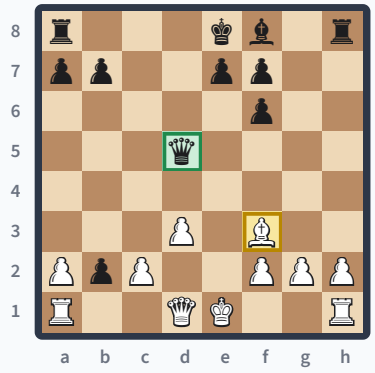


```
3.d4 d6 4.c4 Nb6 5.f4
```

- White builds a huge centre with four pawns.
- Black must hit it fast: ...dxe5, ...Bf5, ...Nc6 and ...c5.

## 3. Real Game: 14.Bxd5!

REAL GAME

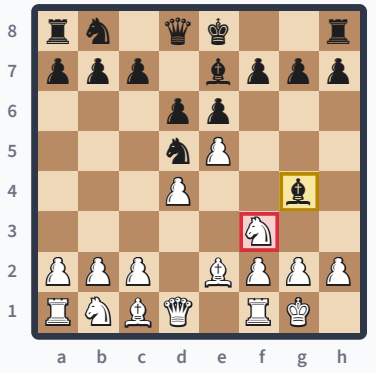


```
14.Bxd5 bxa1=Q 15.Qxa1
```

- White to move in a real game.
- **14.Bxd5**! **14.Bxd5 bxa1=Q 15.Qxa1 Bh6**, wins 5 points.
- White (1581) v Black (1493) · 10+0 · lichess.org/5iRRxP6f

## 4. Modern Variation

CALM AND SOLID



```
3.d4 d6 4.Nf3 Bg4 5.Be2 e6 6.O-O Be7
```

- White develops instead of pushing pawns: often the best approach.
- Black pins the Knight and prepares ...dxe5 or ...c5.

## Alekhine's Defence: Key Ideas

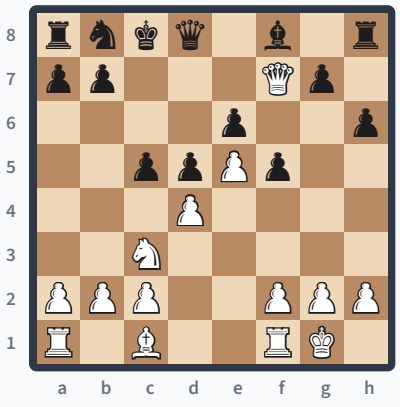
1. **Main idea:** Black attacks e4 at once and lets the pawn chase the Knight.
2. **Watch for:** For White: don't over-push; develop and keep the e5-pawn protected. For Black: attack the pawns before they get support.
3. **In real games** (card 3): most points are lost to simple tactics in the opening. Check every capture!

# PUZZLES: ALEKHINE'S DEFENCE

Six positions from real Lichess games

**Lesson 26 · Openings Puzzles**
Level 3 Openings

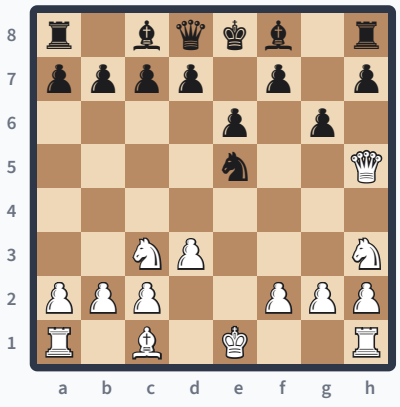
**1** **White to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1363) v Black (1251) · 10+0
lichess.org/rRQAxP3Q

Answer:

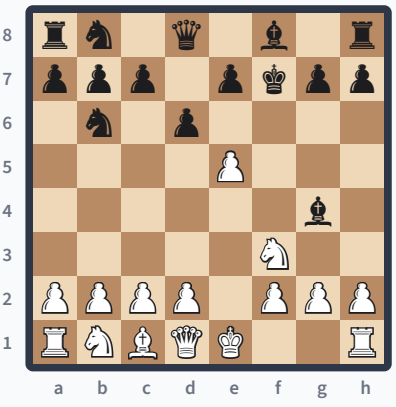
**2** **White to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1477) v Black (1203) · 8+5
lichess.org/8oiHoJm2

Answer:

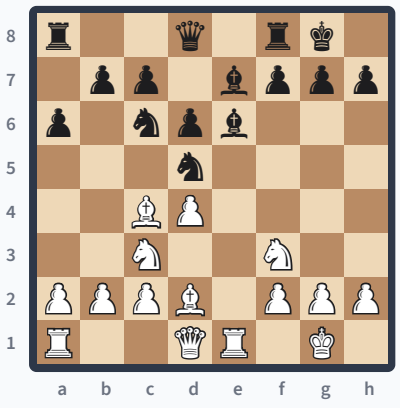
**3** **White to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1547) v Black (1555) · 5+8
lichess.org/e6ylqedC

Answer:

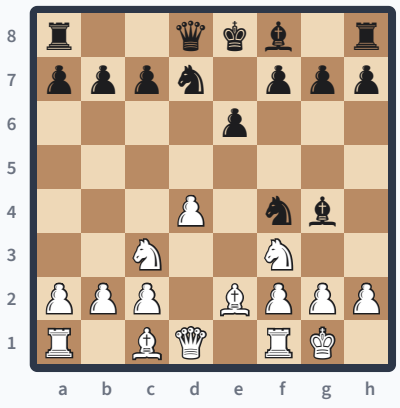
**4** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1748) v Black (1813) · 10+0
lichess.org/nIs1qsSn

Answer:

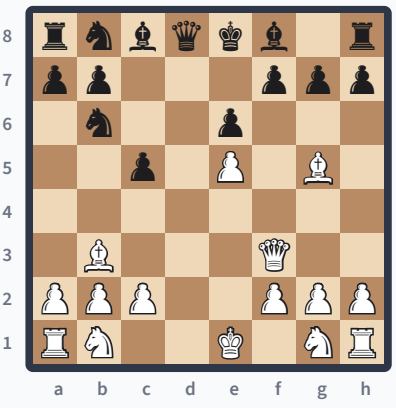
**5** **White to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1897) v Black (1303) · 10+0
lichess.org/5XmQAki6

Answer:

**6** **Black to move. Punish the mistake!**



White (1586) v Black (2133) · 8+0
lichess.org/j73xhBdO

Answer:

**Tip:** after every opening move, ask: what did that leave unguarded?

**Score: ____ / 6**

# SOLUTIONS

All puzzle answers · Each game link is printed under its puzzle

No peeking until you've tried!

## 1. Checks, Captures, Threats p. 2

1 21...Bb5 22.Rxd6 Qxd6, wins 2 points
2 15.Qxg4 Rxd2 16.Kxd2, wins 5 points
3 15.Bxb5+ axb5 16.Qxd4, wins 7 points
4 21...Bxc3 22.Bd2 Bxd2, wins 3 points
5 17...Nd3+ 18.Kf1 axb4, wins 3 points
6 4.Bxg7 d5 5.Bxh8, wins 6 points

## 2. Deflection p. 4

1 28...Bxd3 29.Rxd3 Rxe1+, wins 4 points
2 11.Qxc8+ Qd8 12.Qxb7, wins 4 points
3 20...Bg5 21.Qa7 Bxc1, wins 2 points
4 16...Bxh6 17.Qxh6 Qxe2, wins 3 points
5 12.Rxb6 Qxb6 13.Qxa8+, wins 3 points
6 15...Nxh3+ 16.gxh3 Rxf3, wins 3 points

## 3. Decoy p. 6

1 23...Qxe3 24.Qxe3 Rxe3, wins 3 points
2 34.Rh3 Qxh3 35.gxh3, wins 4 points
3 15.Ng5 Qxg5 16.Bxg5, wins 5 points
4 13...Bg5 14.Qxg5 hxg5, wins 6 points
5 11.Qxd5 Qxd5 12.Bxd5, wins 3 points
6 16.Qxg4 Qxg4 17.fxg4, wins 3 points

## 4. Zwischenzug p. 8

1 22.Nxd7 Qxd7 23.Rxa1, wins 3 points
2 22...Bxf3 23.gxf3 fxg6, wins 3 points
3 16.Bxd5+ Rf7 17.Qxe7, wins 8 points
4 22...Nxe4 23.Qe3 Rxf4, wins 4 points
5 12.fxg7 Rg8 13.Qxf1, wins 5 points
6 12.Bxe7 Qxe7 13.Bxe4, wins 3 points

## 5. X-ray p. 10

1 28...Qxd2+ 29.Rxd2 Rxd2+, wins 2 points
2 26.Qxb6 Bxb6 27.Bxb6, wins 3 points
3 28...Rxf1+ 29.Kg2 Rxf4, wins 3 points
4 31.Rxf3 Re1+ 32.Rf1, wins 3 points
5 29.Bxe4+ g6 30.Bg2, wins 3 points
6 26...Rxe6+ 27.Rxe6 Qxe6+, wins 9 points

## 6. Batteries p. 12

1 29...Qh2#, mate follows
2 18.Bxg4 Qc6 19.Kh1, wins 3 points
3 13...Qh2#, mate follows
4 12...Bxg5 13.Qe2 Bb7, wins 3 points
5 11...Qxh2#, mate follows
6 6.Qb5+ Bd7 7.Qxb7, wins 1 point

## 7. Greek Gift p. 14

1 17.Bxh7+ Kh8 18.Bf5+, mate follows
2 15...Bxh2+ 16.Kf1 Ne3+, wins 1 point
3 14.Bxh7+ Kxh7 15.Qxd5, wins 1 point
4 13...Bxh2+ 14.Kh1 Qxc4, wins 4 points
5 15.Bxh7+ Kf8 16.Bf5, wins 1 point
6 11.Bxh7+ Kh8 12.Ng5, wins 1 point

## 8. Opposite-Side Castling p. 16

1 21...h4 22.Bxg7 Qxg7, wins 2 points
2 20...c6 21.Bb3 Nxb3+
3 19.h3 Qf4 20.g3
4 23...f6 24.Bh2 Rh7
5 16...Bg4 17.Qe4 Bxd1, wins 2 points
6 16.e5 fxe5 17.Nxe5

## 9. Prophylaxis p. 18

1 20...Ng5 21.d4 exd4
2 23.Qe5 Kd7 24.Be8+
3 19...g6 20.d6 Bxe4
4 22.Qh4 Rd2 23.g4
5 12.Bb5 Bxh1 13.Bxc6+
6 7.Bb5 Bxb5 8.Qxb5+

## 10. Defending Worse Positions p. 20

1 19...Bxe2 20.Qxe2 hxg5
2 26...Rxc7 27.e5 dxe5
3 17.g4 fxg3 18.Nxg3
4 16.Qd2 Re8 17.a3
5 10.Rxd1 Nfd7 11.e6
6 12.Qg4 Bf6 13.c3

## 11. Open & Closed Positions p. 22

1 Closed: locked pawns d4/d5, e5/e6. Knights
2 Open: only 2 centre pawns. Bishops
3 Closed: locked pawns e3/e4, f4/f5. Knights
4 Closed: locked pawns f2/f3, c4/c5, d5/d6. Knights
5 Open: only 2 centre pawns. Bishops
6 Open: only 2 centre pawns. Bishops

## 12. Good & Bad Bishops p. 24

1 Good: only 1 of White's 7 pawns are on dark squares
2 Good: only 1 of Black's 6 pawns are on dark squares
3 Bad: 6 of White's 7 pawns are on dark squares (h2, a3, c3, b4, d4, e5)
4 Bad: 5 of White's 7 pawns are on dark squares (b2, f2, d4, h4, e5)
5 Bad: 6 of White's 7 pawns are on light squares (a2, h3, c4, e4, g4, d5)
6 Bad: 5 of Black's 7 pawns are on light squares (b5, d5, f5, e6, h7)

## 13. Outposts p. 26

1 18.Nf5 Kh8 19.Nxd6
2 20...Ne4+ 21.Ke2 Qh5+
3 11...Ne4 12.Nxe4 dxe4
4 14...Nf3+ 15.Kf1 c6
5 21...Nc4 22.Kd1 O-O
6 14.Nd6+ Kf8 15.Bg5

## 14. Open Files & the 7th Rank p. 28

1 24...Rd8 25.Rb1 Rd4
2 30...Qf5+ 31.Nf3 Kf7
3 21...Rhf8 22.Rab1 b3
4 22...Re2 23.Qd1 Rxa2
5 17...Qc5 18.Ra4 Nxb5
6 9.Re1 Qh4 10.Rxe4

## 15. Pawn Majorities p. 30

1 Queenside W3–B2, kingside W2–B4: White has the queenside majority, Black the kingside
2 Queenside W1–B4, kingside W3–B1: Black has the queenside majority, White the kingside
3 Queenside W2–B3, kingside W3–B2: Black has the queenside majority, White the kingside
4 Queenside W2–B3, kingside W3–B2: Black has the queenside majority, White the kingside
5 Queenside W3–B2, kingside W1–B3: White has the queenside majority, Black the kingside
6 Queenside W3–B4, kingside W4–B2: Black has the queenside majority, White the kingside

## 16. Converting an Advantage p. 32

1 19.e4 Nf6 20.Rxd7, wins 4 points
2 19...Qxe4 20.dxe4 Rxf4, wins 3 points
3 13.Qxg4 d5 14.g3, wins 3 points
4 16...Na5 17.Qa4 Nxc4, wins 2 points
5 13...bxc3 14.f5 Qd7, wins 3 points
6 11...dxc3 12.Bxc3 Qxc5, wins 3 points

## 17. Simplification p. 34

1 29...Qxe7 30.Rxe7 Kxe7
2 18.Bxd1 Bb4 19.Bd2
3 30.Qxh1 Rxh1+ 31.Kxh1
4 21...Nxd1 22.Qxd1 Qd8
5 19...Nxe2 20.Qxe2 Qxc3
6 13...Bxd5 14.exd7+ Qxd7

## 18. Rook Endgames p. 36

1 46.Rxf7 g5 47.b4: holds the draw
2 36...b3 37.Rd7+ Ke6: wins
3 58.Kxb7 e4 59.Re8: wins
4 54...Kf6 55.Rh6+ Ke7: holds the draw
5 35...Rd2+ 36.Kg1 Rd1+: holds the draw
6 59.Rf8 c2 60.Rf2: limits the damage

## 19. Opposition & Key Squares p. 38

1 62.Kf3 Kh4 63.Kxf4: holds the draw
2 81.Kf7 Kh6 82.g8=Q: wins
3 65...Kg7 66.Kg4 Kg6: holds the draw
4 69.Kh6 Kf8 70.g4: wins
5 55...Kf3 56.Kg1 g2: wins
6 63.Kg5 Kd5 64.Kxf5: wins

## 20. King's Gambit p. 40

1 15...Bxd3+ 16.Kxd3 Ne7, wins 6 points
2 11.Bxg4+ Kb8 12.Nxc6+, wins 6 points
3 15.dxe6 fxe6 16.h3, wins 2 points
4 9...Qxg4 10.d4 Qxe4+, wins 11 points
5 9.Re1 Bf5 10.Bxf4, wins 1 point
6 12.Bxd7+ Kb8 13.Qe8, wins 3 points

## 21. Queen's Gambit p. 42

1 12...Bb4 13.Ne5 Bxc3+, wins 6 points
2 17.Nxd6 Qe7 18.Ndxf7, wins 4 points
3 10...Qxc4 11.Rfd1 Bd6, wins 3 points
4 12.Qxe4 c5 13.d5, wins 3 points
5 10.Bxg6 hxg6 11.Qe2, wins 6 points
6 17.Rxb8+ Kd7 18.Rab1, wins 3 points

## 22. Scotch Game p. 44

1 14...Nxc4 15.b3 Ne5, wins 3 points
2 13...Qxh2#, mate follows
3 15...Qxc4 16.g4 Ng7, wins 3 points
4 11.Nxd6 bxc6 12.Bxc6, wins 6 points
5 11...Nxe2 12.Rxd8 Rxd8, wins 2 points
6 12...Bxc3 13.g3 Qg4, wins 3 points

## 23. Réti Opening p. 46

1 9.Nxa8 d6 10.Qb5, wins 5 points
2 14.exd6 Nc6 15.dxe7, wins 3 points
3 17...cxd4 18.Qb3 Rb8, wins 3 points
4 15.cxd5 Bf6 16.dxc6, wins 4 points
5 9...Qxg5 10.Bxd5 Qe7, wins 2 points
6 11.exd6 Bxd6 12.Nxf7, wins 1 point

## 24. Scandinavian Defence p. 48

1 17...Qb2#, mate follows
2 17.Qxa8+ Ke7 18.Qxh8, wins 10 points
3 13...Qxf5 14.Nf3 e5, wins 3 points
4 11.Qxf5+ Kb8 12.Nf3, wins 3 points
5 9.Bxh6 Nxc2+ 10.Kd2, wins 2 points
6 12...Bc5 13.Be4 Bxe4, wins 3 points

## 25. King's Indian Defence p. 50

1 13...Nf3+ 14.exf3 Qxd4, wins 6 points
2 16.Bxd5 Nxd5 17.cxd4, wins 9 points
3 11...Bxe5 12.Qf3 Bg4, wins 3 points
4 17...exf3+ 18.Be2 Bxg5, wins 4 points
5 16...Qc5+ 17.Kh1 Qxb6, wins 3 points
6 13...Qxf3 14.Rc1 Bd6, wins 3 points

## 26. Alekhine's Defence p. 52

1 14.Qxe6+ Qd7 15.Qg6, wins 1 point
2 11.Qxe5 f6 12.Qg3, wins 3 points
3 7.Ng5+ Ke8 8.Qxg4, wins 3 points
4 10...Nxc3 11.Bxc3 Bxc4, wins 3 points
5 8.Bxf4 Bd6 9.Bg3, wins 3 points
6 8...Qxg5 9.Nd2 Qxe5+, wins 4 points